THE BOOK OF

CONTEMPLATION

Mount Qaf Companion Handbook
Second Edition

Suluk Global 2025–2027 · Inayatiyya

Kabir · Class of Mount Qaf

Two Retreats
Part I — The Spring Retreat (CT1–CT6)
Part II — The Easter Retreat (CT7–CT10)
Taught by Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

Pod Mentor: Farzana

March – April 2026

226 Teachings · 18 Chapters · 2 Retreats · 10 Sessions

Bismillah ir-Rahman ir-Rahim

In the Name of God, the All-Compassionate, the All-Merciful.

Dedicated to the lineage of teachers through whom the spirit of guidance has shone forth — Hazrat Inayat Khan, Pir Vilayat Inayat Khan, and Pir Zia Inayat-Khan — and to all who turn the heart toward the One.

Toward the One

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INTRODUCTION

Contemplation is the second stage of the Suluk — the spiritual journey of the Inayatiyya. Where Concentration gathered the scattered beam of attention into a single point, Contemplation turns that single point toward the Divine and holds it there. It is the long, patient gaze of the heart upon the One Reality, until the veil between the seer and the Seen becomes thin enough to let the light of that Reality shine through.

This handbook is organized in two parts, one for each retreat weekend of Contemplation Section I. All ten classes (CT1–CT10) were taught by Pir Zia Inayat-Khan:

Part I — The Spring Retreat (CT1–CT6, March 27–29, 2026) opens the Contemplation year with the foundational prayers, purification breaths, and the first movements into mushahada — the witnessing gaze that is the keynote of contemplation.

Part II — The Easter Retreat (CT7–CT10, April 18–19, 2026) deepens the arc with extended Fikr and Zikr, contemplation on the Divine Names, and the subtler practices through which the heart learns to rest in the Presence.

The handbook contains 226 teachings extracted from class transcripts, organized into 18 topic chapters across the two retreats. Within each retreat, chapters are organized by topic — Prayers, Breath, Fikr and Zikr, Wazifa, Contemplation Practices, Teachings, Stories, and more — so you can always find a teaching by subject while keeping the temporal arc of each retreat intact.

"Contemplation is the gaze of the heart upon the One Reality."

— Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

May this handbook serve as a living reference — not a museum of words, but a doorway back into the practices and states from which they arose. Return to it often. The teachings deepen with every reading.

PART I

THE SPRING RETREAT

Contemplation · March 27–29, 2026 · CT1–CT6

Pir Zia Inayat-Khan is the spiritual leader of the Inayatiyya and grandson of Hazrat Inayat Khan. He taught Section I of the Contemplation program (CT1–CT10) across two retreat weekends: the Spring Retreat of March 27–29, 2026 (CT1–CT6) and the Easter Retreat of April 18–19, 2026 (CT7–CT10).

Friday, March 27, 2026 (CT1, CT2)
Saturday, March 28, 2026 (CT3, CT4)
Sunday, March 29, 2026 (CT5, CT6)

149 Teachings · 9 Chapters

Part I · Chapter 1

PRAYERS & INVOCATIONS

The Sacred Words That Open the Way

Contemplation opens, as the Suluk opens, with prayer. Pir Zia taught the foundational invocations of the Inayatiyya — the Opening Invocation, Saum, Salat, Salawat, and the prayers of the lineage — as the living liturgy within which every contemplation is framed.

22 Entries · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

The Invocation — Opening of Contemplation

Source: CT1 · March 27, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

"Toward the One, the perfection of love, harmony and beauty, the only being, united with all of the illuminated souls who form the embodiment of the messenger, the spirit of guidance."

The Invocation opens the first session of the Contemplation series, marking the formal transition from the completed Book of Concentration into the new stage of the Suluk journey. It is the first act of contemplative practice — gathering scattered attention into unified intention.

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Creating the Realm of Sanctuary (Dar al-Aman)

Source: CT1 · March 27, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

HUMANITY IS ONE FAMILY

In a world marked by polarization, militarism, and suffering, we remember our profound interconnection.

"All of us have family living in danger because humanity is one family. We're all interrelated."

"And what happens to the least protected, the most aggressed against, happens really to all of us."

CREATING SANCTUARY

We cannot control what happens throughout the world, but we can embody kindredness and create a space of refuge--a sanctuary.

"We can create sanctuary amongst those we know, those we meet through the attitude of Aman."

"Aman isn't just something that arises outside. It arises outside because it begins in the interior life."

BUILDING THE INNER TEMPLE

"Our intention is to create the Dar al-Aman, the realm of sanctuary, beginning in our own hearts."

"We do this through the consideration that we have for all of God's creatures... the consideration that we show to each other... and the intention to make every thought, every word and every action a a stone in that temple of sanctuary that we're building."

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The Inayati Opening Prayer

Source: CT1 · March 27, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

In the Inayatiyya, we initiate our sacred gatherings with a profound invocation, a calling forth of the divine presence and the stream of spiritual wisdom. This prayer, steeped in tradition, sets the essential tone for our shared contemplation and practice. It reminds us of our ultimate destination and our connection to a lineage of enlightened understanding. We begin by reciting: *"Toward the one, the perfection of love, harmony, and beauty. The only being, united with all of the illuminated souls who form the embodiment of the messenger, the spirit of guidance."* This declaration is a compass for our hearts, orienting us towards the singular source of all existence—the perfection of love, harmony, and beauty—and uniting us with the continuous spiritual guidance embodied by the messengers of truth.

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The Practice of Ittisal: Conjunction with Universal Being

Source: CT2 · March 27, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

The practice of *Ittisal* is an awakening to our inherent rapport with the vaster body, mind, and soul of existence.

THE UNIVERSAL BEING

"Ittisal is a word that means conjunction. And specifically, what we have in mind is conjunction with the universal being, which is to say the being of the universe."

The universe has both inner and outer dimensions, which Murshid speaks of as the *"spirit of guidance."*

"The physical cosmos, you could say, is the body of the universal being."

"Not only are our bodies part of a vaster body, which is the universal body, also our minds are a portion of the universal mind... And not only of consciousness, but of pure intelligence. So beyond the mind of the universe, there is a soul of the universe."

BREATHING WITH THE UNIVERSE

When we connect to this total being, we are no longer limited to our personal senses. Our individual mind is embedded within a larger mind.

"When we tap into this larger body, mind, soul, we are nourished, we are guided, we are inspired. We're shown things that our personal senses don't perceive."

"The more that we breathe with the universe as a cell within that larger body, the more that we become connected with life itself, the more we are guided and and the more that we're able to contribute to the the coherence of the anatomy that is unfolding itself around us."

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Energizing Ittisal with the Intonation of 'Ha'

Source: CT2 · March 27, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

Ittisal—conjunction—is a practice of awakening our rapport with the vaster body, mind, and soul of the universe. This realization can be energized in the body through a series of intonations, the first of which is the syllable *"Ha."*

THE PRACTICE

1. Intone the syllable *"Ha."*
2. *"The way that Ha works is that it… rises up from the coccyx, from the the tailbone, right up into the chest. And you feel its culmination in in the chest."*
3. Feel through the sound how your physical and subtle bodies are embedded within the universe *"as a kind of eddy, a whirlpool of the cosmic matter."*

THE REALIZATION: LITTLE BODY, GREAT BODY

This practice cultivates a profound shift in perspective. We are a vortex of the cosmic substance, constantly exchanging matter and energy with the whole.

"You feel that… when you sense that this physical body is your little body, and that you also have a great body, which is equally yours."

"Normally we think, well, this body is mine and I live in the universe. But you could equally say, this is my little body and the universe is my great body."

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Al-Abd al-Kulli: The Universal Servant

Source: CT2 · March 27, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

THE PRIMAL DEVOTEE

"One name is Al-Abd al-Kulli, the universal servant or worshiper of God, which is a wonderful way of conceiving it, that the sum total of all creatures constitutes a primal devotee of the infinite."

AN ENTITY OF WORSHIP AND WITNESS

"This whole world, all the way out to its farthest shores, constitutes an entity who exists for the worship and witnessing of the divine being."

OUR HOLOGRAPHIC PART

"And we are, each of us, a holographic fraction of that universal totality."

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The 'Ha' Intonation as a Bija Mantra

Source: CT2 · March 27, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

BIJA MANTRAS — ESSENTIAL SOUNDS

The syllable *Ha* is not a word, but an essential sound that resonates in a particular place in the body.

"In the Indic tradition, you would speak of bija mantras. They aren't even words, they're just essential sounds, and they resonate in particular places in the body."

THE PRACTICE OF HA

"The way that Ha works is that it rises up from the coccyx, from the the tailbone, right up into the chest."

"And you feel its culmination in in the chest, that ah sound that really vibrates in in the chest."

FEELING YOUR PLACE IN THE UNIVERSE

"You're feeling through that sound the way in which your physical body and also your subtle etheric body are embedded within the physical and etheric dimensions of the universe as a kind of eddy, a whirlpool of the cosmic matter."

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The Vigilant Practice of Muraqaba

Source: CT3 · March 28, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

The practice of contemplation, or Muraqaba, is deeply connected to a divine name.

"Muraqabah is related to the word Raqib, which is a name of God, the vigilant, the watchful."

"When we practice Muraqabah, we are participating in this divine quality. It's a quality that already pervades existence. Attentive, watchful care."

This is an invitation to shift from a state of sleepwalking to one of profound wakefulness. The practice asks:

"What would it be like not merely to stumble through life, not merely to sleepwalk, but to take every step wakefully, vigilantly?"

THE CONTEMPLATION OF RESPECT (I'TIBAR)

Another word for contemplation is *I'tibar*, which also means respect. This connection is key to the practice.

"Contemplation means that we don't take anything for granted. We see deeply into everyone and everything. We recognize its source."

It is a commitment to engage with the world with a new level of seriousness and presence, recognizing the divine signs in all that we encounter.

"Nothing is just an object, nothing is just a reflective surface. Everything has depth, everything has infinite depth. And there is a meaning, in fact a host of meanings to be discovered in everything we encounter. Nothing is negligible."

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I'tibar: Contemplation as an Act of Respect

Source: CT3 · March 28, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

CONTEMPLATION IS RESPECT

"There's another word that also refers to contemplation, I'tibar... it also means respect--paying respect to something is I'tibar, the same word which means contemplation."

"So contemplation means that we don't take anything for granted. We see deeply into everyone and everything. We recognize its source. Nothing is just an object, nothing is just a reflective surface. Everything has depth, everything has infinite depth."

CROSSING OVER INTO DEPTH

The meaning of I'tibar is deepened by its linguistic root, *'abara*, which implies a movement from the surface into the heart of a thing.

"The word is related to 'abara, which means to cross, like to cross a river, to wade across a river or even to swim across. Crossing over, wading through."

"Whatever you meet with in waking life or in a dream, you wouldn't just meet it as something confronting you. You wouldn't only regard its surface. You'd find a way into it, through it."

This crossing-over transforms our relationship with the world. *"There's a porousness to all things and in I'tibar we become*

porous, we become vaporous, we move through each other. Objects become subjects, subjects not only meet but pass through each other, wade into each other."

THE EMERGENCE OF MEANING

This respectful passage into depth is how we discover the inner significance, or *'ibara*--*"meaning"*--which comes from the same root.

"Meaning comes when there's respect, there is a movement through and across into the depth, and there is an interpretation... we don't only see the obvious in everything, we adduce meaning that is implied, that's evoked."

"In the encounter there's a movement of spirit toward the depth, from the outer evidence to the inner meaning to the name, the divine name."

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Ta'bir: The Interpretation of Dreams

Source: CT3 · March 28, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

"A related word is Ta'bir. It comes from the same root [as I'tibar] and it means interpretation, for instance the interpretation of dreams."

"You might see something in a dream and when you wake up, when you wake, you just jump out of bed and completely forget what happened in the night."

THE CONTEMPLATIVE APPROACH

To practice *Ta'bir*, or dream interpretation, is to be watchful and vigilant upon waking.

"If you're watchful, if you're vigilant, you'll slowly emerge out of sleep and recollect everything that you experienced, as much as you can recall."

"And if you have I'tibar, then you not only remember there was this incident and this person appeared, but you sense behind the narrative a meaning, a signification, things are hinted at that you are meant to know, but you have to linger over it."

A PERSONAL KNOWLEDGE

While dream dictionaries exist, the meaning of a dream is ultimately a personal experience that cannot be found externally.

"One symbol doesn't mean the same thing for every dreamer. Yes, we share cultures and so symbols have similar resonances, but the interpretation of a dream is always going to be a very personal experience."

"And someone could help you to find the meaning of the dream, but really they're just helping you to identify the knowledge that is already your own."

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The Personal Nature of Dream Interpretation

Source: CT3 · March 28, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

THE LIMITS OF DICTIONARIES

While dream dictionaries exist, the meaning of a symbol is never fixed. It is a deeply personal and contextual experience, rooted in the individual.

"Ibn Sirin wrote a dream dictionary, but one symbol doesn't mean the same thing for every dreamer. Yes, we share cultures and so symbols have similar resonances, but the interpretation of a dream is always going to be a very personal experience."

THE KNOWLEDGE WITHIN

An interpreter can act as a guide, but their role is to help the dreamer access the knowledge that is already present within their own being.

"Someone could help you to find the meaning of the dream, but really they're just helping you to identify the knowledge that is already your own."

"And this knowledge is obtained through contemplation, through I'tibar, through going deeper than the surface."

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The Opening Invocation

Source: CT3 · March 28, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

We begin our practice of contemplation by turning our hearts and minds to the Divine Source. In this sacred endeavor, we offer ourselves to the boundless reality that encompasses all existence, a reality described by the invocation: *"Toward the One, the perfection of love, harmony, and beauty, the only being, united with all the illuminated souls, who form the embodiment of the messenger, the spirit of guidance."* This invocation guides us to remember that contemplation is an active participation in the divine quality of attentiveness and watchful care. It is a journey of seeing deeply into everyone and everything, recognizing the divine presence within, and ultimately, understanding that our purpose is to witness and embody these very qualities, bringing meaning and light into our lives.

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The Spiritual Rhythm of Opening, Bestowal, and Patience

Source: CT4 · March 28, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

"These three divine names form a sequence that describes a profound spiritual process. Ya Fattah is the Opener, the one who removes obstacles and opens the way. Ya Wahhab is the Bestower, the Giver of gifts, the one who bestows grace without measure. And Ya Sabur is the Patient, the one who is steadfast and endures."

THE FOUNDATION: YA SABUR (THE PATIENT)

The foundation of this entire process is patience. *"We must cultivate patience as we wait for the opening and the subsequent bestowal."*

This is not a passive waiting, but an active and intentional state of being.

"This is not a passive or resigned waiting, but an active, vibrant steadfastness. It is the quality of endurance, of holding firm in our intention and our practice, even when we see no immediate results. In practicing with Ya Sabur, we align ourselves with the timeless, patient nature of the Divine itself."

THE PRAYER: YA FATTAH (THE OPENER)

"When we call upon Ya Fattah, we are acknowledging that the opening we seek is not something we can engineer through our own will."

When we feel constricted or blocked, this is a prayer for divine intervention.

"It is like a flower bud that cannot force itself to bloom; it must wait for the sun to coax its petals open. We turn to the Opener, trusting that in the right time, the way will be made clear."

THE GRACE: YA WAHHAB (THE BESTOWER)

"Following the opening is the bestowal, Ya Wahhab. Once the channel is cleared by Fattah, the grace of Wahhab can flow."

This bestowal is a gift that is both precisely what is needed and entirely unearned.

"This is the divine gift, the Fazl of God, which is unearned and unconditional. It is the answer to the heart's deepest longing, the nourishment that the soul requires for its journey."

THE RHYTHM OF SPIRITUAL LIFE

The sequence is one of profound trust and surrender.

"We hold our ground with patience, Ya Sabur. We pray for an opening from the Opener, Ya Fattah. And we open our hands and our hearts to receive the gift from the Bestower, Ya Wahhab."

"This is the rhythm of the spiritual life: a patient waiting, a sudden opening, and a generous outpouring of grace. It is a process that unfolds according to a wisdom that is beyond our comprehension."

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Gratitude for Constriction: Deepening Spiritual Roots

Source: CT4 · March 28, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

FOR OPENING AND FOR WAITING

"Let us cultivate gratitude not only for the moments of opening and bestowal but also for the periods of waiting and patient endurance."

THE PURPOSE OF DIFFICULTY

"The times of constriction and difficulty are not a sign of divine displeasure; they are an essential part of the process."

"They are the times when our spiritual roots grow deeper, and our capacity to receive the gift is expanded."

FROM THE ONE BELOVED

"Both the light and the dark, the expansion and the contraction, are from the one Beloved."

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A Closing Prayer for Opening, Grace, and Patience

Source: CT4 · March 28, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

We practice with the Wazifa, Ya Fattah, Ya Wahhab, Ya Sabur, which describes a profound spiritual process—a rhythm of patient waiting, sudden opening, and generous outpouring of grace. In concluding our practice, we offer a prayer, giving thanks for the opportunity to sit in remembrance and for whatever has been received, seen or unseen, as we ask: *"May the Opener open our hearts. May the Bestower fill them with His love. And may the Patient One grant us the steadfastness to remain on this path until we reach our true home in Him."* This prayer encapsulates our profound trust and surrender, aligning our will with the Divine as we patiently await the unveiling of truth and the ultimate journey home in Him.

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The Swing of Breath: Rising Above Birth and Death

Source: CT5 · March 29, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

A foundational practice of Fikr, or remembrance, that uses the natural rhythm of the breath as a vehicle for spiritual ascent. The process begins by simply watching the breath as it moves.

"As the breath goes out far and comes in deep, the effect is that of a swing, going out, falling back, going out, falling back."

THE PRACTICE

"And in Fikr we place a phrase on the swing."

1. **On the Inhale,** inwardly say: "**I rise above birth and death.**"
2. **On the Exhale,** inwardly say: "**through the waves of the air.**"
3. Continue this cycle for several breaths.
4. *"We not only inwardly say these words, we live them."* Feel the sensation of floating, gliding, and soaring.

INTEGRATION

After some time, *"let the words fade away, but stay in the experience of floating on waves, rising above birth and death."*

The practice culminates in a state of dual awareness—maintaining the experience of being beyond birth and death while simultaneously remaining grounded and present.

"Let's see if you can be on two levels at once, beyond birth and death, but also right here, right now, in the room, your feet on the ground."

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Meditation: Entering Dreamless Sleep Consciously

Source: CT5 · March 29, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

We have access to an ancient memory, so ancient that it is hardly susceptible to being remembered. It is an intuition of a time before time.

"Behind one's conscious memories, one intuits a time before time, just as in the morning waking from a dream, one intuits a dreamless sleep preceding the dream."

THE PRACTICE OF FORMLESSNESS

Meditation, in this context, is the art of consciously entering this pre-conscious state.

"Meditation, which comes after contemplation, really means entering dreamless sleep consciously, not with a dualistic consciousness that is our ordinary condition in the daytime, but nonetheless, going into formlessness wakefully."

"And it's precisely that exploration that brings to realization the most primordial of the names."

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The Essence and Practice of Wazifa: Chanting Ya Hayyu

Source: CT5 · March 29, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

The practice of Wazifa, the repetition of a divine name, is a core Sufi method for spiritual realization that moves beyond mere mechanical recitation.

"Whenever we do a Wazifa, we don't just want to, you know, say it with the tongue and then let the mind wander to any random place."

The true purpose is to immerse oneself completely in the quality that the name represents.

THE PRACTICE OF 'YA HAYYU'

When practicing with the name Al-Hayy, *"the whole point is to dissolve into livingness."*

"Let the divine name speak for itself and announce a quality of being that is so clear and unmistakable that in that moment, that is all there is."

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Opening Attunement

Source: CT5 · March 29, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

In the sacred space of contemplation, we begin by aligning ourselves with the divine source and the great stream of illumination. This opening invocation sets our intention and connects us to the universal spirit that underlies all existence. We say: *"Toward the One, the perfection of love, harmony, and beauty, the only being, united with all the illuminated souls who form the embodiment of the messenger, the spirit of guidance."* Having thus invoked the ultimate reality, we remain in a state of deep inwardness. We watch the breath as it goes out, spiraling far into the distance, and then as it changes direction and draws toward the interior. This practice helps us consciously connect with the continuous outpouring of the divine into all of creation and the unfolding of our own being from that very source, leading us to dissolve into its inherent livingness and wisdom.

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The Spiritual Marriage of Opposites

Source: CT6 · March 29, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

BEYOND THE FALSE DICHOTOMY

We must be careful not to fall into a false dichotomy where light is good and darkness is something to be shunned or overcome.

"Whenever we meet with a polarity in creation and we… affirm only one pole, there's a danger of one-sidedness."

"In fact, the opposite poles have something of each other in each and they meet in a spiritual marriage. The coincidentia oppositorum."

"The great Sufi al-Kharraz said to look for God precisely where the opposites meet."

DARKNESS REVEALS LIGHT

Darkness is not merely the absence of light. It is the condition that allows subtler light to be seen--like the stars, which are invisible in the blue sky but brilliant in the blackness of night.

"The veiling of the light of the sun enables other manifestations of light to be revealed."

"Instead of thinking of darkness as the opposite of light, one begins to discover modalities of light, gradations of light, frequencies of light. And one finds that by filtering out the most obvious and most glaring frequencies, the result is not the dispelling of luminosity, but the discovery of of finer transmissions of light."

THE MIDNIGHT SUN

"This is why Sufis speak of the midnight sun, the sun that can only be beheld in the middle of the night, a black sun. The luminous manifestations that emerge in the shade."

"Just as there are things that are easier for our mind to see when our physical eyes are closed... to attain the inner vision, it's necessary to close one's eyes."

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The Practice of Shughli Mahtabi and Light in Darkness

Source: CT6 · March 29, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

We must be careful not to fall into a false dichotomy, thinking that light is good, benevolent, and welcome, while *"darkness by contrast is something opposed to light, something to be shunned, something to be avoided or overcome."*

THE COINCIDENTIA OPPOSITORUM

"Whenever we meet with a polarity in creation and we affirm only one pole, there's a danger of one-sidedness."

The poles are not truly separate. *"In fact, the opposite poles have something of each other in each and they meet in a spiritual marriage. The *coincidentia oppositorum*."*

"And in fact, the great Sufi al-Kharraz said to look for God precisely where the opposites meet."

THE LESSON OF SHUGHLI MAHTABI

This principle is revealed in the lunar practice, *shughli mahtabi*. While the moon can sometimes be seen in the daytime, it is at night that it becomes most visible.

"And this is especially true of the stars... We only see the stars in the black night sky."

"So darkness is showing us something. The veiling of the light of the sun enables other manifestations of light to be revealed."

Instead of thinking of darkness as the opposite of light, we begin to discover different modalities.

"One finds that by filtering out the most obvious and most glaring frequencies, the result is not the dispelling of luminosity, but the discovery of finer transmissions of light."

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The Prayer of All Holy Names and Forms

Source: CT6 · March 29, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

We understand that the Divine expresses itself in countless ways, appearing to us in varied forms and through many names. It is this universal presence we seek to recognize. In our prayer, we invoke this boundless recognition, saying: *"Allow us to recognize thee in all thy holy names and forms. As in Sita and Rama, as in*

Radha and Krishna, as in Parvati and Shiva…" This aspiration extends to many other names, holy names and forms known and unknown to the world, including Tara and Buddha, Sarah, Hagar, and Abraham, Deborah and Solomon, Anahita and Zarathustra, Asiya, Aaron, Maryam and Moses, Mary and Jesus, Khadija and Muhammad. This practice reminds us that the singular divine essence animates all sacred relationships and archetypes, transcending cultural and religious boundaries. By embracing this truth, we foster a deep sense of unity in our hearts and perceive God's light shining in every aspect of creation.

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Part I · Chapter 2

BREATH PRACTICES

The Rhythm That Carries the Contemplation

The breath is the bridge between body and spirit, between the outer world and the inner chamber. These practices — purification breaths, elemental breaths, and the breath of Haq — prepare the ground on which every contemplation stands.

15 Entries · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

From Earth to Water: Concentration to Contemplation

Source: CT1 · March 27, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

The four stages of spiritual practice can be compared to the four elements. The journey begins with Earth, the work of concentration, and now turns toward Water, the practice of contemplation.

THE EARTH ELEMENT -- CONCENTRATION (MUJAHADA)

The first stage of practice corresponds to the heavy, dense, and slow qualities of the Earth element.

"Earth, as you know, is very heavy, very dense, very slow. It corresponds to concentration."

"In our fast-moving world where attention is so rare, it's the first medicine. The very first thing to learn is to slow down and be like a rock. Just learn to be fully still, fully silent, fully present."

A stone carries an abiding vibration because its consciousness is not scattered. *"It's very rooted, very stable. And so this is what we've been developing in concentration."*

THE WATER ELEMENT -- CONTEMPLATION (MURAQABAH)

After establishing the stillness and stability of Earth, we transition to the element of Water. This is the turn from concentration to contemplation.

"After the Earth element comes the element of water. This is the shift we've reached now as we enter into contemplation. So having been still, having been focused, focused on one object, now we're going to begin to move. The mind is going to begin to move."

This is not the random, reactive movement of an untrained mind.

"We didn't want the mind to move until we were present and focused because it would just move randomly, it would just react to stimuli. But now that we've drawn our attention in and stabilized it and deepened it, now we can let it unfold, let it find its way."

This new movement is purposeful and artful, exploring the subtler dimensions of reality.

"This is what contemplation does… for the mind to move, but not erratically, not randomly, but gracefully, artfully, purposefully. This is Muraqabah."

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The Architecture of Meaning in Contemplation

Source: CT1 · March 27, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

We are taking a turn from concentration (Mujahada) to contemplation (Muraqabah). The four stages of practice bear comparison with the four elements.

"Earth, as you know, is very heavy, very dense, very slow. It corresponds to concentration."

"The very first thing to learn is to slow down and be like a rock. Just learn to be fully still, fully silent, fully present."

FROM EARTH TO WATER

After the stillness of Earth, we move to the element of Water.

"This is the shift we've reached now as we enter into contemplation. So having been still, having been focused… now we're going to begin to move. The mind is going to begin to move."

We did not want the mind to move until we were present, because it would just move randomly, reacting to stimuli. Now that we have stabilized and deepened our attention, we can let it unfold purposefully.

"This is what contemplation does. It is what it means for the mind to move, but not erratically, not randomly, but gracefully, artfully, purposefully. This is Muraqabah."

THE QUALITY BEYOND THE FORM

In this purposeful movement, our focus shifts from the external to the essential.

"We're not only going to be focusing on objects or even the forms of objects, but something subtler still, the quality of something, the character of something, the nature of it."

This inquiry leads us to the very foundation of reality.

"And this is leading us into the architecture of meaning that underlies the visible universe. What are the qualities of being that all things manifest in various combinations? These qualities are, in fact, in their essence, the attributes of God."

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Contemplation: When the Object Holds the Mind

Source: CT2 · March 27, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

THE CORE DISTINCTION

A fundamental shift occurs when moving from concentration to contemplation. Concentration is an active, outgoing act of grasping; contemplation is a receptive state of allowing.

"In concentration, the mind holds an object. In contemplation, the object holds the mind."

"In concentration, you reach out and grasp something, something that you want to take hold of in your mind. It's an active, an active act."

"Whereas now, when we move into contemplation, you are letting the object reveal itself."

FROM OBJECT TO SUBJECT

In contemplation, we allow the object to speak for itself. It is no longer a static *"thing"* but becomes a subject that reveals its own signs and meanings in a living dialogue.

"We let the object speak, let it show itself, and let it unfold its meaning, let it reveal its signs. So for this, a certain allowing is needed."

"It becomes a a living encounter with the object, and you see the object is a subject. It's not just the object of your attention, it's a subject in its own right."

Because we are not strictly controlling the process, we may be shown things we do not expect.

THE ICE ANALOGY

This shift can be seen as a movement from a solid to a liquid state.

"Concentration is earthlike... the object really feels like an object. It has a certain density, a certain heaviness, like something frozen, a piece of ice."

"But then in the sunlight, the ice begins to melt. It's, it turns to water, it flows through your fingers, and it flows along the ground, and it makes its way through the landscape, and it's, it's leading you somewhere. That's contemplation, from the solid state to the liquid state."

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The Shift from Objects to Living Ideas in Contemplation

Source: CT2 · March 27, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

FROM HOLDING AN OBJECT TO BEING HELD

"In concentration, the mind holds an object. In contemplation, the object holds the mind."

Concentration is an active act of reaching out and taking hold of a thing. Contemplation begins when you let the object reveal itself, inviting a process to unfold without strictly controlling it.

"We let the object speak, let it show itself, and let it unfold its meaning, let it reveal its signs. So for this, a certain allowing is needed."

"It becomes a living encounter with the object, and you see the object is a subject. It's not just the object of your attention, it's a subject in its own right."

FROM THINGS TO LIVING IDEAS

"Contemplation is not on an object, it is on an idea."

Every material form is an expression of the consciousness that gives rise to it. In contemplation, we shift our perception from fixed *"things"* to the living ideas and patterns they express.

"We're shifting from the tendency to concretize perceptions and to think things. Instead, we think thoughts, we think living ideas."

SEEING PATTERNS INSTEAD OF MONOLITHS

This approach changes how we perceive the world. When dealing with a difficult person, for example, instead of focusing on the person as a fixed entity, one contemplates the mentality they express.

"You see that instead of thinking in terms of hermetically sealed, bounded monoliths, you you see patterns. You see qualities, you see currents of vibration, frequencies."

"You're working very consciously with the constituents of consciousness. That's what we're doing in Muraqabah."

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Elevating Consciousness from the Dense World

Source: CT2 · March 27, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

THE POWER OF AN IDEA

"Contemplation is the ability to retain an idea which raises one's consciousness from the dense world."

This is a movement from the bounded, the fixed, and the concrete toward more fluid modes of perception.

PREPAREDNESS AND ATTUNEMENT

"Ideas are attractors of vibration. And we find ourselves in our own mental life assimilating further formations of consciousness as we are prepared."

This preparedness, called *istidad* in Sufism, is the capacity to attune to and access what is already present.

"All of these frequencies, all of these vibrations... they're like radio waves that are in the room right now. But our preparedness means the capacity to attune to and access a certain transmission. And the whole process of our unfoldment is a process of developing this capacity."

ASCENDING THROUGH LATTICES OF THOUGHT

In contemplation, we navigate and ascend through the structures of the subtle world.

"The particles of the world of Malakut, these form lattices that we navigate in our contemplations, that we ascend through."

"And we're moving toward vaster, finer capacities, which really means reactivating finer modes of perception that we have, that have become vestigial in us, that have been so long dormant that we hardly know we have them anymore because our consciousness is so externalized."

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Navigating Malakut: The Lattices of Thought-Beings (Muwakkals)

Source: CT2 · March 27, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

In contemplation, we move from thinking of things to thinking of living ideas. These ideas are not abstract concepts, but living frequencies in the imaginal realm.

"Ideas are attractors of vibration."

"All of these frequencies, all of these vibrations… they're like radio waves that are in the room right now. But our preparedness means the capacity to attune to and access a certain transmission."

LATTICES OF THE IMAGINAL REALM

An idea is a living formation within the imaginal world of *Malakut*, constituted by what are known as *muwakkals*, or thought-beings.

"The idea… is the formation of frequencies among the muwakkals and among the thought beings, the particles of the world of Malakut."

"These form lattices that we navigate in our contemplations, that we ascend through."

AWAKENING FINER PERCEPTION

By navigating these lattices, we awaken dormant capacities of awareness that have been lost to an externalized and determined consciousness.

"We're moving toward vaster, finer capacities, which really means reactivating finer modes of perception that we have, that have become vestigial in us."

These modes of perception *"have been so long dormant that we hardly know we have them anymore because our consciousness is so externalized and so determined."*

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Ya Fattah: The Divine Opener Beyond Our Will

Source: CT4 · March 28, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

WHEN THE HEART IS CLOSED

"On the path of Suluk, the journey of the soul, the traveler will inevitably encounter periods of difficulty and constriction. These are moments when the path seems to disappear and the heart feels closed."

"We may feel constricted, blocked, or shut down in our hearts and in our lives."

BEYOND OUR OWN WILL

The practice of calling upon Ya Fattah, the Opener, is an admission that true transformation comes from a source beyond the ego.

"When we call upon Ya Fattah, we are acknowledging that the opening we seek is not something we can engineer through our own will."

"It is like a flower bud that cannot force itself to bloom; it must wait for the sun to coax its petals open. We turn to the Opener, trusting that in the right time, the way will be made clear."

A POWERFUL REMEDY

"This Wazifa is a powerful remedy for such states. It is a direct appeal to the divine reality to intervene, to open what has been closed, to bestow what is needed, and to grant the patience to endure the trial until the light returns."

The Wazifa is a key, a tool for transformation given by a spiritual guide to a student facing a particular challenge. *"When we practice it, we are not alone; we are supported by the lineage of teachers and saints who have walked this path before us."*

PRACTICE WITH THE ROSEBUD HEART

1. Bring your awareness to the heart center
2. With each breath, practice *Hosh dar dam* — awareness in the breath
3. Silently, in the heart, repeat the Wazifa: Ya Fattah, Ya Wahhab, Ya Sabur
4. *"You can visualize your heart as a tightly closed rosebud, holding all of its potential within."*
5. As you repeat the names, imagine the divine qualities are like sunlight and gentle rain upon this bud:

*Ya Fattah** is the warmth that encourages the petals to unfurl.

*Ya Wahhab** is the dew that nourishes it from within.

*Ya Sabur** is the deep-rootedness that keeps it stable.

"The opening is the release of the soul's unique fragrance into the world."

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A Breathing Practice for the Wazifa

Source: CT4 · March 28, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

As we engage in the silent Zikr of the Wazifa, the practice of Hosh dar dam, or awareness in the breath, serves as a vital anchor. By bringing our awareness to the breath, we ground ourselves in the living presence, allowing the divine names to permeate our being more deeply and safely. *"The silent Zikr of the Wazifa can be synchronized with the rhythm of the breath. One might recite Ya Fattah on the in-breath, Ya Wahhab at the turning point, and Ya Sabur on the out-breath. Or one might find a different rhythm that feels natural."* The key is to let the names and the breath merge into a single, continuous flow of remembrance, carrying the heart toward the ocean of unity. This integration deepens our attunement to these profound divine qualities, fostering openness, grace, and steadfastness in our lives.

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The Complete Planes of Being: From Unmanifest to Human Form

Source: CT5 · March 29, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

"Sufis down the ages having probed these depths have sought to give names to the gradations of being emerging into consciousness."

"The names of the planes are subjective and are given differently by different thinkers, but also they can serve as a certain kind of key."

THE SIX PLANES

1. **Ahadiyat (Essential Oneness)**

"First is Ahadiyat… which is synonymous with the Zat, Zat-i-Ilahi. The Zat is contrasted with the Sifat. Zat is the essence and the Sifat are the qualities… which are described by the divine names." Ahadiyat is *"the divine essence, which is beyond the beyond, waral wara. It's indescribable and absolutely inconceivable and unknown, the mystery, the hidden treasure."*

2. **Wahdat (Divinized Oneness)**

"The second stage is Wahdat, which could be translated perhaps… as divinized oneness… Before this upwelling of self-awareness, one cannot really speak of Godhood. Godhood manifests out of the great mystery now in Wahdat, quickened by, that is to say, stimulated into emergence through Ishq. 'I was a hidden treasure and I longed to be known.'"

3. **Wahdaniyat (Manifest Oneness)**

"And then Wahdaniyat… which is manifest oneness… Here is where the first creature is manifested… the great soul, the Ruh al-A'zam, and the cosmic person, the al-Shakhs al-Kabir."

4. **Arwah (The World of Souls)**

"The next stage is Arwah, souls. The souls are the irradiation. Each soul a ray."

5. **Ajsam (The World of Mental Bodies)**

"Then Ajsam… Ajsam is not bodies in the sense of physical bodies, but mental bodies, minds."

6. **Insan (The World of Physical Embodiment)**

"And then Insan is physical embodiment."

A PERPETUAL CREATION

This descent through the planes is not a historical event, but a continuous, present-moment reality.

"We have to think beyond our ordinary temporal framework and realize that these aren't events that occurred at a single

time. We're speaking of the ocean and its waves, perpetual creation."

"Here is an outline of how we got here, but again, let's not only use the past tense, how we're continuously getting here from the source, how the source is continuously manifesting everything that is."

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The Unfolding of the Self and the Universe

Source: CT5 · March 29, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

The Sufi teaching on the emergence of the seven divine names maps two parallel processes: the creation of the universe and the formulation of the individual self. The development from sheer being (*Al-Hayy*), to awareness (*Al-Alim*), to a sense of agency (*Al-Qadir*) culminates in the arising of will.

FROM POWER TO DESIRE

The journey from infancy to selfhood mirrors the cosmic journey. After the discovery of power, the question of its use arises.

"The child over time comes to see that after throwing porridge on the ground once and twice and three times, it's… no longer so interesting and the question becomes, how to use this power? If I can do anything, or at least I can do some things, what ought I do? What do I want to do? What outcomes could I envision? What am I looking for? And this line of questions opens up the next divine name, Al-Murid, the desirer."

THE DIVINE CREATIVE LONGING

This same desiring force is at work throughout all of creation, from the formation of solar systems to the evolution of life. We are participants in this cosmic process.

"Each of us has a hand in the making of this world. That's no small thing. It's our participation in the power which is the power of all powers."

"This restless desire is quivering in all of the molecules of creation, stirring new possibilities. And we are partakers not only in the divine power, but also in the divine creative longing, Irada. Irada, desire."

THE SEEKER IS GOD

This divine desire, when it becomes tangled or narrowly conceived in us, can lead to dissatisfaction. But this very dissatisfaction can become a guidepost, transforming the world into a place of learning.

"The world becomes a a school of love where we learn lessons along the way, learn how to love, learn to clarify our desire, clarify it, and empower it and focus it and align with it."

"It's no coincidence that an initiate in the inner school is known as a Murid. A seeker, a lover. That is the meaning of Murid. And as we know, this is a a divine name, which if one is paying close attention, tells one something from the very beginning. That which is hinted at the beginning will become more clear in the end. But that is that the seeker is God."

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The Continuous Unfolding of Creation

Source: CT5 · March 29, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

The planes of being are not a historical account of a past creation event. They describe a dynamic, ongoing process—a perpetual unfolding from the divine essence in every moment.

BEYOND A TEMPORAL FRAMEWORK

We must think beyond our ordinary framework of time and realize that the stages of creation are not events that occurred at a single point in the past.

"How can something suddenly come out of infinity? If it was going to happen, why should it happen at one time rather than another? And in eternity, there is no time to speak of anyway."

"So we have to think beyond our ordinary temporal framework and realize that these aren't events that occurred at a single time."

THE OCEAN AND ITS WAVES

This perspective shifts our understanding from a static universe to a living, breathing reality that is constantly being renewed.

"We're speaking of the ocean and its waves, perpetual creation."

"The deepest meditators discover that this this first creature is so much the effusion of the Godhead that yes, it is creation, but it is also the very light of the creator."

A CONTINUOUS MANIFESTATION

The story of how we got here is the story of how we are *always* getting here, continuously manifesting from the Source.

"Let's not only use the past tense, how we're continuously getting here from the source, how the source is continuously manifesting everything that is."

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Divine Nostalgia: The Creative Impulse

Source: CT5 · March 29, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

THE WELLING UP OF CREATION

The impulse for creation stems from a profound and paradoxical longing within the Divine -- not a yearning for a past that was, but a yearning for self-manifestation.

"As my father used to love the word nostalgia... he would say the divine nostalgia began to well up."

THE OCEAN AND ITS WAVES

This creative act is not an event that occurred at a single point in the past. To think in this way confines the eternal to a limited, human timescale.

"How can something suddenly come out of infinity? If it was going to happen, why should it happen at one time rather than another? And in eternity, there is no time to speak of anyway."

"We have to think beyond our ordinary temporal framework and realize that these aren't events that occurred at a single time. We're speaking of the ocean and its waves, perpetual creation."

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The Subjectivity of Naming the Divine Planes

Source: CT5 · March 29, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

Sufis have long sought to give names to the gradations of being that emerge into consciousness. While these names can be useful, it's essential to understand their nature.

BEYOND DESCRIPTION

"The names are to some extent arbitrary because the names of the planes are subjective and different thinkers give different terms. We're speaking of states of being beyond description and and beyond denomination."

CLUES AND KEYS

Despite their subjectivity, these names are not without purpose. They are not meant to be rigid doctrines, but rather meditative tools.

"Some of the essential articulations that have come down can serve as clues, as helpful clues… they can serve as a certain kind of key."

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The Practice of Gazing into Darkness

Source: CT6 · March 29, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

This practice explores the discovery of light within darkness, complementing the practices of gazing at the sun and moon.

THE LIGHT IN THE SHADE

"Sufis speak of the midnight sun, the sun that can only be beheld in the middle of the night, a black sun. The luminous manifestations that emerge in the shade."

"Instead of thinking of darkness as the opposite of light, one begins to discover modalities of light, gradations of light, frequencies of light."

"By filtering out the most obvious and most glaring frequencies, the result is not the dispelling of luminosity, but the discovery of of finer transmissions of light."

THE PRACTICE

A practice of pure witnessing, allowing the eye to perceive the light inherent in total darkness.

1. *"Find the darkest space that you can find and darken it as fully as possible."* You might go into a closet or bathroom with no windows, placing a towel under the door so no light comes in.

2. *"Sit in the darkness with open eyes and as much as possible without blinking. Not painfully so, but try to avoid blinking as much as possible."*
3. *"Look into the darkness and see what you see."*
4. Continue for about ten minutes or more.

WITNESS, DO NOT IMAGINE

This is not a practice of visualization. The instruction is to receive, not to project.

"We're not projecting any kind of image, whether preconceived or spontaneously imagined. We're not imagining. We're just witnessing the light that appears to your eyes in the darkness."

Observe with fine attention, *"observing the little grains of light in their various patternings, in the various tincturings they take on, in their waves and ripples, in their multi-dimensionality."*

"That sense of spatial distance dissolves in the darkness and the vision might be happening in your retina, in your brain, in a disembodied mind. It doesn't matter. You're just meeting the vision of the light in the darkness."

DARKNESS IS ALSO A KIND OF LIGHT

"You'll find that there's light in the darkness. And in fact, it serves as a testimony to the fact that, you know, what we call darkness is just a certain portion of the spectrum of illumination in its various modes. Darkness is also a kind of light."

After the practice, do not rush on to the next thing. *"Just see how has this act of attention affected me? What is my state of being now, having having done this?"*

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Knocking on the Door of the Latifas with the Breath

Source: CT6 · March 29, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

The subtle centers within us, known as latifas, are like sacred portals to deeper states of being, and our approach to them is paramount. To open these gateways, especially within the body, we use the breath as a gentle knock. It's akin to approaching the home of someone you hold in great affection and esteem; *"you're not going to bang on the door, you're going to gently, gently knock and let the, you know, the cadence of your knock express something of your greeting to the one living inside."* This sensitivity in our breath, attuned to each specific subtle space, is crucial. Whether connecting with the passionate heart (Qalb) or the luminous soul (Ruh), our mindful breathing becomes a profound greeting, allowing these divine qualities to softly awaken and manifest within our experience.

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Part I · Chapter 3

FIKR & ZIKR — REMEMBRANCE

Silent and Spoken Remembrance of the One

Fikr is the silent remembrance borne on the breath; Zikr is the spoken remembrance that resounds in the heart. Together they form the continuous thread of presence that contemplation gathers into a single luminous point.

24 Entries · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

Guided Zikr Practice — Ya Hayyu

Source: CT1 · March 27, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

THE PRACTICE

Invocation of the divine name Al-Hayy through its Ya-form: *"Ya Hayyu"* (O Living One).

Guided group zikr led by Pir Zia. The class invokes the name together in unison, repeated 101 times.

"Shall we invoke this name now? Al-Hayy."

CLOSING WORDS

"The livingness in you is no different than the livingness in the Earth, which is no different than the eternal livingness which is in the divine being."

"When you're ready, if you would like, we can open our eyes again."

CONTEXT

This is the first guided zikr practice of the Contemplation series, working with Al-Hayy — the first of the seven Ummahat (mother names). The practice moves from intellectual understanding of Al-Hayy into direct experiential invocation through the repetition of the sacred name.

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Al-Hayy: Contemplating The Living

Source: CT1 · March 27, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

Al-Hayy, The Living, is the first of the seven mother names. Its primacy is foundational to all existence.

"Why is it the first? Before something can be something, certainly before something can do something, something must simply be. Something must simply exist, live. This comes first."

THE SOUND OF LIVINGNESS

The name Al-Hayy exemplifies how sacred words embody the quality they designate. The sound itself is a transmission.

"Even if you are not told that Hayy means the living, if you would simply recite Hayy, Hayy, Hayy, Hayy, Hayy, you would find in your breath a surge of livingness that confirms the meaning of the word."

LIFE NEVER DIES

We often mistakenly equate life only with physical embodiment, but this is just one of its modes.

"It is an error to identify life exclusively with physical embodiment. Life is something more innate."

"Long before we incarnated, already we lived. After this body dissolves into its elements, still we'll live. In fact, life never dies. Death dies, life lives."

THE GROUND OF LIFE

Contemplating Al-Hayy is an invitation to feel into a deeper, more ancient reality of being.

"You can sink down into yourself and discover a ground of life that is more ancient than the novel manifestations of being that we identify so exclusively with."

"There's a felicity in the sheer livingness of the soul. Our livingness in the one that is inalienable."

"The livingness in you is no different than the livingness in the Earth, which is no different than the eternal livingness which is in the divine being."

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Considering Your Responsibility Sacred

Source: CT1 · March 27, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

"My conscientious self, consider your responsibility sacred."

This chivalric rule is a contemplation on personal agency. It is an invitation to decide how to lead the precious life that has been entrusted to us.

"We are free to sculpt our lives. We can't control other people, but we have perfect discretion in determining how we respond to them. And if we don't affirm that freedom and claim it, then we'll find ourselves merely reacting to circumstances, acting on conditioning."

TRUE RESPONSIBILITY — DHARMA

This contemplation requires distinguishing our true responsibility from the expectations others project onto us.

"The real question is, what is truly due to each person, to each being? What is the the haqq, the right that each being has? And what is the haqq of one's own self?"

"What does it mean to do justice to ourself? Fundamentally, it means being true to your purpose, to your dharma, your responsibility."

"At the end of the day, we're not going to be asked about something that someone else was responsible for. We'll be asked about what we were responsible for."

THE NATURE OF SERIOUSNESS

"Seriousness doesn't mean a kind of dry as dust solemnity. There may certainly be joy in it. There may be a lightness of touch in it. It doesn't have to be ponderously weighty and self-important."

"Seriousness means sincerity, care, devoted attention."

THE TEST OF DHARMA — AN ANALOGY

An ancient Hindu epic tells of Yudhisthira, who, at the end of a long pilgrimage, is left with only a dog for a companion. An angel descends in a flying car and offers to take him to his destination--but the dog may not come.

Yudhisthira refuses: *"No, I can't. I won't. Thank you for the offer, but I'm I'm traveling with my friend."*

At that moment, the dog transforms. *"And the dog revealed, 'I am Dharma. I am your Dharma. And you were true to me.'"*

THE HOLY OF HOLIES

Your purpose is a music that is unfolding. The opportunity is to sense what is intrinsic to that purpose and what is merely incidental distraction.

"Not everything that is pulling you in, not everything that captures your thought stream is intrinsic to your purpose."

Contemplate *"your real work, what you're responsible for. Even if it's hard, just the the sacredness of your sacred duty. How it's a holy thing, actually."*

"Maybe more holy than, you know, artifacts in temples or synagogues, mosques, churches. It's the the holy of holies contained in your heart, the sacred energy given to you for your opus, your work."

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The Test of Dharma: The Story of Yudhisthira and the Dog

Source: CT1 · March 27, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

There are responsibilities you choose, and there are responsibilities that come to you--where you realize that by the nature of your placement, you have come to hold a trust.

"An example would be a story that is told at the culmination of the Mahabharata, great Hindu epic, which has as its heroes, Yudhisthira and his wife, Draupadi, and his brothers."

THE STORY OF YUDHISTHIRA

After concluding their earthly affairs, the family resolves to embark on a pilgrimage into the mountains to ascend Mount Meru. Along the way, a dog joins them, and they enjoy its companionship.

But the journey is arduous. *"Tragically, in the course of the ordeals and vicissitudes of the venture, one after the other, Yudhisthira's brothers are they they perish… and Draupadi does also."*

"And in the end, it's only Yudhisthira and the dog."

Nearly exhausted, with the mountaintop looming, a flying car descends from the sky. The angel steering it offers a rescue: *"Step into the car and come with me and I'll take you to your destination. Only the dog may not come."*

Yudhisthira, who had been on the verge of accepting, looks at his companion. He said, *"No, I can't. I won't. Thank you for the offer, but I'm traveling with my friend."*

At that moment, the dog began to transform, taking on an angelic appearance.

"And the dog revealed, 'I am Dharma. I am your Dharma. And you were true to me.'"

SENSING YOUR DHARMA

The word Dharma can be interpreted in many ways, but in contemplation, we can move beyond rigid definitions.

"The opportunity is to sense the Dharma as something very much linked with guidance, with intuition, with your your own deepest knowing."

"It's not egoically defined. In fact, your Dharma has very much to do with relationships. But since it is of the spirit, since it is an expression of divine guidance, it'll never be simplistic. It'll never be rigid. It's always going to be an unfolding process of being, knowing, doing."

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Entering Malakut: Guided Contemplation as Invitation

Source: CT2 · March 27, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

LED INTO A LANDSCAPE

One method of Muraqabah, or contemplation, is to be led into a landscape within *Malakut*, the imaginal realm. This approach differs from the fixed-point focus of concentration.

"What differs from concentration is that you don't only meet there with what you have prescribed. The entry is an invitation and there is an evocation of a certain kind of space."

A SELF-ARISING REALITY

The intention guides you to this realm, but once there, the experience is one of pure receptivity. *Malakut* is not a projection of one's own mind, but a real place where genuine discovery occurs.

"We usher ourselves into a certain space within Malakut, but what unfolds there is self-arising in as much as Malakut is a real place."

"The intention takes us there, but then we're there and we're making our way through the space and we're shown what we're shown."

THE PRACTICE

Using narrative and music as a guide, one enters this imaginal space and simply remains present to what reveals itself.

"We're going to let that narrative take us into that place and enter it and then just be there, walk there, see what shows itself, let yourself be open to the thoughts, the ideas, the presences that are disclosed."

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Winter's Renewal: Touching the Root of Being

Source: CT2 · March 27, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

A guided contemplation on the winter landscape as a mirror for inner renewal—stepping back to touch the root of being and emerge restored.

THE WINTER LANDSCAPE

"Back down in the valley as winter sets in, how inebriating it is to savor the musty scent of the earth, sodden with abundant rainfall. Your attention is drawn towards all that impending life grinding to a halt or poised in waiting underground."

"The hibernation of hedgehogs and badgers and umpteen other little creatures, and the germination taking place in the seeds in anticipation of the breakthrough of spring."

STEPPING BACK TO RENEW

"Turning ponderously upon yourself, you recognize yourself in this teeming wellspring of life. One needs to step back in life before stepping forward, to lie low."

"It is not really escaping from the unceasing challenges, but anticipating action by fostering a renewal of life. For life is not just cyclic, but ever recurrently renewed. For this, one has to sometimes skim rock bottom."

TOUCHING THE ROOT OF YOUR BEING

"You are touching upon the root of your being. You will notice that, likened to the earth, it is profuse in its generosity, unrelenting in its benevolence in resorbing our pollution and recycling it into something beautiful."

"Only a small fraction of its bounty normally flowers in our personality, and we have to plunge deep into the springheads of our being to haul them to the surface in rapt contemplation."

RE-ENCHANTED EMERGENCE

"In the silence within, new ideas surface unpredictably. Fresh resolve, a new zest to respond to life's calling, as though you lie underground as a seed in incubation."

"The sun beckons upon you with its flares to emerge from your lethargy and dance the round of life. You stretch, your being unfurls, restored, recharged, reinstated, re-enchanted."

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The Closing Prayer (Salat): Recognizing the One in All Holy Names

Source: CT2 · March 27, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

THE DIVINE LIGHT IN ALL FORMS

"Most gracious sovereign, messenger, messiah, and savior of humanity. We greet thee with all humility."

"Thou art the first cause and the last effect, the divine light and the spirit of guidance, Alpha and Omega."

"Thy light is in all forms, thy love in all beings. In a loving mother, in a kind father, in an innocent child, in a helpful friend, in an inspiring teacher."

IN ALL HOLY NAMES

"Allow us to recognize thee in all thy holy names and forms, as Sita and Rama, as Radha and Krishna, as Parvati and Shiva, as Tara and Buddha."

"Let us know thee as Sarah, Hagar, and Abraham, as Deborah and Solomon, as Anahita and Zarathustra, as Asia, Aaron, Maryam, and Moses, as Mary and Jesus, as Khadija and Muhammad, and many other names and forms known and unknown to the world."

THE MESSAGE OF GOD

"We adore thy past, thy presence deeply enlighteneth our being, and we look for thy blessing in the future."

"Oh messenger, Christ, Nabi, the Rasul of God. Thou whose heart constantly reacheth upward, thou comest on earth with a message as a dove from above when Dharma decayeth, and speakest the word that is put into thy mouth, as the light filleth the crescent moon."

"May the message of God reach far and wide, illuminating and making the whole of humanity one single family in the parenthood of God."

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Untangling Our Desires to Find the Divine Impulse

Source: CT3 · March 28, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

We are the inheritors of all the divine qualities, but in our descent into the physical world, these qualities have a tendency to become tangled up within us. Our work is to recognize the sacred origin of even our most confused desires.

THE DIVINE IMPULSE IN DESIRE

"Murshid said that every desire, every human desire, has at its origin a divine impulse."

"Does that mean that all of our urges are honorable or enlightened? No, but it means that at the back of them, at the origin of them, is a providential ray of the divine nature."

"But that ray, that expression of a divine quality has become confused in us, narrowed down, contorted, tangled up."

THE WORK OF WEAVING A TAPESTRY

The spiritual path is not about rejecting our nature, but about refining it through a process of careful transformation.

"So we have work to do. And it's really a work of untangling. It's not really about rejecting anything. It's about taking all of our experience and disentangling it, finding the threads, untying the knots, stretching out the threads, identifying them, and then weaving them beautifully."

"The same quantity of thread could either be a tangled jumble or an exquisite tapestry."

"The divine qualities are seeking their expression in this universe. This universe was made for this. We were born for this."

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Cosmic Recapitulation in the Womb

Source: CT3 · March 28, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

The entire process of cosmic creation is mirrored and recapitulated within the intimate development of the human embryo.

THE WOMB OF COMPASSION

"You can see the process in embryology. Think of how once you were an embryo in the womb and you floated in the amniotic fluid and the primary sensation was of life itself. You weren't

thinking, how am I going to do this or do that? You floated and simply were alive."

This state of pure being echoes the divine quality of *Al-Hayy*, the Living.

"Actually, you know the womb is, the word in Arabic is rahm, rahm. Rahman and Rahim come from this. The compassion, the mercy that brought forth this world. So that's the state of livingness that that comes first."

FROM LIVINGNESS TO KNOWINGNESS

As the embryo develops, a new quality emerges, reflecting the divine name *Al-'Alim*, the Knower. This mirrors the cosmic dawning of awareness.

"On the physical level, the cycle begins again with Al-Hayy. Then Al-'Alim, the knower, out of sheer livingness comes knowingness, just as out of the Ahadiyyat, out of Wahdat came Ahadiyyat. First beyond being and non-being, then being awakening to itself and knowing."

ONTOGENY RECAPITULATES PHYLOGENY

This principle, where the development of an individual mirrors the evolutionary and cosmic history, reveals a profound truth about our own nature.

"Ontogeny recapitulates phylogeny. The way we grow in the womb, some would say recapitulates the whole story of human emergence and that process recapitulates the whole arc of the cosmos, which itself echoes the dawning of the divine intelligence."

INNATE INTELLIGENCE

This primary knowing is not dependent on sensory perception; it is an innate condition of consciousness itself.

"Even before the senses open, there's a knowing mind, there's a self-knowing. And that self-knowing isn't yet defined in opposition to another, it's innate."

"Murshid uses that word intelligence in a very specific way. Intelligence is consciousness in its innate condition. When intelligence is presented with an object, then there is a subject and an object and a knowledge intervening between them. And this is what we would call consciousness. But in the most primal condition of intelligence, there is no encounter with an external object and so intelligence is simply an innate self-awareness."

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Weaving an Exquisite Tapestry of Divine Qualities

Source: CT3 · March 28, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

THE TANGLED THREADS OF BEING

"Every desire, every human desire, has at its origin a divine impulse... But that ray, that expression of a divine quality has become confused in us, narrowed down, contorted, tangled up."

THE WORK OF UNTANGLING

"So we have work to do. And it's really a work of untangling. It's not really about rejecting anything. It's about taking all of our experience and disentangling it, finding the threads, untying the knots, stretching out the threads, identifying them, and then weaving them beautifully."

"The same quantity of thread could either be a tangled jumble or an exquisite tapestry."

OUR RAISON D'ÊTRE

"The divine qualities are seeking their expression in this universe. This universe was made for this. We were born for this."

"The ultimate raison d'être of our being is this witnessing, this adoring, this glorifying, this return of the one to the one through the many."

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Ontogeny Recapitulates Phylogeny: The Cosmos in the Womb

Source: CT3 · March 28, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

THE CYCLE RENEWED IN THE WOMB

"You can see the process in embryology. Think of how once you were an embryo in the womb... the primary sensation was of life itself. You floated and simply were alive."

"So on the physical level, the cycle begins again with Al-Hayy. Then Al-'Alim, the knower, out of sheer livingness comes knowingness, just as out of the Ahadiyyat, out of Wahdat came Ahadiyyat. First beyond being and non-being, then being awakening to itself and knowing."

A COSMIC ECHO

"And in that knowing comes the flashing forth of the cosmos. Ontogeny recapitulates phylogeny."

"The way we grow in the womb, some would say recapitulates the whole story of human emergence and that process recapitulates the whole arc of the cosmos, which itself echoes the dawning of the divine intelligence."

REINSCRIBED AND RECAPITULATED

"Passing through the river of Lethe and entering a new cycle, there is a kind of reset. And the whole cosmic process of becoming is reinscribed and recapitulated."

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The Ultimate Gift of Ya Wahhab: Nearness to the Giver

Source: CT4 · March 28, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

THE ESSENCE OF THE GIFT

While the bestowal of Ya Wahhab may appear as worldly blessings, its true essence is an inner, spiritual transformation.

"The gift of Wahhab is ultimately the gift of nearness to the Giver. While it may manifest as worldly blessings, its true essence is a spiritual transformation."

"The greatest gift is the purification of the Nafs, the awakening of the Qalb, and the illumination of the Ruh."

"It is the bestowal of divine qualities upon the Abd, the servant, so that the servant may become a clearer mirror for the attributes of the Lord."

HUMILITY IN RECEIVING

A subtle danger lies in the ego's desire to claim the divine gift as its own achievement.

"The name Ya Wahhab is a constant reminder that all good comes from the divine source as a free and unmerited gift."

"Our role is simply to prepare the vessel and to receive with humility and gratitude, knowing that we have done nothing to deserve it."

MANIFESTATION ON EVERY PLANE

The opening that precedes the gift can occur on every level of our being--from the most mundane to the most sublime.

"There can be an opening in the world of Nasut, our physical and social life, where a problem is resolved or a new path appears."

"There can be an opening in the Malakut, the world of the heart, where a new depth of feeling and love is discovered."

"And there can be an opening in the Jabrut, the world of the soul, where one receives a profound spiritual insight or a glimpse of the divine unity."

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Ya Sabur: The Patient Endurance of Spiritual Struggle

Source: CT4 · March 28, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

THE SUBSTANCE OF THE SPIRITUAL STRUGGLE

"Sabur, patience, is the very substance of Mujahada, the spiritual struggle."

"It is the steadfastness required to remain present with oneself, to witness the agitations of the lower self without being swept away by them."

"It is the endurance to continue polishing the mirror of the heart, day after day, even when it seems covered in the dust of the world. Without Sabur, the path is impossible, for the journey is long and the ego is ever-resistant to its own transformation."

SABUR IN DAILY PRACTICE

"The quality of Sabur is not just for the long-term waiting, but also for the daily commitment to show up for the practice, regardless of our mood or external circumstances."

"Consistency is key in this practice. It is better to practice for a short time every day than for a long time once a week. This daily return to the inner sanctuary builds a momentum... This steadfastness itself is a form of prayer that attracts the divine response."

PREPARING THE VESSEL

There is a story of a great Wali, a friend of God, who sat in Muraqabah for forty years facing a wall, waiting for an opening.

"Day after day, he practiced with unwavering Sabur. One day, the opening came, and the wall before him became transparent, and he could see the mysteries of the Malakut, the angelic world. His patience had prepared the vessel of his being to receive the immense gift that Wahhab had in store for him."

THE GOAL OF THE JOURNEY

Patience sustains the journey toward its ultimate goal: the experience of Fana and Baqa.

"Fana is the annihilation of the false, separate self in the divine presence. Baqa is the subsistence, the eternal life, of the true self in and through God."

"The opening of Fattah clears the way for this transformation, and the patience of Sabur sustains us on the journey toward it."

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The Story of the Wali Who Waited Forty Years

Source: CT4 · March 28, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

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THE WALI AND THE WALL

"There is a story of a great Wali, a friend of God, who sat in Muraqabah for forty years facing a wall, waiting for an opening. Day after day, he practiced with unwavering Sabur."

"One day, the opening came, and the wall before him became transparent, and he could see the mysteries of the Malakut, the angelic world. His patience had prepared the vessel of his being to receive the immense gift that Wahhab had in store for him."

ALIGNING WITH THE DIVINE TIMELINE

This practice is a profound exercise in aligning the will of the Abd, the servant, with the will of Haqq, the divine Reality.

"We express our desire for opening, but we leave the timing and the nature of that opening to the Opener. We express our need for a gift, but we trust the Bestower to know what gift is best. And we commit to patience, acknowledging that our timeline is not the divine timeline."

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Nizam un Nisa — The Saint of Sabur and Ishq

Source: CT4 · March 28, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

"The life of the great woman saint Nizam un Nisa, a disciple of Hazrat Nizamuddin Auliya, is a beautiful example of Sabur and Ishq. She served her Murshid with selfless devotion for many years, performing the most menial tasks in the Khankah."

"Her patient, loving service purified her heart to such a degree that she became one of the great spiritual lights of her time, a channel for the divine gifts of Wahhab to all who came to her."

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The Marriage of Zikr (Remembrance) and Fikr (Contemplation)

Source: CT4 · March 28, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

To fully engage with the divine names and allow their spiritual grace to penetrate deeply within us, we are called to bring both our hearts and minds into the practice. It is not enough merely to repeat the sacred sounds; we must also contemplate their profound implications for our lives and the greater cosmos. *"It is beneficial to combine the practice of Zikr, the remembrance of the divine names, with Fikr, contemplation on their meanings. As we repeat 'Ya Fattah,' we can contemplate the nature of opening in our lives and in the cosmos... This marriage of sound and meaning deepens the practice..."* This conscious fusion ensures the wisdom of the names permeates fully into our hearts and minds, allowing us to move beyond mere recitation. By uniting sound and meaning, we cultivate a profound, experiential connection that transforms our entire being and illuminates our path.

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The Murshid's Lesson on Experiential Knowledge

Source: CT5 · March 29, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

In Sufi cosmology, the names for the planes of being are not philosophical concepts to be cataloged, but clues for direct experience.

THE NOTEBOOK

A story is told of Hazrat Inayat Khan's time with his Murshid, a specialist in the metaphysics of Ibn al-Arabi.

"The Murshid was always speaking about the most ordinary things. And finally one day, the Murshid began to speak of metaphysics and Hazrat took out his notebook to take notes and the Murshid went back to speaking about the trees and milk and things like that."

THE NAMES AS KEYS

The purpose of these teachings is not to accumulate information, but to enter into a state of being. On another occasion, the Murshid did share the names of the planes.

"And Hazrat went home with those names in his mind and just took each name one by one and entered it."

"Just having been told these names without any elaboration or extensive description, having been given these names, he simply went and meditated and went to them."

This illustrates the true function of sacred knowledge: the names can serve as a key, but only when used for inner realization, not for intellectual collection.

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The Fiery Heart: Born of Sympathy and a Life Deeply Lived

Source: CT6 · March 29, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

In the anatomy of the *Latif* (the subtle centers), the heart, or *Qalb*, is approached through the space of the physical heart.

"It's the subtle heart underlying the physical heart. And its flowering is a consequence of the maturation of the Nafs. The Qalb emerges out of the shell of the Nafs."

BORN OF SYMPATHY

The blossoming of the heart begins when the personal self moves beyond its own boundaries into a state of fellow feeling.

"It's born of sympathy. When the Nafs isn't only competitive and oppositional, but begins to see not only its own self, but other selves, and feel not only its own suffering, but others' suffering, sympathy is born."

"When feeling bursts the bounds of the ego and becomes cosmic, becomes sympathetic, becomes open to the inspiration that fuels poetry and music, then the heart is at last blossoming."

A LIFE DEEPLY LIVED

The heart's character is forged through direct experience--it is not a center that can be cultivated by skimming the surface of life.

"The heart is born of a life deeply lived. It cannot come into its own when we skim the surface. It's born of pain and grace."

"There's passion in it, there's forgiveness, there's longing, a rawness that expresses an urgency which one can easily differentiate from the, let's say, cunning of the immature Nafs or the serene detachment of the Khafi."

THE ELEMENTAL CENTERS

Each subtle center has its own elemental nature, its own quality and mode of being.

"There's a fire in the heart. The Khafi is more airy. Nafs is more earthy. Heart is fiery and the soul is watery."

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The Luminous Soul: The Flowing Freshness of Ruh

Source: CT6 · March 29, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

"There's another complementary pair, pair of modes of being. And these are the organs of the heart and of the soul."

"In Murshid's teaching and in Suluk, soul means Ruh, not Nafs, Ruh. The heart is the Qalb, and the soul is the Ruh."

THE FIERY HEART (QALB)

The heart is born from a life lived with depth, emerging from the shell of the Nafs through sympathy and fellow-feeling.

"The heart is born of a life deeply lived. It cannot come into its own when we skim the surface. It's born of pain and grace."

"There's passion in it, there's forgiveness, there's longing, a rawness that expresses an urgency... There's a fire in the heart."

THE WATERY SOUL (RUH)

"The soul stands opposite to the heart... the soul is watery. It flows. Actually, the Persian synonym for Ruh is Ravan, which means flowing."

"Whereas the heart is raw, fiery, passionate, moved by intense love, the soul is luminous, watery, extremely gentle."

"The soul is fresh-sprung, you might say, from the source. There's a nascency in it, a fresh, sheer, simple immediacy."

STRENGTHENING THE HEART

The freshness of the Ruh offers a counterpoint to the heart's intensity, bringing balance and healing.

"What strengthens the heart and stirs it from its anesthesia is the counterpoised Ruh with its fresh dawn light and its fresh dew water."

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The Subtle Centers as Portals to States of Being

Source: CT6 · March 29, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

THE FOUR CENTERS

The subtle centers, or latifas, are often understood in complementary pairs.

"The last two days we touched upon two latifas, first Nafs in the belly, and then the Khafi in the forehead, representing, uh, what you might call your personal self, your social self, your egoic self on the one hand, and your higher, mode of being, your wide vision, your deeper insight."

"Now there's another complementary pair, pair of modes of being. And these are the organs of the heart and of the soul... In Murshid's teaching and in Suluk, soul means Ruh, not Nafs, Ruh. The heart is the Qalb, and the soul is the Ruh."

These four centers correspond to the four elements:

- **Nafs** (personal self) is earthy
- **Khafi** (higher vision) is airy
- **Qalb** (heart) is fiery
- **Ruh** (soul) is watery

"Whereas the heart is raw, fiery, passionate, moved by intense love, the soul is, um, luminous, watery, extremely, um, gentle."

ENTRY POINTS INTO STATES OF BEING

While the latifas are associated with specific places in the body--the belly, forehead, left chest, and right chest--these locations are best understood as portals.

"These modes of being are not restricted to one location, but these organs that we describe, these Latif are entry points into a certain, um, state of being."

"And actually there are even different systems of Latif and different teachers identify them in different places. So there's no ultimate objectivity about, um, any system, but, um, this is the way that's come down to us and if we look for these portals in these places, we'll find them."

HOW TO OPEN THE PORTALS

We access these states of being through a gentle and respectful approach, using the breath as our medium.

"How do you open the portal in each place in the body? It's through, you knock on the door and you knock with the breath."

"And if you're going to the home of someone that you hold in high affection and esteem, you're not going to bang on the door, you're going to gently, gently knock and let the, you know, the cadence of your knock express something of your greeting to the one living inside. So that's going to show itself in the way in which we breathe in each space."

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A Contemplative Journey into a Fiery Landscape

Source: CT6 · March 29, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

A guided contemplation to *"take a break from the humdrum existence in a virtual world of pure though exhilarating phantasm."*

A NOTE OF CAUTION

This contemplation uses the imagery of fire. A gentle caution is advised for anyone who has experienced a related ordeal.

"I would advise caution… especially in this case where we're dealing with fire."

"Be easy on yourself. And I would say, you know, if you have any kind of background like that, this one just… be with us in spirit, but no need to join in this particular contemplation."

THE CONTEMPLATION

1. Begin by *"peering through a kaleidoscope,"* sparking a venture into worlds of light.

2. *"Imagine most realistically, spirals of light extending and closing in on you. Beings of light like a beacon at sea, random flashes and sparks bursting forth like fireworks."*

3. *"Give yourself over to this enthralling effulgence until you feel a spillover into your clothes, in your aura, in your eyes."*

4. *"Imagine that you are a firecracker exploding in innumerable sparks and colors, shapes and patterns, and then diffracting in a landscape of light."*

5. *"Instead of sitting and enjoying the scene, you can step into this world of light, forging forward toward a horizon of light, getting brighter and more magnificent as you advance."*

6. Experience yourself soaring above the clouds at sunrise. Feel *"the sheer ecstasy of buoyancy, of being part of this volatile skyscape."*

7. A realization dawns: *"You realize that these are the blueprints of the forms of the world, sketched in light. Their architectonic seem like structures of temples of light, inhabited by beings of light."*

THE TRANSFORMATION

"There must be some reality to it because you can observe its effect upon you."

"As you gaze in the mirror, you cannot believe what you see. You are transformed beyond recognition, radiant, glowing."

"And if you offset your glance, you will discover behind the features of your face a countenance so beautiful you cannot believe it is you and think it is an angel revealing himself or herself to you."

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The Watery Soul (Ruh) and its Cognates

Source: CT6 · March 29, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

The soul, or Ruh, is one of four subtle centers, each with its own elemental quality. Where the Nafs is earthy, the Khafi is airy, and the heart is fiery--the soul is watery.

"Heart is fiery and the soul is watery. It flows."

THE FLOWING NATURE

"Actually, the Persian synonym for Ruh is Ravan, which means flowing."

This quality is also connected to the essence of life itself, reflected in the roots of words that signify spirit.

"Atman, in German you say atem, the breath, pure breath."

OPPOSITE THE FIERY HEART

The watery soul stands in a complementary relationship to the fiery heart (Qalb).

"The soul stands opposite to the heart, whereas the heart is raw, fiery, passionate, moved by intense love. The soul is luminous, watery, extremely gentle..."

A FRESH IMMEDIACY

The soul possesses a unique quality of nascency, of being newly born from the source. It is distinct from the raw passion of the heart and the sober wisdom of the Khafi.

"The soul is fresh-sprung, you might say, from the source. There's a nascency in it, a fresh, sheer, simple immediacy, whereas the Khafi represents the sobriety that comes after intoxication."

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Embracing Pain to Open the Heart

Source: CT6 · March 29, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

THE STRATEGY OF AVOIDANCE

"The heart carries your store of emotions and that may be why so often the heart is closed down because there's too much to come to terms with there."

The protective impulse is *"to shut it down and bury it. But then things go very wrong."*

"By refusing pain, one dooms oneself to suffering."

THE UNIVERSAL GATEWAY

"Sooner or later the time will come when it will be necessary to accept the pain in the heart, allow it, sense it."

This personal pain becomes a portal to a vaster reality.

"Through that pain, sense the pain that is in all of creaturehood, and in the same flash encounter the joy that is equally omnipresent through a mood of deep solidarity with all of the beings swept along by waves of becoming."

AWAKENING THE HEART

"The fact is what strengthens the heart and stirs it from its anesthesia is the counterpoised Ruh with its fresh dawn light and its fresh dew water."

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Guided Zikr of the Syllables Ha and Hu

Source: CT6 · March 29, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

Friends, the time has come to move to the next stage of *ittisal* in our practice. We have been working with the syllable *"Ha,"* which you feel right here in the chest, connecting to your

physical and etheric body. The next stage introduces the syllable *"U"* (or *"Hu"*), which vibrates higher up, lifting energy through the throat into the skull, and aligning with the mental or astral being. This shift in vibration allows a profound identification with the universal psyche. So, let's do a few times: *"Ha. Ha. Ha. Ha. Ha. Ha. Ha. Ha. Ha. Ha. Ha. Ha. Ha. U. U. U. U. U. U. U. U. U. U. U. U. U."* This guided recitation deepens our awareness of interconnectedness, animating and sustaining our body and mind, as we come to understand that our individual mind is a part of the vast, intergalactic universal mind.

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Part I · Chapter 4

WAZIFA — WORKING WITH THE NAMES

The Ninety-Nine Names as Instruments of Transformation

The Names of God are not mere epithets but living attributes of the Divine. To repeat a Name with attention is to invite that quality to take root in the soul. This chapter gathers the wazifas given during the retreat — each a key to a particular door.

8 Entries · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

Wazifa — Murshid's Complete Teaching on the Practice

Source: CT1 · March 27, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

WHAT WAZIFA IS

"One of the practices that is central to the inner school is the practice of Wazifa. And Wazifa, as you may know, means an assignment, an assignment that is given to you and that you keep up with dedication, a daily practice. A name that is entrusted to you, a divine name given into your care."

"That this name has come down through revelation, has been passed down through the silsila, and now is given to you as a trust to, yes, to say, say it with your tongue, certainly, but more than that, to enter its field. When you have a Wazifa for that time, you enter the field of that name. You dedicate your life to beholding God through the portal of this particular name."

"A door is open to you. And as soon as that Wazifa is given and accepted, yes, you say the name diligently each day in the morning, or with some Wazifas it will be in the evening. But more than that, you live your life in the continuous presence of that divine attribute. You become the 'abd, you become the servant of that name."

MURSHID'S TEACHING — READ IN FULL BY PIR ZIA

"Every spoken word is a re-echo of thought and every thought is the re-echo of an emotion. And as the activity from within manifests on the surface, so the word spoken takes its reverse process. It is reproduced on the mind, and from the mind, it is reproduced on the heart, the factor of feeling. That which comes from within comes involuntarily, and what enters within from without enters voluntarily."

"Therefore, Wazifa is taught by Sufis as a voluntary production of a certain thing on the mind and in the heart. Mind being

powerful to produce that which is impressed upon it from within and without. As many times as a word is repeated, even in a whisper, so many records it has produced in one's mind and in the heart."

Principles of Practice (from Murshid)

Principle · Guidance

Numbers · Must be in accordance with the law of numbers — set count, regular rhythm; without consideration of numbers, rhythm and balance are lost

Moon phase · Commence during the rise of the moon (progressive trend); waning moon brings upset and confusion

Place · Same place every day creates a growing atmosphere

Time · Same time every day — invisible forces get accustomed to meet and help; without a set time, it becomes difficult to gather them

Purity · Cleanliness of body, purity of mind, fragrance, beautiful thoughts give quicker result

Diet · Flesh food is sometimes undesirable for Wazifa; disturbances of mind make it fruitless

Character · Weakness of character and an impious life ruins the life of the one who repeats Wazifa

Secrecy · Keep the Wazifa secret and its effect secret; pride of repeating should be avoided

Authorization · Must be taught by a blessed soul or permission taken from a holy person — produces a thousandfold effect

THE LIVING EXPERIENCE — PIR ZIA'S COMMENTARY

"Thoughts become words, and very often this happens without intentionality. But if we have a clear intention, we may choose a word, and not only a word, a name, not only a name, a divine name. Let it be given or let it be blessed, and then repeat it at the same time every day, as much as possible in the same place every day."

"And then the word becomes a thought, thought becomes a feeling, body, mind, heart, soul, all become aligned in the field of the quality which is an emanation of the divine nature. We do this without fanfare, it's done quietly, no one else knows."

"Beginning with the waxing moon, and when there is consistency, then the magnetism of the practice builds up. You're joined by angels and benevolent jinn. You're surrounded by whirling thought beings that are drawn to the name because they too are entrusted with it."

"And when you recite the name, you'll also recognize that name in others who are entrusted with it and those who simply embody it in one fashion or another. That name will show itself on all sides. The name will become a world."

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Meditating on a Stone: The Example of Pir Dahan

Source: CT1 · March 27, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

BE LIKE A ROCK

The spiritual stage of concentration corresponds to the element of Earth--heavy, dense, and slow. In a fast-moving world where attention is rare, this is the first medicine.

"The very first thing to learn is to slow down and be like a rock. Just learn to be fully still, fully silent, fully present."

"A rock can teach us a lot. And even spending time with a stone becomes an opportunity to emulate the stillness of the stone, the way it yields to gravity and occupies a single place."

PIR DAHAN — THE MOUTH OF THE PIR

"Sometimes the mystics meditate on stones."

"There's a very special place in California where Hazrat Inayat Khan sat on a stone. It's called Pir Dahan, the mouth of the Pir. You can still feel his vibrations there."

A stone holds this power because its nature is concentration itself.

"A stone carries an abiding vibration down through the years because its consciousness isn't scattered. It's very rooted, very stable. And so this is what we've been developing in concentration."

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Becoming the Servant (Abd) of the Name

Source: CT1 · March 27, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

When a divine name is given as a Wazifa, it is not simply a word to be recited; it is an assignment to enter its sacred field. It is a trust, a divine name given into your care. As soon as a Wazifa is given and accepted, you dedicate your life to beholding God through the portal of this particular name. Yes, you say the name diligently each day, but *"But more than that, you live your life in the continuous presence of that divine attribute. You become the Abd, you become the servant of that name."* This profound practice means allowing the divine quality of the name to permeate your entire existence, transforming your inner and outer life until the name becomes your world, and its essence is embodied in your every thought, word, and action.

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The Primal Intelligence Before Consciousness

Source: CT3 · March 28, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

INTELLIGENCE VS. CONSCIOUSNESS

"Intelligence is consciousness in its innate condition. When intelligence is presented with an object, then there is a subject and an object and a knowledge intervening between them. And this is what we would call consciousness."

"But in the most primal condition of intelligence, there is no encounter with an external object and so intelligence is simply an innate self-awareness."

IBN SINA'S FLOATING MAN

The philosopher Ibn Sina (Avicenna) proposed a thought experiment: imagine a person floating in the air with all senses closed, with no sensation at all. In the absence of ongoing stimuli, mental activity would gradually quiet down.

"And what Ibn Sina envisioned is a return of consciousness to its ground as pure intelligence."

THE JOURNEY OF THE CHILD

This process from innate intelligence to object-oriented consciousness is a gradual one, recapitulated in the development of a child.

"At first the child is very ensconced, first in the interior of the mother's body, then in the bosom. But gradually the child begins to recognize relationships between objects and see itself and recognize itself in the mirror. And then another kind of knowledge develops."

In this way, *"the whole cosmic process of becoming is reinscribed and recapitulated."*

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Zikr Practice: Invoking Ya 'Alimu, The All-Knowing

Source: CT3 · March 28, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

A contemplative Zikr to internalize the divine quality of Al-'Alim -- consciousness in its innate condition.

THE UNFOLDING OF DIVINE INTELLIGENCE

"The quality of Al-Hayy of the living, of pure being, gives rise to the quality of Al-'Alim, the knowing. First of all, self-knowing. I am."

"Intelligence is consciousness in its innate condition... in the most primal condition of intelligence, there is no encounter with an external object and so intelligence is simply an innate self-awareness."

"So intelligence is unfolding, Al-'Alim, on each plane, in the angelic plane, on the jinnic or mental plane, and in the physical plane."

THE PRACTICE OF REMEMBRANCE

This practice is a prolonged and immersive repetition of the divine name. The rhythmic invocation serves to move beyond intellectual understanding and into a direct, heart-centered experience, allowing consciousness to be saturated with the reality of the Knower.

"Ya 'Alimu, ya 'Alimu, ya 'Alimu..."

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The Power of Consistent Practice and Community

Source: CT4 · March 28, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

THE DAILY COMMITMENT

"Consistency is key in this practice. It is better to practice for a short time every day than for a long time once a week."

This daily return to the inner sanctuary builds momentum. The quality of Sabur (patience) is not just for long-term waiting, but for the daily commitment to show up for practice regardless of mood or circumstance.

"This steadfastness itself is a form of prayer that attracts the divine response."

THE AMPLIFICATION OF COMMUNITY

"Practicing within a spiritual community, a Khankah, whether physical or virtual, can greatly amplify the effect of the Wazifa."

When a group of hearts turn their focused attention (Tawajjuh) to the same divine qualities, a powerful energetic field is created.

"This collective intention can help to facilitate the opening for each individual, and the shared Baraka provides support and encouragement for everyone on the path."

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The Silsila: A Living Practice Imbued with Baraka

Source: CT4 · March 28, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

On the path of Suluk, a Wazifa given by a Murshid is a key to a vast spiritual inheritance. It is not just a formula, but a living practice supported by the entire lineage of teachers who transmitted it.

"It is a key, a tool for transformation, but it is not just a formula. It is a living practice, imbued with the Baraka, the spiritual grace, of the entire Silsila, the chain of transmission."

"When we practice it, we are not alone; we are supported by the lineage of teachers and saints who have walked this path before us."

THE SPIRITUAL INHERITANCE (WIRATHA)

This chain of transmission connects us to a spiritual inheritance that flows through the centuries.

"Through the Silsila, we are connected to a Wiratha, a spiritual inheritance, that flows from the Prophet Muhammad (peace be

upon him) and through the great saints and masters of our lineage."

"When we are given a Wazifa by our Murshid, we are being given a key to access this inheritance. The names are not mere words; they are living streams of divine energy and wisdom that have been flowing through the hearts of the lovers of God for centuries."

THE LIVING SPIRIT OF THE LINEAGE

The presence and support of the masters in our lineage are not confined to their physical lives. By engaging with their teachings, we connect with their living spirit.

"Their presence and Baraka are not confined to their physical lives. When we engage with the teachings they transmitted, we are connecting with their living spirit, and their support is available to us on the inner planes."

THE SACRED BOND OF INITIATION

The act of Bayat, or initiation, formalizes this connection and opens a direct channel for grace.

"In taking Bayat, the mureed, the student, consciously opens their heart to the guidance and Baraka of the teacher and the Silsila. This creates a sacred bond, a channel through which the grace of the lineage can flow more directly to support the student's journey."

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The Closing Prayers: Salat and Khatum

Source: CT6 · March 29, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

SALAT

"Most gracious sovereign, messenger, Messiah, savior of humanity, we greet thee with all humility."

"Thou art the first cause and the last effect, the divine light and the spirit of guidance, Alpha and Omega."

"Thy light is in all forms, thy love in all beings."

"Allow us to recognize thee in all thy holy names and forms. As in Sita and Rama, as in Radha and Krishna... as in Mary and Jesus, Khadija and Muhammad, and in many other names, holy names and forms known and unknown to the world."

"May the message of God reach far and wide, illuminating and making the whole humanity as in a single family in the parenthood of God. Amen."

KHATUM

"Thou who art the perfection of love, harmony, and beauty, the sovereign of heaven and earth, open our hearts that we may hear thy voice, which constantly cometh from within."

"Disclose to us thy divine light, which is hidden in our souls, that we may know and understand life better."

"Most merciful and compassionate God, give us thy great goodness, teach us thy loving forgiveness, raise us above the distinctions and differences which divide us. Send us the peace of thy divine spirit and unite us all in thy perfect being. Amen."

FINAL BLESSING

"May your heart be filled with heavenly joy. May your soul be illumined with divine light. May your spirit unfold the divine message. May you go on in the spiritual path. May God's peace abide with you forever and evermore. Amen."

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Part I · Chapter 5

CONTEMPLATION PRACTICES

Holding the One Reality in the Heart

At the center of the Suluk stands contemplation itself — mushahada, muraqaba, the gaze of the witness, the abiding in presence. These practices train the heart to hold a single reality until the veil between seeker and sought dissolves.

37 Entries · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

Aman and Dar al-Aman — The Realm of Sanctuary

Source: CT1 · March 27, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

Pir Zia opened the Contemplation series with an extended reflection on the state of the world and the community's response — holding prayer for Suluk members in conflict zones.

THE INTERIOR SOURCE OF SANCTUARY

"Aman isn't just something that arises outside, it arises outside because it begins in the interior life. And our intention is to create the Dar al-Aman, the realm of sanctuary beginning in our own hearts. We do this through the consideration that we have for all of God's creatures. The consideration that we show to each other in Suluk, and the intention to make every thought, every word, and every action a stone in that temple of sanctuary that we're building."

HUMANITY AS ONE FAMILY

"I know that the members of this class who are very near to falling bombs, flying drones, you've been in my prayers, and I know we've all been holding this prayer. And others have family who are in dangerous places, endangered places. And in fact, all of us have family living in danger because humanity is one family. We're all interrelated."

"And what happens to the least protected, the most aggressed against, happens really to all of us. So we keep lifting up this prayer and let's care for each other. Let's be a community that demonstrates, that embodies kindredness. We can't control what happens throughout the world, but we can create sanctuary amongst those we know, those we meet through the attitude of Aman."

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From Concentration to Contemplation — Mujahada to Muraqabah

Source: CT1 · March 27, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

Pir Zia formally named the transition using the Arabic terms and mapped the four Suluk stages to the four elements.

THE TRANSITION

"Now, we are taking a turn. We're moving from concentration to contemplation. Some of you speak Arabic or languages that use Arabic vocabulary. Concentration is sometimes called mujahada. So we've been practicing mujahada. And what comes next is Muraqabah, contemplation."

"From concentration to contemplation. So over these next few days, we'll begin to develop a sense of what contemplation is, how it differs from concentration. We have to begin with concentration, but the story doesn't end there."

THE FOUR STAGES AS FOUR ELEMENTS

Stage · Arabic · Element · Quality
Concentration · Mujahada · Earth · Heavy, dense, slow — learning to be still like a rock
Contemplation · Muraqabah · Water · The mind begins to move gracefully, artfully, purposefully
Meditation · — · Air · (To come)
Realization · — · Fire · (To come)

"Earth, as you know, is very heavy, very dense, very slow. It corresponds to concentration. And in our fast moving world where attention is so rare, it's the first medicine. The very first thing to learn is to slow down and be like a rock. Just learn to be fully still, fully silent, fully present."

"And I hope, and I believe, that over the last several months you've had the chance to deepen that capacity for stillness, focus, unperturbed attention. So we begin with concentration, but we

don't end there. And after the earth element comes the element of water."

THE TEACHING OF THE STONE — PIR DAHAN

"Rocks aren't usually given much consideration, but a rock can teach us a lot. And even spending time with a stone becomes an opportunity to emulate the stillness of the stone. The way it yields to gravity and occupies a single place. Sometimes the mystics meditate on stones."

"There's a very special place in California where Hazrat Inayat Khan sat and meditated on a stone. It's called Pir Dahan, the mouth of the Pir. You can still feel his vibrations there. A stone carries an abiding vibration down through the years because its consciousness isn't scattered. It's very rooted, very stable. And so this is what we've been developing in concentration."

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What Contemplation Is — The Mind Moves Gracefully

Source: CT1 · March 27, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

FROM STILLNESS TO PURPOSEFUL MOVEMENT

"Having been still, having been focused, focused on one object, now we're going to begin to move. The mind is going to begin to move. We didn't want the mind to move until we were present and focused because it would just move randomly, it would just react to stimuli."

"But now that we've drawn our attention in and stabilized it and deepened it, now we can let it unfold, let it find its way. And this is what contemplation does."

"So there will be more to say in the coming days and more to practice in the way of exploring what it means for the mind to

move, but not erratically, not randomly, but gracefully, artfully, purposefully. This is Muraqabah."

FROM OBJECTS TO QUALITIES — THE ARCHITECTURE OF MEANING

"And it means that we're not only going to be focusing on objects, or even the forms of objects, but something subtler still. The quality of something, the character of something, the nature of it. And this is leading us into the architecture of meaning that underlies the visible universe."

"What are the qualities of being that all things manifest in various combinations? These qualities are in fact, in their essence, the attributes of God. And the names of God invoke them."

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Closing Contemplation — Scattered Attention and the Holy of Holies

Source: CT1 · March 27, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

Pir Zia guided a closing contemplation on acknowledging scattered attention and reconnecting with sacred purpose.

THE CONTEMPLATION

"So you could just take a moment and acknowledge the ways in which you've been scattered, caught up in things that aren't really yours to attend to."

"At the time it just seems like a little thing, it was just a little extravagance, a little deviation. But, you know, pitter-patter, splish splash, the drops add up. Each little drop of kind of negligence and distraction accumulates and soon we're drowning in forgetfulness."

"So after noticing all of the distractedness, we could just take a moment and sense, you know, your real work, what you're

responsible for, even if it's hard. Just the sacredness of your sacred duty. How it's a holy thing, actually. Maybe more holy than, you know, artifacts in temples or synagogues, mosques, churches. It's the holy of holies contained in your heart, the sacred energy given to you for your opus, your work."

CLOSING RECITATION

Spoken twice — Pir Zia first, then the class joins:

"My conscientious self, consider your responsibility sacred."

"My conscientious self, consider your responsibility sacred."

"And when you're ready, we can open our eyes and it's time for our pause."

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The Living Anatomy of Divine Names

Source: CT1 · March 27, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

The qualities of being that all things manifest are, in their essence, the attributes of God--and the names of God invoke them.

"Working with the names of God, intoning them, has long been the practice of the Sufis."

"The names have come down to us down through long generations, received through revelation, communicated from heart to heart, and recited in the course of succeeding lives."

"We are fortunate to be the recipients of these oral traditions, these legacies of sacred sound carrying inspired speech that articulates the fundamental qualities of being."

A LIVING ORGANISM

To delve into the names is to discover their profound interconnectedness. There are many names, far more than the symbolic number 99.

"The names themselves form a living anatomy. They're related to each other. They branch out from each other. They interact with each other, like the organs of a living organism."

"To delve into the names is to begin to see the organicity of them, the interrelationships between them, the interplay of meanings."

JALAL, JAMAL, AND KAMAL

The names can be understood through their essential character and grouped into three primary categories.

"There are names which fall on the side of majesty and power, the Jalali names. The other names that are rather names of beauty and elegance, the Jamali names. And then names in which beauty and power merge, Kamali names."

THE MOTHER NAMES (UMMAHAT)

Among the names are seven that are considered foundational--the mothers, or matrixes, from which others unfold.

*"These are called the seven leading names, *Al-Asma as-Sab'a al-A'imma*... Also called the *Ummahat*, the mother names."*

"They unfold in sequence. And this sequence is the basis of the manner in which the universe itself has come into being. And similarly, the manner in which each of us has come into being."

"Our own microcosmic process of emergence is embedded within and reflects the larger macrocosmic process of creation."

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The Seven Mother Names (Ummahat)

Source: CT1 · March 27, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

THE MOTHER NAMES

Within the vast anatomy of divine names is a series of seven known as Al-Asma as-Sab'a al-A'imma, the seven leading names.

"Also called the Ummahat, the mother names, the mothers. They are matrixes."

"They unfold in sequence. And this sequence is the basis of the manner in which the universe itself has come into being. And similarly, the manner in which each of us has come into being."

"Our own microcosmic process of emergence is embedded within and reflects the larger macrocosmic process of creation."

THE ASSIGNMENT OF WAZIFA

The central practice for working with a divine name is Wazifa.

"Wazifa... it means an assignment, an assignment that is given to you. And that you keep up with dedication, a daily practice, a name that is entrusted to you, a divine name given into your care."

"When you have a Wazifa for that time, you enter the field of that name. You dedicate your life to beholding God through the portal of this particular name... You become the Abd, you become the servant of that name."

CONDITIONS FOR PRACTICE

"As many times as a word is repeated, even in a whisper, so many records it has produced in one's mind and in the heart."

To give the practice a *"quicker result,"* several conditions create rhythm, balance, and a growing atmosphere:

1. **Rhythm and Balance** -- *"The repetition of the same number every day or a regular increase or decrease in number, set in time, shows rhythm, and in rhythm, there is balance."*
2. **Timing with Nature** -- *"A Wazifa commenced during the rise of the moon has a progressive trend because it is in harmony with nature's tide."*

3. **Consistency of Place** -- *"Sitting in the same place every day when repeating the Wazifa helps because it creates a growing atmosphere every day."*
4. **Consistency of Time** -- *"Repeating Wazifa at the same time every day is also desirable because the invisible forces get accustomed to meet and help at the same time."*
5. **Purity and Atmosphere** -- *"Cleanliness of body and purity of mind and fragrance around and beautiful thoughts in the mind are the things which give a quicker result."*
6. **Secrecy** -- *"The pride of repeating Wazifa should be avoided. It should be secret, and its effect should be kept a secret also."*
7. **Blessing** -- *"Wazifa should be taught by some blessed soul... By doing so, a Wazifa produces a thousandfold effect because there is some powerful thought working with you at the time."*

THE NAME BECOMES YOUR WORLD

"And when there is consistency, then the magnetism of the practice builds up. You're joined by angels and benevolent jinn. You're surrounded by a whirling morass, thought beings that are drawn to the name because they too are entrusted with it."

"And when you recite the name, you'll also recognize that name in others who are entrusted with it... That name will show itself on all sides. The name will become your world. This is the meaning of Wazifa."

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Entering the Field of a Name: The Practice of Wazifa

Source: CT1 · March 27, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

A DIVINE TRUST

One of the central practices of the inner school is Wazifa.

"Wazifa, as you may know, it means an assignment, an assignment that is given to you. And that you keep up with dedication, a daily practice, a name that is entrusted to you, a divine name given into your care."

"Well, that is an extraordinary thing that this name has come down through revelation, has been passed down through the Silsila, and now is given to you as a trust to, yes, to say it with your tongue, certainly, but more than that, to enter its field."

ENTERING THE FIELD

"When you have a Wazifa for that time, you enter the field of that name. You dedicate your life to beholding God through the portal of this particular name. The door is open to you."

With a Wazifa, you do more than recite the name each day.

"You live your life in the continuous presence of that divine attribute. You become the Abd, you become the servant of that name."

THE NAME BECOMES YOUR WORLD

With consistent practice, the magnetism builds. You are joined by unseen helpers drawn to the quality of the name.

"And when you recite the name, you'll also recognize that name in others who are entrusted with it, and those who simply embody it in one fashion or another. That name will show itself on all sides."

"The name will become your world. This is the meaning of Wazifa."

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The Sacred Conditions for Wazifa

Source: CT1 · March 27, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

WHAT IS WAZIFA?

Wazifa is a central practice of the inner school.

"Wazifa, as you may know, means an assignment -- an assignment that is given to you. And that you keep up with dedication, a daily practice, a name that is entrusted to you, a divine name given into your care."

It is more than recitation; it is an immersion. *"When you have a Wazifa for that time, you enter the field of that name. You dedicate your life to beholding God through the portal of this particular name... You become the Abd, you become the servant of that name."*

THE CONDITIONS FOR PRACTICE

For the practice to be effective, certain conditions must be observed.

Number and Rhythm

"The repetition of the same number every day or a regular increase or decrease in number, set in time, shows rhythm, and in rhythm, there is balance."

Consistency of Time and Place

"Sitting in the same place every day when repeating the Wazifa helps because it creates a growing atmosphere every day."

"Repeating Wazifa at the same time every day is also desirable because the invisible forces get accustomed to meet and help at the same time. Without a set time, it becomes difficult to gather them."

Purity of Atmosphere

"Cleanliness of body and purity of mind and fragrance around and beautiful thoughts in the mind are the things which give a quicker result."

Secrecy

"The pride of repeating Wazifa should be avoided. It should be secret, and its effect should be kept a secret also."

Permission from a Teacher

"Wazifa should be taught by some blessed soul, or a permission should be taken from a holy person before repeating a Wazifa. By doing so, a Wazifa produces a thousandfold effect because there is some powerful thought working with you at the time, which undoubtedly speeds the success."

THE WORLD OF THE NAME

When these conditions are met, the practice creates a powerful magnetism. The word becomes a thought, the thought a feeling, and the entire being aligns with the divine quality of the name.

"When there is consistency, then the magnetism of the practice builds up. You're joined by angels and benevolent jinn."

"That name will show itself on all sides. The name will become your world. This is the meaning of Wazifa."

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The Seven Lata'if: A Spectrum from the Ephemeral to the Eternal

Source: CT2 · March 27, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

THE SUBTLE ANATOMY

"A Latifa is a subtle organ. Just as the visible physical body has its various organs, there is a subtler anatomy underlying our flesh and blood."

That underlying anatomy *"stands arrayed as a spectrum that mediates between the individualized physical embodiment that we call this body and the timeless, the placeless, the unconditioned."*

THE PILGRIMAGE OF LIFE

"The seven Lata'if are ranged between the poles of the ephemeral and the eternal. And they're also markers in the pilgrimage of life, the journey of being…"

This is a journey *"in which body loses itself in transcendence, and then the soul that has always been in us reveals itself and how then we are shown how this earthly self is an avatar of the soul, an incarnation of the soul."*

THE SPIRAL PATH

"The Lata'if describe this spiral and also at each moment of the journey, inscribe within us the perpetual presence of each mode…"

"All of these stations are really facets of one Ayn, one essence that is our life forever in God."

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The Nafs: The Providential Role of the Personal Self

Source: CT2 · March 27, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

THE CONDITION OF "ME, ME"

The Nafs is the personal self, the ego. In the subcontinent, they observe that the goats are always saying, *"Meh, meh,"* which in Hindi-Urdu means *"Me, me."*

"We're the ones that are really always thinking, me, me, what about me? Me first. Let me have the last word."

"You know, this constant I, me, my preferences, getting the best seat, that's one condition that the Nafs finds itself in."

While it can be difficult to step out of this narrow circle, this little self is not something to be simply discarded.

THE PROVIDENTIAL ROLE

"Actually, this personal self, this little self, it also has a providential role. It's part of our story."

The personal self is the vessel for our journey into the world. It is *"the means by which the soul enters into the unfolding story of creation, partaking of joys and sorrows."*

A GATEWAY TO THE HEART

The experience of personal suffering is what allows for the development of compassion and solidarity.

"If we have a self that can suffer, then the next step is to see there's another self that could also suffer, my friend, my neighbor. And seeing that suffering, having compassion, having sympathy, because one knows what it's like to be afraid or to be hurt."

This shared experience--this intimacy among selves--opens the way to what we call the heart. The heart cannot be reached without first traversing the Nafs.

"You couldn't have the heart without the Nafs first of all. The soul reaches the heart through the Nafs."

THE SOFTENING

For the soul's journey through the self to the heart to take place, the Nafs must transform.

"But for that traversal to occur, the Nafs needs to soften, needs to open, needs to, most essentially, see the self in every other self, not only see its own self."

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The Evolution of the Self: From Ammara to Mutma'inna

Source: CT2 · March 27, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

"The person who wears a name, who has a business card, a social media profile, that's the Nafs. It is you and it isn't you. It's not all of you, but it's one expression of the journey that is your being."

This personal self is not static--it is part of a developmental journey. The Nafs goes through stages of unfoldment.

THE STAGES OF UNFOLDMENT

1. **Nafs al-Ammara — The Imperious Self**

This is the stage where one is *"imperious... intent on telling everyone what to do and having your way."*

2. **Nafs al-Lawwama — The Accountable Self**

The self becomes *"self-reflective, seeing the consequence of your actions."* In this stage, one comes to feel one's own responsibility and accountability in everything one does.

3. **Nafs al-Mutma'inna — The Tranquil Self**

This is the state of being that emerges beyond the duality of the first two stages--a state of *"steady, clear-sighted, tranquil, wise agency."*

BEYOND THE PENDULUM SWING

The journey from the imperious to the accountable self is not always a straight line.

"There can be a pendulum swing between Ammara and Lawwama, you know, demanding satisfaction and then retreating in shame and and guilt."

"Beyond the swing of the pendulum is steady, clear-sighted, tranquil, wise agency."

A MALLEABLE AND INTERCONNECTED SELF

The most important thing to remember is that the self is not fixed.

"And it's malleable. That's the important thing to remember. It's malleable."

This transformation is not a solitary process. It is *"a great wonder of life, the way in which contact with a self that is moving from Ammara to Lawwama, from Lawwama to Mutma'inna, encourages your own movement."*

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The Lata'if as a Journey to the One Essence (Ayn)

Source: CT2 · March 27, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

THE PILGRIMAGE OF LIFE

The seven Lata'if are markers in the pilgrimage of life, ranged between the poles of the ephemeral and the eternal.

This is *"the journey of being, in which body loses itself in transcendence, and then the soul that has always been in us reveals itself."*

We are shown how this earthly self is an avatar of the soul--embedded in vast historical, geological, and biological processes. This journey is a *"flowering in the birth of a heart that yearns for the ineffable, and how just beyond the heart's yearning, there is a serenity that takes in all of the surrounding horizons."*

FACETS OF ONE ESSENCE

Ultimately, this pilgrimage reveals a profound unity.

"all of these stations are really facets of one Ayn, one essence that is our life forever in God."

"The Lata'if describe this spiral and also at each moment of the journey, inscribe within us the perpetual presence of each mode within the tricosm."

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The 'Me, Me' of the Nafs: An Illustrative Story

Source: CT2 · March 27, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

THE GOATS OF INDIA

"There's a funny observation in India... you know, the goats, what do the goats say? Meh, meh."

"Well, in, in, um, Hindi, Urdu, meh means me, me. So they're always saying, me, me."

THE NARROW CIRCLE OF SELF

"But the goats themselves aren't actually as self-conscious as we are."

"We're the ones that are really always thinking, me, me, what about me? Me first. Let me have the last word."

"You know, this constant I, me, my preferences, getting the best seat, that's one condition that the Nafs finds itself in."

"And we all, you know, know what it's like to live that way, and we know that it can be difficult to step out of that very narrow little circle, even when we want to step out of it."

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From Ice to Water: A Metaphor for Contemplation

Source: CT2 · March 27, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

In our practice, concentration involves holding an object with the mind, a firm grasp. Contemplation, however, invites a profound shift, transforming our engagement into a more fluid and receptive state. As Murshid teaches, *"Concentration is earthlike in a way, and, um, the object really feels like an object. It has a certain density, a certain heaviness, like something frozen, a*

piece of ice... But then in the sunlight, the ice begins to melt. It's, it turns to water, it flows through your fingers... it's leading you somewhere. That's contemplation, from the solid state to the liquid state." This fluid state allows the object to reveal itself, unfolding its meaning and offering unexpected insights. It transforms our attention from active grasping to an encounter of mutual revelation.

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Contemplating a Difficult Person as a Pattern of Thought

Source: CT2 · March 27, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

In contemplation, we learn to shift our perception from rigid *"things"* to living *"ideas,"* especially when navigating interpersonal challenges. *"Suppose you're having trouble with a certain person. You know, one level is of reacting is just to think, well, I don't like that person. But a deeper perspective would be, well, that person is, um, entertaining a certain mentality, and it isn't only exclusive to themself, and in fact, I myself have within me some traces of that mentality."* This realization allows us to move beyond viewing individuals as isolated problems, instead perceiving shared patterns and qualities that are woven into the fabric of manifestation. We then consciously engage with the constituents of consciousness, fostering deeper self-awareness.

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The Divine Longing of the Hidden Treasure

Source: CT3 · March 28, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

I WAS A HIDDEN TREASURE

The entire universe is born from a divine impulse -- a love that moves being from hiddenness to manifestation.

"Kuntu kanzan makhfiyyan fa ahbabtu an 'urafa fa khalaqtu-l khalqa. I was a hidden treasure and I longed to be known. And so created the world that I might be known."

"The names were hidden and unknown, unfelt, unseen, unheard. And a longing arose."

THE STATE OF HIDDENNESS (WAHDAT)

Before creation, there is a plane of absolute unity and silence, a state of unexpressed potentiality.

"There is a plane of being called Wahdat. In Wahdat, the treasure is hidden. The silence is absolute. There is no here or there, before or after. Everything that would ever be already is, but without any expression."

"And in that abyss of perfect fullness -- a fullness that was an emptiness, an emptiness that was a fullness, when all was hidden... until a yearning arose. Ahbabtu, I loved. Ishq arose, yearning, longing."

A DOUBLE PRAYER

This primordial impulse is not a singular movement, but a mutual yearning from the heart of reality.

"It was the yearning of all that was hidden in the treasure. The names desired their own existentiation. The a'yan, could say the eyes of all those destined to become creatures, sought to open to the names and witness the names."

"It was a double prayer."

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Creation as a Perpetual Unfurling

Source: CT3 · March 28, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

"Creation didn't happen long ago, it happens perpetually."

THE YEARNING TO BE KNOWN

The driving force of this perpetual creation is *Ishq* -- a divine yearning.

"There is a plane of being called Wahdat. In Wahdat, the treasure is hidden. The silence is absolute. There is no here or there, before or after. Everything that would ever be already is, but without any expression."

"There was a silence that was unruffled by the slightest vibration until a yearning arose. Ahbabtu, I loved. Ishq arose, yearning, longing."

THE COSMIC PROGRESSION

This yearning causes the One Being to move through distinct stages of emergence and self-awareness.

"In Wahdat there is really speaking no being or non-being. In Ahadiyyat, emergence, being begins to feel itself, begins to surge, leading to Wahdaniyyat or Wahidiyyat when the one being reaches self-awareness."

This is the moment of the divine declaration: *"I am."*

FROM BEING TO KNOWING

The cosmic progression is mirrored in the unfolding of the divine qualities.

"The quality of Al-Hayy of the living, of pure being, gives rise to the quality of Al-'Alim, the knowing. First of all, self-knowing. I am."

"And in the self-knowing of I am comes the recognition of all that the divine I contains, all of the qualities. They emerge into knownness, unfurling. And in this unfurling, the universe begins to take shape."

Its paradigm is the cosmic person, *"the template of all that would take form… the witness of the divine names and the embodiment of the divine names."*

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The Soul's Descent and the River of Forgetfulness

Source: CT3 · March 28, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

THE JOURNEY OF DESCENT

"Each of us is a fraction of the cosmic person. The cosmic person has undergone what might be called a descent, a nuzul, from the spiritual world to the mental world and from the mental world to the physical world."

"Of course, these aren't different places. The three different modes of experiencing the same place."

THE RIVER OF FORGETFULNESS

"We as fractions of the cosmic person are thus swept along from the spiritual world into the mental world, from the mental world into the physical world. Along the way, we have at intervals undergone a certain forgetting, ghafla."

"In the legends of the Greeks, this experience is denoted by the symbol of a river called Lethe. And Lethe is the river of forgetfulness and anyone who would pass through that river would lose their memories."

"Now when the consciousness that is a fraction of the cosmic person passes from the spiritual world, having been an angel, into the mental world, becoming a jinn, there is a process of forgetting that takes place. The soul forgets its angelic identity. And becomes fully a mental being."

"And then when the mental being undergoes descent into the physical world, similarly it passes through a transition that

involves forgetting. All of us to some extent forget in the process of being born."

THE PATH OF REDISCOVERY

"The divine qualities that were experienced in the angelic realm have to be rediscovered in the mental realm and once again in the physical realm. We are the inheritors, as all beings are, of all of the divine qualities."

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We Are Fractions of the Cosmic Person

Source: CT3 · March 28, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

A WORK OF UNTANGLING

Every desire has at its origin a divine impulse. But that ray, that expression of a divine quality, has become confused in us--narrowed down, contorted, tangled up. Our spiritual practice is a work of untangling.

"The same quantity of thread could either be a tangled jumble or an exquisite tapestry."

The task is to take all of our experience and disentangle it: finding the threads, untying the knots, stretching out the threads, identifying them, and then weaving them beautifully.

THE ULTIMATE RAISON D'ÊTRE

"The divine qualities are seeking their expression in this universe. This universe was made for this. We were born for this."

All of reality is in a process of articulating the divine nature. This is the ultimate purpose of our existence.

"The ultimate raison d'être of our being is this witnessing, this adoring, this glorifying, this return of the one to the one through the many."

THE ANALOGY OF THE WOMB

This cosmic process is mirrored in our own physical becoming.

"You can see the process in embryology. Think of how once you were an embryo in the womb and you floated in the amniotic fluid and the primary sensation was of life itself."

"That life was sustained for you. Actually, the womb is, the word in Arabic is rahm, rahm. Rahman and Rahim come from this. The compassion, the mercy that brought forth this world."

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The Double Prayer: Divine Names and the A'yan

Source: CT3 · March 28, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

"Kuntu kanzan makhfiyyan fa ahbabtu an 'urafa fa khalaqtu-l khalqa. I was a hidden treasure and I longed to be known. And so created the world that I might be known."

"The names were hidden and unknown, unfelt, unseen, unheard. And a longing arose."

THE YEARNING OF THE NAMES

This divine longing was a double prayer. From one side, it was the yearning of all that was hidden within the treasure.

"The names desired their own existentiation."

THE YEARNING OF THE A'YAN

From the other side, there was a corresponding yearning from that which was not yet manifest--the latent essences of all beings, known as the *a'yan.*

"The a'yan, could say the eyes of all those destined to become creatures, sought to open to the names and witness the names."

"It was a double prayer. A yearning arose and the one being began to feel beingness."

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The Burning Bush and Divine Self-Awareness

Source: CT3 · March 28, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

FROM UNITY TO SELF-AWARENESS

The cosmic journey unfolds from *Wahdat* (unity), through *Ahadiyyat* (emergence), to the moment the One Being reaches self-awareness.

"In Wahdat there is really speaking no being or non-being. In Ahadiyyat, emergence, being begins to feel itself, begins to surge, leading to Wahdaniyyat or Wahidiyyat when the one being reaches self-awareness."

THE PRIMORDIAL UTTERANCE

This dawning of consciousness is expressed in the story of Moses and the burning bush.

"I am. The word spoken in the divine voice through the burning bush in the story of Moses, peace be upon him. Ahyeh asher ahyeh. I am that I am."

THE LIVING BECOMES THE KNOWING

This primordial declaration signifies the transition from pure being to self-knowing being--the foundational moment from which creation unfurls.

"And in this way, the quality of Al-Hayy of the living, of pure being, gives rise to the quality of Al-'Alim, the knowing. First of all, self-knowing. I am."

"And in the self-knowing of I am comes the recognition of all that the divine I contains, all of the qualities. They emerge into knownness, unfurling. And in this unfurling, the universe begins to take shape."

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A Heart-Centered Meditation on the Rosebud

Source: CT4 · March 28, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

THE PRACTICE

A meditation centered in the heart using the Wazifa *Ya Fattah, Ya Wahhab, Ya Sabur* (The Opener, The Bestower, The Patient).

1. Bring awareness to the heart center.
2. With each breath, practice Hosh dar dam — awareness in the breath.
3. Silently, in the heart, repeat the Wazifa.
4. *"You can visualize your heart as a tightly closed rosebud, holding all of its potential within."*

NURTURING THE ROSEBUD

As you repeat the divine names, feel their qualities acting upon this inner bud.

"Imagine that the sound vibration and the divine qualities they represent are like sunlight and gentle rain upon this bud. Ya Fattah is the warmth that encourages the petals to unfurl. Ya Wahhab is the dew that nourishes it from within. And Ya Sabur is the deep-rootedness that keeps it stable and grounded throughout the process."

"The opening is the release of the soul's unique fragrance into the world."

UNVEILING, BESTOWAL, AND STEADFASTNESS

This practice connects us to a profound spiritual process of transformation. The opening is an unveiling, the gift is nearness, and the patience is the substance of the journey itself.

"The opening of Fattah is also related to the experience of Kashf, or unveiling. It is the opening of the inner senses, the perception of realities that are normally veiled from our ordinary consciousness. It is a shift from seeing the form to perceiving the meaning that shines through the form."

"The gift of Wahhab is ultimately the gift of nearness to the Giver... the bestowal of divine qualities upon the Abd, the servant, so that the servant may become a clearer mirror for the attributes of the Lord."

"Sabur, patience, is the very substance of Mujahada, the spiritual struggle... Without Sabur, the path is impossible, for the journey is long and the ego is ever-resistant to its own transformation."

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Power, Beauty, and Perfection: Jalal, Jamal, and Kamal

Source: CT4 · March 28, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

THE THREE ASPECTS OF DIVINE MANIFESTATION

"These three names also correspond to the three primary aspects of the divine manifestation: Jalali, Jamali, and Kamali."

"Ya Fattah, the Opener, has a quality of Jalal, or divine power and majesty; it is the force that can break through any barrier."

"Ya Wahhab, the Bestower, is pure Jamal, the divine beauty and generosity that gives endlessly."

"Ya Sabur, the Patient, represents Kamal, the perfection and equilibrium that holds the tension between power and beauty in perfect balance."

PATIENCE — THE SUBSTANCE OF THE PATH

"Sabur, patience, is the very substance of Mujahada, the spiritual struggle."

"It is the steadfastness required to remain present with oneself, to witness the agitations of the lower self without being swept away by them. It is the endurance to continue polishing the mirror of the heart, day after day, even when it seems covered in the dust of the world."

"Without Sabur, the path is impossible, for the journey is long and the ego is ever-resistant to its own transformation."

ALIGNING WITH DIVINE REALITY

"This practice is a profound exercise in aligning the will of the Abd, the servant, with the will of Haqq, the divine Reality."

"We express our desire for opening, but we leave the timing and the nature of that opening to the Opener. We express our need for a gift, but we trust the Bestower to know what gift is best. And we commit to patience, acknowledging that our timeline is not the divine timeline."

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The Practice of Sama: Opening the Heart Through Music

Source: CT4 · March 28, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

While the Wazifa is a direct invocation, the divine Opener, Ya Fattah, can also be invoked through other profound spiritual practices. One such powerful avenue for heart-opening is the practice of Sama. *"The practice of Sama, listening to spiritual music and poetry, is another powerful means of invoking Fattah. The harmony of the melody, the rhythm of the drum, and the meaning of the sacred words can bypass the rational mind and speak directly to the soul."* This ecstatic state allows the heart to suddenly open, facilitating a profound experience of

unity and love. Through Sama, we invite a direct and intuitive opening, preparing the vessel of our being for the divine grace of Wahhab.

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Khatam: Sealing the Baraka of a Practice

Source: CT4 · March 28, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

After cultivating a sacred state during meditation, it is vital to consciously preserve its spiritual essence as we transition back to daily life. *"At the end of our meditation, we perform a Khatam, a seal. This is a concluding prayer or a moment of silent intention to seal the Baraka of the practice within our hearts, so that it is not dissipated when we return to our worldly activities. It is like placing a lid on a precious perfume to preserve its fragrance."* This conscious act helps to integrate the spiritual state into our being, allowing its profound effects to continue unfolding within us long after our formal practice concludes. It ensures that the peace, patience, and openness cultivated in meditation inform our character and guide our interactions with the world.

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Al-Qadir: The Divine Power in Cosmos and Self

Source: CT5 · March 29, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

THE GREAT FLARING FORTH

Following the emergence of life (Al-Hayy) and knowing (Al-Alim) is Al-Qadir, The Powerful.

"In the genesis of the universe, it's evident in the great flaring forth, that unleashing of intense energy from which in time the stars were born. An energy so intense that by comparison with it, the stars could be called ice cubes."

This is a state of raw, protean power, an immense and extravagant potentiality. *"So searingly hot that no form could cohere yet, no molecules or even atoms, just protean power."*

THE AWAKENING OF AGENCY

This same sequence unfolds in the development of the human self. After the dawning of knowing comes the realization of power.

"With that knowing then comes a sense of power. I am. First the baby is more or less lost in its mother, but learns to recognize itself, assert itself, and test its powers."

This is the stage of discovering personal agency, of realizing one can act upon the world. *"If something can be thrown off the table so that it smashes on the ground, then it will do just that. And suddenly the whole world has changed. It has changed the world."*

This includes the simple, profound act of negation: *"Learning to say no, and not only to say no when you don't want something, but just to say no for the sake of saying no. It's just an exercise in power."*

A PARTICIPATION IN DIVINE POWER

This personal power is not separate from the divine, but is a direct participation in that primordial, cosmic energy.

"Each of us has a hand in the making of this world. That's no small thing. It's our participation in the power which is the power of all powers."

"Whatever we do or say is mobilized by energy that we can't claim to be ours in any exclusive way... It's that original energy

of Al-Qadir. Whatever we do, we're participating in a very ancient energy… it's really God's own power."

"How strange and wonderful to be partakers in this cosmic power unleashed by the divine longing."

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Al-Murid: The Divine Will and Desire

Source: CT5 · March 29, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

After the realization of power comes the question of its use. Once power exists, it seeks direction, and this direction is given by will and desire.

"The divine name Qadir ushers in the name that comes after it, which is Murid, the willing, the wishing, the desiring. First the powerful, then the desiring."

FROM POWER TO DESIRE

In the development of the human being, the awakening of power is followed by the question of what to do with it.

"The child over time comes to see that after throwing porridge on the ground once and twice and three times, it's no longer so interesting and the question becomes, how to use this power? If I can do anything, or at least I can do some things, what ought I do? What do I want to do? What outcomes could I envision? What am I looking for? And this line of questions opens up the next divine name, Al-Murid, the desirer."

THE COSMIC LONGING

This same impulse is at work in the cosmos, a restless, creative force that drives evolution, forming solar systems and complex life forms.

"Matter is weaving itself and re-weaving itself, mutating, taking turns that lead to cul-de-sacs, but other turns that lead to

remarkable leaps in complexity. All by way of an exploration of what is wanted. Al-Murid."

"This restless desire is quivering in all of the molecules of creation, stirring new possibilities."

We are not just participants in divine power, but in this divine creative longing.

"We are partakers not only in the divine power, but also in the divine creative longing, Irada. Irada, desire."

THE SEEKER IS GOD

The spiritual path can be seen as a school where we learn to understand, purify, and align our personal desires with this universal, divine will.

"It's no coincidence that an initiate in the inner school is known as a Murid. A seeker, a lover. That is the meaning of Murid. And as we know, this is a divine name, which if one is paying close attention, tells one something from the very beginning… That which is hinted at the beginning will become more clear in the end. But that is that the seeker is God."

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The Murid: The Seeker is God

Source: CT5 · March 29, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

In the cosmic sequence of divine qualities, sheer potency and raw power, *Al-Qadir*, gives way to the emergence of will and purpose. This is the quality of *Al-Murid*--the Willing, the Wishing, the Desiring.

"First the powerful, then the desiring."

"This restless desire is quivering in all of the molecules of creation, stirring new possibilities."

A SCHOOL OF LOVE

We are not separate from this cosmic unfolding; we are its participants. The journey of the self mirrors this movement from power to purpose, from *"I can"* to *"What do I want?"*

"And we are partakers not only in the divine power, but also in the divine creative longing, Irada. Irada, desire."

This longing, when unrefined, can become tangled and lead to dissatisfaction. The spiritual path is a process of learning to align our individual will with its divine source.

"So the world becomes a school of love where we learn lessons along the way, learn how to love, learn to clarify our desire, clarify it, and empower it and focus it and align with it."

THE SECRET IN THE NAME

The name for a spiritual seeker, a Sufi initiate, holds the key to this entire process.

"It's no coincidence that an initiate in the inner school is known as a Murid. A seeker, a lover. That is the meaning of Murid. And as we know, this is a a divine name, which if one is paying close attention, tells one something from the very beginning."

This shared name reveals the ultimate truth of the path.

"That which is hinted at the beginning will become more clear in the end. But that is that the seeker is God."

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From Power to Will: The Emergence of Desire

Source: CT5 · March 29, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

"The dispensation is quite a remarkable thing for all of us, to have been given agency. Each of us has a hand in the making of this world. That's no small thing."

PARTICIPATION IN DIVINE POWER (AL-QADIR)

This agency is our participation in Al-Qadir, The Powerful--the power which is the power of all powers.

"Whatever we do, we're participating in a very ancient energy. And as we know, energy cannot be created or destroyed, it just surges through us. We can partake of it, but it's really God's own power. How strange and wonderful to be partakers in this cosmic power unleashed by the divine longing."

THE QUESTION OF WILL (AL-MURID)

At first, this is like an infant testing its powers, *"just doing something for the sake of it."*

"If something can be thrown off the table so that it smashes on the ground, then it will do just that. And suddenly the whole world has changed. It has changed the world."

But the exercise of power for its own sake is a stage. Over time, *"it's no longer so interesting and the question becomes, how to use this power? If I can do anything, or at least I can do some things, what ought I do? What do I want to do? What outcomes could I envision? What am I looking for?"*

"And this line of questions opens up the next divine name, Al-Murid, the desirer."

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Being in Two Worlds at Once

Source: CT5 · March 29, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

Having explored the experience of rising above birth and death through our breath, we now turn to the art of dwelling in two realities simultaneously. The practice is to integrate the boundless with the immediate. It's about maintaining an awareness of the eternal while fully engaging with the present.

"Let's see if you can be on two levels at once, beyond birth and death, but also right here, right now, in the room, your feet on the ground." This calls us to consciously inhabit our primordial being, recognizing that we are continuously getting here from the divine source, even as we stand grounded in our physical existence. Such dual awareness allows us to experience the depth of our spiritual origin without losing touch with the reality of our earthly journey, fostering a truly integrated life.

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Integrating Contemplation into a Busy Life

Source: CT6 · March 29, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

THE PARADOX OF A BUSY LIFE

In a life with no end to responsibilities, it is easy to feel too tired for even ten minutes of contemplation. Yet this exhaustion is precisely the reason it is so necessary.

"The question, especially in the West where life is so busy… is if contemplation, even only for 10 minutes in the evening, is not too much when we are tired."

"The answer is that for that very reason… contemplation is required more… Just because we're busy and we're tired, is that a reason not to give ourselves the chance to practice contemplation? On the contrary, one could see it as all the more reason for needing it."

THE MEAL ANALOGY

A formal practice session is like eating a meal, while the spiritual nourishment sustains you throughout the entire day.

"We take our food at certain times every day. Yet all the time, even when we are sleeping, the food nourishes our body."

"The explicit practice of reciting the name and thinking of the name, that's like the meal, but then all through the day one is digesting it and it's feeding the cells and it's nourishing you. And that happens when the name continues to live in your consciousness, even if you're not reciting it, it's there. It's feeding your blood."

THE GOAL IS INTEGRATION, NOT SECLUSION

Contemplation is not meant to be a separate, isolated activity. Its purpose is to infuse and inspire every aspect of life.

"If contemplation does not develop in such a form that everything one does in life becomes a contemplation, then contemplation does not do a person any good."

"It is not the Sufi's idea to retire in seclusion or to sit silent all day. The idea is that by contemplation, one must be so inspired... that progress is attained in every aspect of life."

SPIRITUAL FOOD FOR YOUR LIFE'S MISSION

Instead of taking more of your time and energy, contemplation delivers fresh energy that empowers your purpose in the world.

"You might find that the wazifa actually, instead of just taking more of your time and energy, it it empowers you. It it delivers fresh energy that can empower your life's mission."

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The Enduring Nourishment of Spiritual Practice

Source: CT6 · March 29, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

THE NEED FOR PRACTICE IN A BUSY LIFE

"The question, especially in the West where life is so busy and where there is no end to responsibilities, is if contemplation,

even only for 10 minutes in the evening, is not too much when we are tired."

The answer is that for this very reason, contemplation is required more, not less.

"Just because we're busy and we're tired, is that a reason not to give ourselves the chance to practice contemplation? On the contrary, one could see it as all the more reason for needing it. So busy, so preoccupied, so exhausted, a greatest need may indeed be letting our mind be with something, be with one theme, be with a particular quality, and let it wash over you, let it fill you, let it enliven you, rather than being so scattered constantly."

THE MEAL AND ITS DIGESTION

Contemplation is like spiritual food, which nourishes the being long after the meal is over.

"We take our food at certain times every day. Yet all the time, even when we are sleeping, the food nourishes our body."

The fragmentary experiences of daily life are like fast food, quickly eaten. Contemplation offers slow-cooked nourishment, mindfully received.

"The explicit practice of reciting the name and thinking of the name, that's like the meal, but then all through the day one is digesting it and it's feeding the cells and it's nourishing you."

WHAT TRULY ENDURES

"Yes, we are all very busy and yet so much of the busyness of what we're involved in is just going to turn to dust and what will be left of it? Very little."

"At the end of this life, what endures is what we've assimilated, what we've digested, what has really nourished our spiritual bones and that's what we've given care to, given love to."

The wazifa—our spiritual practice—is this essential food. Instead of just taking time and energy, it delivers fresh energy that can empower your life's mission.

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The Ittisal Practice: Shifting from Body to Mind

Source: CT6 · March 29, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

STAGE ONE: THE SOUND "HA" — PHYSICAL & ETHERIC ATTUNEMENT

The first stage of the ittisal practice works with the syllable *"ha"*.

"The ah. That you feel right here in the chest. Undoubtedly, it's vibrating the chest."

"There's a kind of clearing of the chest when you make that sound... it expands the lungs, quickens the circulation, wonderful sensation."

"As you're doing that, you're tuning into your embeddedness within the cosmos... You feel that interconnectedness animating and sustaining your body. And not only the physical body, the underlying etheric body, called the nasama."

STAGE TWO: THE SOUND "HU" — THE SHIFT TO THE MENTAL

The practice evolves by adding the vowel *"u"* to create the sound *"hu"*.

1. After sounding *"ha,"* introduce the vowel *"u"*.
2. Notice how the vibration shifts. *"The ha is here, but if you say u, it's up here. It's higher up."*
3. Feel the energy lift from the chest, *"through the throat, all the way up through the concavity of the mouth into the interior of the skull."*

4. Recognize the corresponding inner shift. *"With that shift, there's a shift in identification from the physical and subtle physical or etheric to the mental, which is also called the astral."*

THE UNIVERSAL MIND (NAFS-I-KULL)

This shift opens an awareness of the mind's place within a vaster consciousness.

"Now you are identifying your mental being, your psyche, as a fraction of the universal psyche, which is called the Nafs-i-kull."

"Our mind could never be what it is if it wasn't for our education and acculturation and ongoing communication with many other minds. It's a node within a vast web, a web of minds."

"As if your brain is one little neuron in a vast intergalactic brain. And whatever one is part of, one has access to."

"What I call 'my little mind' is mine, but also the universal mind is also my mind. It's my great mind. It's yours just as much as the little mind is yours."

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Why the West Needs Contemplation More Than Ever

Source: CT6 · March 29, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

THE QUESTION OF BUSYNESS

A question often arises, especially in modern life where there is no end to responsibilities: when we are tired from a busy day, is adding even ten minutes of contemplation too much?

"The answer is that for that very reason, in the West, contemplation is required more than in the East, where everything, even the surroundings, is helpful to contemplation."

The fatigue and distraction of a hyper-industrialized world are not reasons to avoid contemplation--they are the very reasons it is so desperately needed.

"So busy, so preoccupied, so exhausted, a greatest need may indeed be letting our mind be with something, be with one theme, be with a particular quality, and let it wash over you, let it fill you, let it enliven you, rather than being so scattered constantly."

CONTEMPLATION AS NOURISHMENT

For the practice to be effective, it cannot be isolated from the rest of life. It must become a source of nourishment that sustains you throughout the day.

"A person who gives 10 or 20 minutes to contemplation every evening and forgets it all day will not derive any benefit."

"We take our food at certain times every day. Yet all the time, even when we are sleeping, the food nourishes our body."

The fragmentary way we experience life makes it difficult to assimilate the divine nature within our experiences. Contemplation provides a way to slow down and receive deep nourishment.

"It's like slow-cooked food, eaten mindfully, digestion is incomparably better than fast food quickly eaten."

THE TRUE FIELD OF PRACTICE

The goal is not to retire into seclusion, but to bring the fruits of contemplation into every aspect of existence.

"By contemplation, one must be so inspired in study and in aspiration that progress is attained in every aspect of life."

"Concentration and contemplation are great things, but no contemplation is greater than the life we have about us every day."

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The Upcoming Wazifa of the Seven Leading Names

Source: CT6 · March 29, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

YOUR SPIRITUAL FOOD

"So next time we meet, God willing, each of you will receive one of the seven leading names as your wazifa to do for a period of time and that will be your spiritual food."

This practice is an invitation to give yourself the time to focus on what endures beyond worldly activity.

"Yes, we are all very busy and yet so much of the busyness of what we're involved in is just going to turn to dust and what will be left of it? Very little."

"At the end of this life, what endures is what we've assimilated, what we've digested, what has really nourished our spiritual bones and that's what we've given care to, given love to."

A SOURCE OF ENERGY, NOT A BURDEN

While many of us are busy with honorable missions and offerings of service, this practice is not meant to be another exhausting task.

"You might find that the wazifa actually, instead of just taking more of your time and energy, it empowers you."

"It delivers fresh energy that can empower your life's mission."

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How to Conclude a Spiritual Practice

Source: CT6 · March 29, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

With every spiritual practice, it is essential to dedicate a moment at its conclusion, rather than immediately moving on to the next task. Just as we mindfully consume a meal, we must allow the spiritual nourishment to settle and integrate into our being. Therefore, Pir Zia teaches: *"with every practice, sense at the at the end, don't just rush off to the next thing, just see how has this act of attention affected me? What is my state of being now, having having done this?"* This reflective pause is not an egoic thought, but a sincere dedication to understanding the profound impact of one's engagement. By consciously taking this time, we move beyond mere activity, allowing the sacred essence of the practice to permeate our inner state. This careful assimilation ensures the benefits are deeply rooted, empowering our spiritual growth and sustaining us in our daily lives, rather than dissipating in the rush of subsequent demands.

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The Ittisal Practice: The 'U' Sound and the Universal Mind

Source: CT6 · March 29, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

The next stage of our ittisal practice involves the 'U' sound, shifting our identification from the physical and etheric to the mental, where your psyche is a fraction of the universal psyche, the Nafs-i-kull. This practice invites us to conceive of our individual minds not as isolated entities, but as nodes within an immense, interconnected web of consciousness, extending beyond our personal brains into the universal mind. Just imagine, *"As if your brain is one little neuron in a vast intergalactic brain. And whatever one is part of, one has access to."* This profound realization connects us to the mind of all minds, transforming our understanding of self. By sensing this

embeddedness, we transcend the boundaries of our individual skull, gaining access to a shared consciousness and the vast wisdom that permeates the cosmos.

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Part I · Chapter 6

GUIDED VISUALIZATIONS & MOVEMENT

Inner Images and Sacred Gestures

The imagination is a wing of the soul. Guided journeys to the Garden of the Heart, visualizations of light and lineage, and the gestures that accompany prayer: each uses image or movement as a doorway into the interior.

4 Entries · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

The Magnetism of Wazifa: Angels and Jinn

Source: CT1 · March 27, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

THE QUIET PRACTICE

The practice of Wazifa is done with quiet dedication and consistency. It is a sacred trust, undertaken without public display.

"We do this without fanfare. It's done quietly. No one else knows. Beginning with the waxing moon."

THE UNSEEN SUPPORT

Through this consistent practice, a spiritual magnetism builds, attracting support from the unseen realms.

"And when there is consistency, then the magnetism of the practice builds up. You're joined by angels and benevolent jinn."

"You're surrounded by a whirling morass, thought beings that are drawn to the name because they too are entrusted with it."

THE NAME BECOMES YOUR WORLD

As the practice deepens, the divine quality of the name begins to manifest everywhere, transforming one's perception of reality.

"And when you recite the name, you'll also recognize that name in others who are entrusted with it, and those who simply embody it in one fashion or another. That name will show itself on all sides. The name will become your world. This is the meaning of Wazifa."

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The Zikr of Ya Hayyu

Source: CT1 · March 27, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

AL-HAYY — THE LIVING

The first of the seven mother names is *Al-Hayy*, the Living.

"Why is it the first? Before something can be something, certainly before something can do something, something must simply be. Something must simply exist, live. This comes first."

The quality of this name is embodied in its very sound. *"Even if you are not told that Hayy means the living, if you would simply recite Hayy, Hayy, Hayy, Hayy, Hayy, you would find in your breath a surge of livingness that confirms the meaning of the word."*

This livingness is not confined to physical embodiment. It is the primal, perpetual nature of being itself.

"Long before we incarnated, already we lived. After this body dissolves into its elements, still we'll live. In fact, life never dies. Death dies, life lives."

"Life is intrinsic. And it marks divinity. It belongs to God. This is divine nature in its primal mode."

THE PRACTICE OF INVOCATION

The practice is a *zikr*, an invocation and remembrance, of this divine name in its vocative form: *Ya Hayyu* (O Living One).

Through the continuous repetition of the name, we enter its field and experience the *"sheer livingness"* that is our own inalienable nature.

THE UNITY OF LIVINGNESS

After the practice, rest in the realization of non-separation.

"The livingness in you is no different than the livingness in the Earth, which is no different than the eternal livingness which is in the divine being."

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The Ultimate Opening: Realizing Oneness through Fana and Baqa

Source: CT4 · March 28, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

"The ultimate opening of Fattah is the realization of Tawhid, the oneness of being. It is the crumbling of the illusion of a separate self, and the direct perception that there is no reality other than the one divine Reality."

*"The core declaration of Islam, "*La ilaha illa'llah*" -- "*There is no god but God*" -- is the ultimate expression of this truth. All spiritual practices are ultimately aimed at bringing the seeker to this lived, experiential realization."*

THE EXPERIENCE OF FANA AND BAQA

"Ultimately, the greatest gift of Ya Wahhab is the experience of Fana and Baqa. Fana is the annihilation of the false, separate self in the divine presence. Baqa is the subsistence, the eternal life, of the true self in and through God."

"This is the ultimate goal of Tasawwuf. The opening of Fattah clears the way for this transformation, and the patience of Sabur sustains us on the journey toward it."

THE DIVINE SELF-DISCLOSURE

"The ultimate gift of Wahhab, the fruit of the opening of Fattah, is the Tajalli, the divine self-disclosure. It is when the Beloved unveils His beauty (Jamal) and majesty (Jalal) within the mirror of the seeker's heart."

"This is not an abstract concept but a direct, tasting experience that transforms the very substance of one's being. All the practices of the path are in preparation for this moment of encounter."

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Guided Meditation: Journey into a Fiery Landscape (Full Text)

Source: CT6 · March 29, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

Now, let us embark on a unique journey, a meditation into a virtual world of pure, exhilarating phantasm. This contemplation encourages opening oneself to the unexpected, encountering realities long forgotten. *"Peering through a kaleidoscope sparks a whole venture into worlds of light. Imagine most realistically, spirals of light extending and closing in on you."* Give yourself over to this enthralling effulgence until you feel a spillover into your clothes, in your aura, in your eyes. Imagine you are a firecracker exploding in innumerable sparks and colors, stepping into this world of light. As you advance, it gets brighter and more magnificent, ultimately revealing the luminous blueprints of the world and transforming your own countenance into something radiant, like an angel revealing itself to you. This is a profound exploration of inner light and its transformative power.

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Part I · Chapter 7

TEACHINGS & WISDOM

The Living Commentary of the Path

Alongside the practices, Pir Zia offered teachings — framings, commentaries, and rules of the Suluk — that illuminate the inner landscape. These are the lamps set along the path.

25 Entries · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

The Divine Names — Living Anatomy of God's Attributes

Source: CT1 · March 27, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

THE ORGANIC NATURE OF THE NAMES

"As we know, there are many names. 99 is sometimes mentioned as a symbolic number, but there are more than 99. And the names themselves form a living anatomy. The names are related to each other, they branch out from each other, they interact with each other, like the organs of a living organism."

"So to delve into the names is to begin to see the organicity of them, the interrelationships between them, the interplay of meanings. And we see that there are names that are more original, and others that unfold from those most primal names."

THREE CATEGORIES OF DIVINE NAMES

Category · Quality · Description
Jalali · Majesty & Power · Names of divine might and sovereignty
Jamali · Beauty & Elegance · Names of divine grace and tenderness
Kamali · Beauty & Power merged · Names of divine perfection and completion

THE LEGACY OF SACRED SOUND

"The names have come down to us down through long generations, received through revelation, communicated from heart to heart, and recited in the course of succeeding lives. We are fortunate to be the recipients of these oral traditions, these legacies of sacred sound carrying inspired speech that articulates the fundamental qualities of being."

THE SEVEN LEADING NAMES — THE UMMAHAT

"In these next five days, we're going to be working with a series of seven names which are called the seven leading names. Al-Asma as-Sab'a al-A'imma, the seven leading names."

"Also called the Ummahat, the mother names, the mothers. They are matrixes. And you might say that one gives rise to the next one. They unfold in sequence. And this sequence is the basis of the manner in which the universe itself has come into being."

MICROCOSM REFLECTS MACROCOSM

"And similarly, the manner in which each of us has come into being. Because our own microcosmic process of emergence is embedded within and reflects the larger macrocosmic process of creation. The way in which the fertilized egg develops in the womb, the process of birth and growth of body and mind. This entire journey is comparable to the astronomical and geological and biological processes that have produced the earth."

"And the key to all of it lies with the seven mother names."

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Chivalric Rule — Consider Your Responsibility Sacred

Source: CT1 · March 27, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

> ***My conscientious self, consider your responsibility sacred.***

THE RULE AS CONTEMPLATION

"Now we come to our next chivalric rule, which is, my conscientious self, consider your responsibility sacred. Each of these rules is really a contemplation. So we began contemplation before entering formally into the stage of contemplation, whenever we've been working with the rules, we've been working with contemplation, reflecting upon our lives, on our choices, seeing how our consciousness is in our own hands."

ON FREEDOM AND AGENCY

"We are free to choose our thoughts, our words, our actions. We are free to sculpt our lives. We can't control other people, but we have perfect discretion in determining how we respond to them. And if we don't affirm that freedom and claim it, then we'll find ourselves merely reacting to circumstances, acting on conditioning."

"So the purpose of these rules is to remind us of our own agency. It's an invitation to decide how to lead this precious incarnate life that has been entrusted to us."

TRUE RESPONSIBILITY — HAQQ

"This rule invites us to consider responsibility. What are our true responsibilities? If someone has a certain expectation of you, it may or may not correspond to your actual responsibility. People project expectations in all directions all of the time. The real question is, what is truly due to each person, to each being? What is the haqq, the right that each being has?"

"And what is the haqq of one's own self? We need to do justice to others in our relations with them. At the same time, we need to do justice to ourself. What does it mean to do justice to ourself? Fundamentally, it means being true to your purpose, to your dharma, your responsibility."

"At the end of the day, we're not going to be asked about something that someone else was responsible for. We'll be asked about what we were responsible for. We're not responsible for everything, but that which we are responsible for, at the end of the day, we'll be asked about it. Still more fundamentally, we'll ask ourselves, that which was my responsibility, did I attend to it?"

ON SERIOUSNESS

"Now, seriousness doesn't mean a kind of dry as dust solemnity. There may certainly be joy in it. There may be a lightness of touch in it. It doesn't have to be ponderously weighty and self-

important. Seriousness means sincerity, care, devoted attention.”

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Introduction of Nizam un Nisa — Contemplation Part II Instructor

Source: CT1 · March 27, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

Pir Zia formally introduced Nizam un Nisa to the Suluk class. She will lead the Part II sessions beginning with the next weekend.

“It's a delight to see you, to look across the screen and to see each face, each pair of eyes. We met at the beginning of Suluk and then the last two times you were with Qutbuddin, and I heard very good things about all that happened during those gatherings.”

“And now we're together again for two sessions, and then you'll be with Nizam un Nisa, who is here these next few days. I welcome you, thank you so much for being here, Nizam un Nisa. And I know that it'll be a wonderful thing for this group to have the chance to spend time with you.”

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The Three Qualities of Divine Names (Jalali, Jamali, Kamali)

Source: CT1 · March 27, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

We are now entering the stage of contemplation, moving beyond focus on mere forms to the subtler qualities, characters, and underlying nature of things. These qualities are, in essence, the attributes of God, and the Divine Names invoke them, forming a living anatomy that reveals the interplay of meanings. *“There are names which fall on the side of majesty and power, the Jalali*

names. The other names that are rather names of beauty and elegance, the Jamali names. And then names in which beauty and power merge, Kamali names." Understanding these distinct yet interconnected categories helps us to perceive the organicity of the Divine attributes, from the primal names to those that unfold from them. This framework guides our contemplation, allowing us to delve into the fundamental qualities of being and the way they manifest in the universe.

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Death Dies, Life Lives

Source: CT1 · March 27, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

We often associate life exclusively with physical embodiment, believing it ends when the body dissolves. However, contemplating the divine name Al-Hayy, *"the Living,"* reveals a more profound truth. Embodied life is merely one mode of existence; life permeates the subtle physical, mental, and angelic realms. It is an error to identify life solely with our temporary physical form, as life encompasses all planes. As I shared, *"In fact, life never dies. Death dies, life lives."* Our livingness is innate, perpetual, and primary, preceding incarnation and persisting long after the body's dissolution. This inherent vitality marks divinity itself, inviting us to discover a ground of life more ancient and inalienable than its novel manifestations.

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Your Purpose as an Unfolding Melody

Source: CT1 · March 27, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

As we consider our sacred responsibility, we recognize that we are free to sculpt our lives, choosing our thoughts, words, and actions. This agency calls us to discern our true purpose, our unique dharma, amidst the many distractions and expectations that vie for our attention. It is not always a matter of rejecting external influences, but rather actively integrating them into our spiritual path. Indeed, *"your purpose is a is a music that's unfolding and whatever notes glide into the space must somehow be incorporated within the unfolding melody if they are to cohere meaningfully in the fulfillment of your soul's journey."* This means embracing all experiences, both expected and unexpected, making them our own, and allowing them to contribute to the unique composition of our soul's journey. By doing so, we ensure our path coheres meaningfully toward its fulfillment.

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The Wisdom of Lying Low: Stepping Back to Step Forward

Source: CT2 · March 27, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

In the rhythm of life, we often find ourselves echoing the natural world's cycles of retreat and emergence. There is a profound wisdom in recognizing when to pause and allow for inner recalibration, rather than always pushing forward. *"One needs to step back in life before stepping forward, to lie low. It is not really escaping from the unceasing challenges, but anticipating action by fostering a renewal of life. For life is not just cyclic, but ever recurrently renewed. For this, one has to sometimes skim rock bottom."* This period of quiet introspection and deep grounding, even through difficult moments, is essential. It allows us to touch the very root of our being, cultivating a fertile inner

space where new ideas and a fresh zest for life can unpredictably surface, preparing us to emerge restored and re-enchanted.

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The Nafs as the Foundation for Compassion

Source: CT2 · March 27, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

While we often perceive the Nafs, our personal self, as a source of ego-driven desires, it holds a profound and providential role in our spiritual unfoldment. It is the very means by which the soul enters into the story of creation, experiencing both joy and suffering. *"If we have a self that can suffer, then the next step is to see there's another self that could also suffer, my friend, my neighbor. And seeing that suffering, having compassion, having sympathy, because one knows what it's like to be afraid or to be hurt, growing compassion, solidarity, friendship, these things happen at the level of self meeting self."* This intimate companionship on the path, where the Nafs softens and recognizes itself in every other, opens the way to what we call the heart, revealing its true purpose.

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The Physical Center of the Nafs and the Umbilical Cord

Source: CT2 · March 27, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

When we begin our exploration of the Lata'if, or subtle organs, we start with the Nafs, which refers to the self or ego. Its physical center offers a profound connection to our earliest experience of individuality. *"The Latifa of the Nafs is approached in the, in the belly, just beneath the navel... Oh, yes, this is where I was*

connected to the body of my mother through the umbilical cord. This is where I was fed and given drink and even given breath in the womb. Then I was born into the world and the cord was cut. And when the cord was cut, that was the beginning of my becoming a separate person." This physical point reminds us of the origins of our separate identity, which often manifests as the 'me, me' of the ego. By consciously breathing into this center, we can begin to soften the Nafs and transform our sense of self.

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The Co-Emergence of Selves on the Path

Source: CT2 · March 27, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

The journey of the Nafs, our personal self, is a vital part of our spiritual story, moving through stages like Ammara, Lawwama, and Mutma'inna. This path of constant transformation is remarkably not undertaken in isolation, for our individual emergence into higher states of being is deeply intertwined with the development of those around us. It is a profound aspect of the spiritual journey to witness how intimately linked our progress is. *"And it, it's emergence is in concert with the emergence of and and the transformation of other selves, which is itself a great wonder of life, the way in which contact with a self that is moving from Ammara to Lawwama, from Lawwama to Mutma'inna, encourages your own movement."* This mutual encouragement highlights the profound companionship inherent on the spiritual path, where each individual's softening and opening fosters growth in all, enriching the collective spiritual tapestry.

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The Goal of Contemplation: From Outer Evidence to Inner Meaning

Source: CT3 · March 28, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

Contemplation invites us to transcend surface appearances, recognizing the infinite depth inherent in all things. Through watchful care and respect, we approach every encounter with reverence. We learn to take seriously all we meet, recognizing its signs and divine presence. *"In the encounter there's a movement of spirit toward the depth, from the outer evidence to the inner meaning to the name, the divine name."* This journey, called I'tibar, means crossing over from the obvious to the implied, from what is seen to what is sensed. It is a process of discerning subtle significations hidden beneath the surface. Ultimately, this spiritual crossing reveals all phenomena as projections of the divine names, drawing us into a deeper, more intimate communion with the One who continuously manifests as a hidden treasure in every moment of our lives.

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The Threefold Emergence of Being: Wahdat, Ahadiyyat, Wahdaniyyat

Source: CT3 · March 28, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

The divine secret of the hidden treasure reveals itself through a subtle and profound process of emergence into being. We can understand this unfolding through three primary states. First, Wahdat, the plane of absolute oneness where the treasure remains hidden, in perfect silence, without any distinction of being or non-being, or here and there. In this abyss of fullness, a yearning, or Ishq, arises. This longing initiates the transition to

Ahadiyyat, the state of singular emergence. As Pir Zia explains, *"In Wahdat there is really speaking no being or non-being. In Ahadiyyat, emergence, being begins to feel itself, begins to surge, leading to Wahdaniyyat or Wahidiyyat when the one being reaches self-awareness."* This culminates in the divine declaration *"I am,"* which signifies the full awakening of self-knowing, establishing the very foundation for all future manifestation and the universe's unfolding.

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The Raison d'Etre: Return of the One to the One

Source: CT3 · March 28, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

Our spiritual path, often guided by practices of contemplation, invites us to look beyond the surface of life and uncover its profound significance. It reveals that our very existence holds a sacred purpose, deeply intertwined with the divine unfolding. Indeed, the creation itself arose from a longing of the hidden treasure to be known. As I have said, *"The ultimate raison d'être of our being is this witnessing, this adoring, this glorifying, this return of the one to the one through the many."* This journey is not merely about passive observation but active engagement with the divine qualities manifested in every aspect of existence. Each of us, as a fraction of the cosmic person, is called to witness and embody these qualities. Through this process of recognition and participation, we contribute to the continual unfolding of the Hidden Treasure, bringing ourselves and all of reality into ever-deepening communion with the Divine Source.

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Integrating the Spiritual State (Hal) into Daily Life

Source: CT4 · March 28, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

Our spiritual practices are not meant to be confined to the meditation cushion; they are designed to permeate our entire existence. We cultivate profound inner states, or Hals, which are then brought forth into the world. *"The state, the Hal, that is cultivated in meditation is then carried back into our daily lives. The patience, the openness, and the generosity we touch upon in our Zikr are meant to inform our character and our interactions with the world."* Through consistent engagement with practices like the Wazifa Ya Fattah, Ya Wahhab, Ya Sabur, we develop these divine qualities. Ya Sabur cultivates steadfast patience, Ya Fattah encourages an open heart, and Ya Wahhab fosters generosity of spirit. The aim is for these temporary states, or Hals, to become integrated into our very being, transforming into stable spiritual stations, or Maqams. This allows the fruits of our remembrance to manifest authentically, making us more present, compassionate, and gracious in every encounter, reflecting the divine in our every action.

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Universal Truths: Parallels between Tasawwuf and Dharma

Source: CT4 · March 28, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

Our practice with the divine names reveals profound spiritual principles that resonate far beyond the bounds of Tasawwuf. Indeed, these are universal truths, reflecting the singular journey of the soul. We find striking parallels in other traditions. *"In the language of Dharma, one might speak of patient endurance*

(Kshanti), the opening of the heart-lotus, and the reception of grace (Prasada). The names and forms may differ, but the underlying reality of the spiritual process is one." This profound agreement across traditions reminds us that the path from a constricted self to boundless reality, a journey requiring patience, awaiting a divine opening, and sustained by grace, is a universal human aspiration. Ultimately, the essence of spiritual transformation transcends all cultural forms and terminologies.

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The Spiritual Ego: Avoiding the Trap of the Nafs

Source: CT4 · March 28, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

As we embark on the spiritual journey, we call upon the Divine Names, opening ourselves to profound experiences and graces. The process of receiving these gifts, however, holds a subtle peril if we are not vigilant. *"A subtle danger on the path is to claim the opening or the gift as one's own achievement. This is the trap of the Nafs, which seeks to build a spiritual identity. The name Ya Wahhab is a constant reminder that all good comes from the divine source as a free and unmerited gift."* Our role is simply to prepare the vessel of our heart and receive with utmost humility and profound gratitude, recognizing that we truly deserve nothing, and everything is a blessing from the Divine. This understanding fosters true spiritual growth and keeps us aligned with the source of all good.

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The Two Faces of Opening: Lutf (Gentleness) and Qahr (Severity)

Source: CT4 · March 28, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

The divine name Ya Fattah, the Opener, reveals a fundamental truth about spiritual progress. While we often seek gentle, harmonious breakthroughs, the divine hand works in profound and sometimes surprising ways to clear the path. *"The divine action of Fattah can manifest with Lutf, or gentleness, like the slow blooming of a flower. It can also manifest with Qahr, or divine severity, like a lightning strike that shatters a rock. Sometimes, a sudden, disruptive event in our lives is the very action of Fattah, breaking open a structure of the ego that was holding us back."* With the perspective of Sabur, or divine patience, we are called to trust in the wisdom of these powerful openings, discerning grace even in the most challenging events, as they serve to purify and evolve our being.

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Ishq: The Divine Love That Fuels Our Patience

Source: CT4 · March 28, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

As we cultivate Sabur, the quality of patient endurance on our spiritual journey, we often wonder what sustains us through its inevitable difficulties. The answer lies in the profound power of divine love. *"The driving force that gives us the strength for Sabur, the patience to endure this journey, is Ishq, divine love. It is the longing of the heart for the Beloved that makes any hardship bearable. This Ishq is itself a gift from Wahhab, a spark of the divine love placed within our hearts."* This spark of Ishq, placed divinely within, is the inner fire that not only makes the journey bearable but also illuminates the path ahead, guiding us through challenges with unwavering devotion and

transforming our trials into opportunities for deeper connection with the Beloved.

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The Foundation of Practice: Niyyah (Clear Intention)

Source: CT4 · March 28, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

As we approach any sacred endeavor on the spiritual path, the quality of our intention and inner resolve is paramount. Before engaging in practice, we must pause and thoughtfully consider the true wellspring of our motivation. *"Before beginning any spiritual practice, it is essential to form a clear intention, or Niyyah. We should take a moment to clarify in our hearts why we are undertaking this practice. Is it for personal gain, or is it for the sake of drawing nearer to the divine Reality and being of service to creation?"* A pure intention not only profoundly orients the entire practice, but it also prepares the heart to become a more fitting and open receptacle for the divine grace we seek, allowing it to flow freely.

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The Seven Leading Divine Names

Source: CT5 · March 29, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

The teaching explores the profound process by which all existence unfolds. We delve into the gradations of being, understanding the divine qualities that govern both cosmic manifestation and our individual becoming. *"We've been speaking about the emergence of the seven leading names, the seven mother names, one after another in sequence. In this way, we've been speaking about the emergence of the universe and*

also the emergence of ourselves." This continuous revelation of divine qualities, such as sheer livingness, knowingness, power, and desire, shapes both the macrocosm and our personal journey, from primordial essence to physical embodiment. By understanding these sequential emanations, we gain insight into our deepest origins and ongoing spiritual development.

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The First Creature: The Light of the Creator

Source: CT5 · March 29, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

As we delve into the ancient memories of existence, seeking to understand the emergence of the universe and ourselves from the divine essence, we recognize a sequence of unfolding. Beyond essential oneness and divinized oneness, there comes a stage of manifest oneness where consciousness first takes form. It is here that *"And here is where the first creature is manifested. And the deepest meditators discover that this first creature is so much the effusion of the Godhead that yes, it is creation, but it is also the very light of the creator."* This pivotal realization highlights that the very first emanation of creation is not distinct from the divine, but rather its radiant and inseparable essence, a pervasive light continually giving rise to all being. This understanding reminds us of our own inherent connection to the source.

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The Cosmic Unfolding of Desire

Source: CT5 · March 29, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

We explore how the divine name Al-Murid, the Desirer, manifests in the grand tapestry of the cosmos. This divine creative longing, Irada, fuels the ceaseless transformation we witness. In the universe, this shows itself as *"matter is weaving itself and re-weaving itself, mutating, taking turns that lead to cul-de-sacs, but other turns that lead to remarkable leaps in complexity. All by way of an exploration of what is wanted."* This restless desire quivers in all creation, stirring new possibilities. As partakers in this divine creative longing, we learn to clarify our own desires, focusing them to align with this cosmic unfolding, and realize that ultimately, the seeker is God.

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The World is a School of Love

Source: CT5 · March 29, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

We are partakers not only in the divine power, but also in the divine creative longing, Irada. This restless desire quivers in all creation and through us, yet our desires can often become narrowly conceived or knotted, leading to dissatisfaction. It is through these experiences that *"the world becomes a a school of love where we learn lessons along the way, learn how to love, learn to clarify our desire, clarify it, and empower it and focus it and align with it."* In this school, the very dissatisfaction we face proves a stepping stone toward higher realization. Indeed, as an initiate is known as a Murid—a seeker and a lover—this teaching reveals that the seeker is, in essence, God refining divine longing through us.

In Pir Zia's own words: *"So the world becomes a a school of love where we learn lessons along the way, learn how to love, learn to clarify our desire, clarify it, and empower it and focus it and align with it."*

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Darkness as a Revealer of Finer Light

Source: CT6 · March 29, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

We often fall into a false dichotomy, thinking that light is good and darkness is something to be shunned. Yet, embracing darkness reveals a profound truth about the nature of luminosity and its hidden forms. As we observe the night sky, we understand this principle: *"So darkness is showing us something. The veiling of the light of the sun enables other manifestations of light to be revealed."* Indeed, by filtering out the most obvious and glaring frequencies of light, we are not dispelling luminosity, but rather discovering finer transmissions and gradations. This enables us to realize that what we label as darkness is merely another portion of the spectrum of illumination, a condition for perceiving an inherent light that otherwise remains veiled.

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Contemplation as Slow-Cooked Food for the Soul

Source: CT6 · March 29, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

In a world where life often feels relentlessly busy and responsibilities never end, it's natural to wonder if contemplation, even for a short time, isn't too much when we are tired. Yet, this very busyness underscores our profound need for it. Rather than being constantly scattered, contemplation invites us to slow down and dedicate ourselves to a particular quality, letting it wash over and enliven us. As I once said, *"it's like slow-cooked food, eaten mindfully, digestion is incomparably better*

than fast food quickly eaten. And that's what contemplation offers." This mindful engagement allows us to assimilate the divine nature, fostering a deep spiritual nourishment that strengthens our being. What truly endures in life is what we have absorbed, cared for, and allowed to feed our spiritual bones.

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Part I · Chapter 8

STORIES, PARABLES & POETRY

The Wisdom That Travels in Images

Some truths refuse to be said plainly. They must be told as story, sung as poetry, enacted as parable. This chapter preserves the tales and verses that illuminated the retreat.

1 Entries · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

Story of Yudhisthira and the Dog — The Dharma Within

Source: CT1 · March 27, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

THE STORY (FROM THE MAHABHARATA)

Pir Zia told this story to illuminate the chivalric rule about sacred responsibility:

"An example would be a story that is told at the culmination of the Mahabharata, great Hindu epic, which has as its heroes, Yudhisthira and his wife Draupadi and his brothers. Now, they go through many ordeals in the course of a great conflict that occurs. And finally emerge victorious."

"But the story doesn't end there. Having concluded their earthly affairs satisfactorily, this family resolves to embark on a pilgrimage into the mountains with a view to ascending Mount Meru and retiring there in a state of samadhi, meditative absorption."

"Along the way, a dog, black dog, arrives and joins them, and they enjoy the dog's companionship. But tragically, in the course of the ordeals and vicissitudes of the venture, one after the other, Yudhisthira's brothers — they perish. They lose their lives one after another. And Draupadi does also. And so Yudhisthira has the solemn duty of cremating them. And in the end, it's only Yudhisthira and the dog."

"And the mountain top is looming in the distance, but Yudhisthira is nearly exhausted and the remaining span seems almost impossible to traverse. And it's just then that a flying car comes down from the sky. And the angel who is steering it says, step into the car and come with me and I'll take you to your destination. Only the dog may not come."

"Of course, Yudhisthira had been on the verge of enthusiastically accepting this favor until hearing that he would have to part ways with his companion of many, many days now. And, you

know, he must have looked into the eyes of the dog, and the dog must have looked into his eyes. He said, no, I can't, I will thank you for the offer, but I'm traveling with my friend."

"And the dog looked up and smiled. And the dog began to transform, to shape shift, and take on an angelic appearance. And the dog revealed, I am Dharma, I'm your Dharma. And you were true to me. And with that, Yudhisthira and Yudhisthira's Dharma climbed into the car and were whisked up the mountain to their destination."

THE TEACHING — DHARMA IS NOT RIGID

"The word Dharma has many interpretations. Like any word, it could be politicized. It could be interpreted in a very rigid fashion. But in our contemplation, we have the opportunity to go to an experiential place, to move beyond the way in which societies reinforce designated meanings collectively."

"The opportunity is to sense the Dharma as something very much linked with guidance, with intuition, with your own deepest knowing. That doesn't set you apart from community. It's not egoically defined. In fact, your dharma has very much to do with relationships. But since it is of the spirit, since it is an expression of divine guidance, it will never be simplistic. It'll never be rigid. It's always going to be an unfolding process of being, knowing, doing."

DISCERNING WHAT IS TRULY YOURS

"One senses its palpable relevance when one sees that not everything that one is caught up in is dharmic to you. Not everything that is pulling you in, not everything that captures your thought stream is intrinsic to your purpose. There is much that is incidental, or that must be made your own in some way, needs to be brought into communion with your purpose."

"There isn't a sharp dividing line, but your purpose is a music that's unfolding, and whatever notes glide into the space must somehow be incorporated within the unfolding melody if they

are to cohere meaningfully in the fulfillment of your soul's journey."

CROSS-TRADITIONAL REFERENCE

This Hindu epic teaching is used to illuminate the Sufi concept of sacred responsibility and the chivalric rule. Mount Meru parallels Mount Qaf in the Sufi tradition.

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Part I · Chapter 9

DEEP STUDY & SACRED TERMS

Keys to the Arabic Lexicon of the Path

Certain words carry the whole teaching folded into a syllable — tawhid, mushahada, fana, baqa. Here the sacred vocabulary of contemplation is unfolded, each term a key to a chamber of meaning.

13 Entries · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

Al-Hayy — The Living (First Mother Name)

Source: CT1 · March 27, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

Al-Hayy is the first of the seven Ummahat (mother names). Pir Zia introduced it with a teaching on mantric language, why livingness is the first attribute, and what it means to discover the ground of life within.

INTRODUCTION

"Now we are going to work with the Ummahat, the mother names. And the first of these is Al-Hayy. Al-Hayy. It's an aspirated H, Al-Hayy, Al-Hayy meaning the living."

MANTRIC LANGUAGE — THE SOUND EMBODIES THE MEANING

"Now as soon as you hear the name Al-Hayy, you will recognize how it exemplifies the reality of what we could call mantric language, which is to say words, names that in their very sonic structure embody the quality they designate."

"Even if you are not told that Hayy means the living, if you would simply recite Hayy, Hayy, Hayy, Hayy, you would find in your breath a surge of livingness that confirms the meaning of the word. It's in the sound itself."

WHY AL-HAYY IS FIRST

"So this is the first of the seven, Al-Hayy. Why is it the first? Before something can be something, certainly before something can do something, something must simply be. Something must simply exist, live. This comes first. Being, living."

LIFE BEYOND PHYSICAL EMBODIMENT

"All too often when we use the word living, we think living means being in a body with a beating heart. And when the body dies, then life ends. But really, embodied life is only one mode of

life. There's life in the plain of the subtle physical world. There's life on the plain of the mental realm. There's life on the plain of the angelic intelligences."

"Life encompasses all planes. So it is an error to identify life exclusively with physical embodiment. Life is something more innate. Long before we incarnated, already we lived. After this body dissolves into its elements, still we'll live. In fact, life never dies. Death dies. Life lives."

"Life is innate, perpetual, primary. And the universe begins with it. Creation unfolds from it. Our own individual journey has this inception. Pure, sheer life."

THE GROUND OF LIVINGNESS

"You could ask yourself, how does it feel to be alive? And the first answer might be, it's good to look out through these eyes, it's good to breathe fresh air, it's good to be alive. Well, this is true, but it isn't the end of the story. If you look deeper, it isn't only this eyesight that evidences your livingness."

"You can sink down into yourself and discover a ground of life that is more ancient than the novel manifestations of being that we identify so exclusively with. And still you can say, it's good to be alive."

"There's a felicity in the sheer livingness of the soul. Our livingness in the one that is inalienable. Yes, our mind might become oblivious to the innateness of it, but that innateness persists. Life is intrinsic, and it marks divinity. It belongs to God."

"This is divine nature in its primal mode before all of the names that describe the unfolding relationship between the whole and the parts. Sheer livingness."

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Arabic and Sufi Terms — Contemplation Class 1

Source: CT1 · March 27, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat Khan

Arabic/Sufi Term · Meaning · Context/Significance

Mujahada · Striving, concentration · The stage of Concentration — learning stillness through effort

Muraqabah · Contemplation, watchfulness · The stage of Contemplation — the mind moves gracefully, purposefully

Aman · Safety, sanctuary, peace · The attitude that creates Dar al-Aman; arises from the interior life

Dar al-Aman · Realm of sanctuary · Built beginning in one's own heart through consideration for all beings

Al-Asma as-Sab'a al-A'imma · The Seven Leading Names · The seven mother names (Ummahat) — matrices from which the divine attributes unfold

Ummahat · Mothers, matrices · The seven leading divine names; each gives rise to the next in the sequence of creation

Al-Hayy · The Living · First of the seven mother names; sheer livingness, divine nature in its primal mode

Ya Hayyu · O Living One · Invocatory form of Al-Hayy used in zikr practice, repeated 101 times

Jalali · Majestic, powerful · Category of divine names associated with majesty and power

Jamali · Beautiful, graceful · Category of divine names associated with beauty and elegance

Kamali · Perfect, complete · Category where beauty and power merge

Wazifa · Assignment, daily practice · A divine name entrusted as a daily spiritual practice; one enters the field of that name

'Abd · Servant · One who serves a divine name through Wazifa practice

Haqq · Right, truth, what is due · What is truly owed to each being; justice to others and to oneself

Dharma · Sacred duty, purpose · Linked with guidance and intuition; always unfolding, never rigid

Pir Dahan · Mouth of the Pir · Place in California where Hazrat Inayat Khan meditated on a stone

Silsila · Chain of transmission · The lineage through which sacred names and practices are passed down

Samadhi · Meditative absorption · Referenced in the Mahabharata story — Yudhisthira's pilgrimage to Mount Meru

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A Caveat for Contemplation: Protecting Those with Trauma

Source: CT2 · March 27, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

As we delve into deeper contemplative practices, it's crucial to approach them with self-awareness and care for our inner state. Not every exercise is suitable for every person at every moment, and acknowledging this is an act of wisdom. When engaging with methods that invite introspection and potentially unbidden insights, it's important to discern what serves your well-being. Pir Zia reminds us that *"if you find at this time that, um, uh, memories or, um, you know, intrusive thoughts tend to, um, come unbidden, well then, um, you know, this won't be one of the exercises for you right now. And that's just fine."* This counsel encourages us to prioritize our inner peace and choose practices that support our healing and growth without causing destabilization. It underscores the importance of a gentle and self-compassionate approach to spiritual work.

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Crossing Over: The Deeper Meaning of I'tibar

Source: CT3 · March 28, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

The practice of I'tibar, or contemplation, invites us to look deeply beyond the immediate surface of our experiences, be they waking moments or dreams. This profound word is intimately connected to 'abara, meaning to cross, like a river. As Pir Zia

explains: *"...the word is related to 'abara, which means to cross, like to cross a river... Crossing over, wading through. So whatever you meet with in waking life or in a dream, you wouldn't just meet it as something confronting you. You wouldn't only regard its surface. You'd find a way into it, through it. There's a there's a porousness to all things and in I'tibar we become porous, we become vaporous, we move through each other."* Through this vigilant and respectful approach, we gain a deeper understanding, transitioning from mere perception to profound spiritual insight and communion.

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The Womb (Rahm) as an Embodiment of Divine Mercy

Source: CT3 · March 28, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

Reflecting on the very beginning of our physical existence, we find a powerful metaphor for the divine presence that sustains all life. Imagine yourself as an embryo in the womb, floating effortlessly in amniotic fluid, where your primary experience was simply being alive, without effort or thought of how to sustain yourself. This primal state of effortless sustenance points to a deeper truth about our origin. *"Actually, you know the womb is, the word in Arabic is rahm, rahm. Rahman and Rahim come from this. The compassion, the mercy that brought forth this world."* This connection highlights that the very essence of life and creation is rooted in boundless divine compassion and mercy. Understanding this, we can begin to attune ourselves to the constant flow of divine care that continues to uphold us in every breath, every experience, and every step we take.

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The Unveiling of Kashf and the 'Eye of the Heart'

Source: CT4 · March 28, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

The divine name Ya Fattah signifies a profound opening, not merely of external circumstances, but of our inner perception. When we invoke the Opener, we seek access to deeper realities. *"The opening of Fattah is also related to the experience of Kashf, or unveiling. It is the opening of the inner senses, the perception of realities that are normally veiled from our ordinary consciousness. This can be the opening of the 'Ayn al-Qalb, the eye of the heart, which begins to see the divine Tajalli, the self-disclosure of God, in all of creation."* This transformation allows us to move beyond superficial appearances, perceiving the underlying meaning and divine presence that illuminates all of existence. It is a shift from seeing the form to perceiving the meaning that shines through the form.

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The Three Planes of Opening: Nasut, Malakut, and Jabrut

Source: CT4 · March 28, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

When we call upon Ya Fattah, the Opener, we acknowledge that the divine intervention we seek isn't limited to one aspect of our existence. The process of opening can manifest across the entirety of our being, touching different dimensions of our self. *"The opening that we pray for with Ya Fattah can occur on the different planes of our being. There can be an opening in the world of Nasut, our physical and social life... There can be an opening in the Malakut, the world of the heart... And there can be an opening in the Jabrut, the world of the soul..."* Thus, the

divine opening is not confined to a single dimension, but can transform our outer circumstances, deepen our inner experience, and unveil profound spiritual truths, guiding us toward wholeness.

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From Fleeting State (Hal) to Lasting Station (Maqam)

Source: CT4 · March 28, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

The goal of our spiritual practice is not merely to experience beautiful moments, but to allow those moments to profoundly reshape who we are. We cultivate states in meditation, but the deeper aim is for these to become lasting qualities that inform our everyday existence. As it is taught, *"There is a distinction in Tasawwuf between a Hal, a temporary spiritual state, and a Maqam, a permanent spiritual station. An experience of opening through Ya Fattah may initially come as a fleeting Hal… Through consistent practice and the steadfastness of Sabur, this temporary state can become integrated into our being and established as a stable Maqam…"* This means that through dedicated engagement with the Wazifa and cultivating virtues like patience, the glimpses of divine reality transform us, establishing a new level of consciousness from which we live and interact with the world.

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Connecting with the Living Spirit of the Lineage

Source: CT4 · March 28, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

Our spiritual journey is not one we undertake alone; it is sustained by a continuous stream of grace and wisdom from those who have walked this path before us. The spiritual lineage, or Silsila, is not merely a historical record but a living current of support. In this understanding, *"The teachings we share come to us through a lineage of masters, including my father, Pir Vilayat Inayat Khan, and his close disciples like Mansur Kreps and Pir Dahan. Their presence and Baraka are not confined to their physical lives. When we engage with the teachings they transmitted, we are connecting with their living spirit…"* This profound connection means that the spiritual inheritance, a Wiratha, continues to flow. Their Baraka and support are always available to us on the inner planes, transforming our practice from a solitary endeavor into a shared journey, drawing from centuries of divine wisdom and illumination.

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The Qutb: The Spiritual Axis of the Age

Source: CT4 · March 28, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

In our contemplation of the divine unfolding, we recognize that grace is channeled through specific points of focus. There exists a profound spiritual principle guiding the flow of divine blessings to all creation. *"In every age, there is a Qutb, a spiritual axis, who is the focal point for the divine grace flowing to the world. The Qutb is the supreme channel for the quality of Fattah, the opening of the ways for humanity."* While we may not know this Qutb personally, by aligning our hearts with the intention of universal service, we connect with this central current of grace. This connection facilitates the necessary openings and guidance, illuminating the path for both individual seekers and the collective awakening of humanity.

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The Journey Through the Lata'if (Subtle Centers)

Source: CT4 · March 28, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

The path of awakening involves a profound exploration of our inner landscape, a journey through various subtle dimensions of our consciousness. This process of unveiling our true nature is often met with internal resistance, requiring a divine key to unlock its potential. *"The journey of awakening can be pictured as a progression through the subtle centers of consciousness, the Lata'if: from the Nafs, the ego-self, to the Qalb, the heart, then to the Ruh, the spirit, and finally to the Sirr, the secret, innermost core of our being. Each of these centers is like a chamber with a locked door. The key to all these doors is the grace of Ya Fattah, the Opener."* By invoking Ya Fattah, we invite the divine grace to clear the way, enabling us to move from the confines of the ego towards our true, innermost essence and experience unity.

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Clarifying the Term 'Soul': Ruh, Not Nafs

Source: CT6 · March 29, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

When we speak of the *"soul"* in the context of Murshid's teaching and Sufi practice, it is vital to clarify our terminology, as translations can sometimes lead to imprecision. This distinction is crucial for navigating the subtle anatomy of our being and deepening our contemplation. As Pir Zia states, *"in Murshid's teaching and in Suluk, soul means Ruh, not Nafs, Ruh. The heart is the Qalb, and the soul is the Ruh."* This definition highlights that while Nafs relates to the mental or egoic self, Ruh refers to

the pure spirit, fresh-sprung from the divine source. By understanding that the Qalb, or subtle heart, matures out of the Nafs and is distinct from the Ruh, we can more accurately engage with these different modalities of inner experience. This precision guides our practice in approaching these distinct portals of being.

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A Caution for Contemplating Fire

Source: CT6 · March 29, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

We now approach a fiery landscape contemplation, a practice that invites us to open ourselves to the unexpected and perhaps encounter things long forgotten. While contemplation generally offers profound insights, this particular visualization, rich with flashes and sparks of light and fire, calls for a special degree of self-awareness and care. As I suggest with all practices, but especially here, *"I would, uh, advise caution, um, once again, and especially in this, uh, case where we're we're dealing with fire… be be, you know, be easy on yourself."* If you have any background of trauma or sensitive experiences related to fire, it is perfectly acceptable to opt out of this specific exercise. Remember to always prioritize your well-being and meet yourself with gentleness on this path of spiritual exploration. This teaching reminds us that true spiritual practice always includes self-compassion.

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PART II

THE EASTER RETREAT

Contemplation · April 18–19, 2026 · CT7–CT10

Pir Zia Inayat-Khan is the spiritual leader of the Inayatiyya and grandson of Hazrat Inayat Khan. He taught Section I of the Contemplation program (CT1–CT10) across two retreat weekends: the Spring Retreat of March 27–29, 2026 (CT1–CT6) and the Easter Retreat of April 18–19, 2026 (CT7–CT10).

Saturday, April 18, 2026 (CT7, CT8)
Sunday, April 19, 2026 (CT9, CT10)

77 Teachings · 9 Chapters

Part II · Chapter 1

PRAYERS & INVOCATIONS

The Sacred Words That Open the Way

Contemplation opens, as the Suluk opens, with prayer. Pir Zia taught the foundational invocations of the Inayatiyya — the Opening Invocation, Saum, Salat, Salawat, and the prayers of the lineage — as the living liturgy within which every contemplation is framed.

12 Entries · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

The Journey is in Each Step

Source: CT7 · April 18, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

THE DESTINATION IS PRESENT IN THE STEP

We are travelers in a caravan, *"finding our footing on the path that can only be taken one step at a time."* This requires a reorientation of our perspective away from a distant goal and toward the reality immanent in the process itself.

"Somehow the whole journey is present in each step. The destination is already right here with us each step along the way."

REALIZING YOUR DIVINE INHERITANCE

The spiritual path is not about acquiring something new, but about realizing what is already within you.

"The whole of the path consists of this, not obtaining something external, but activating and realizing and integrating what is already one's own. Your birthright, your divinely appointed nature."

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Opening Invocation

Source: CT7 · April 18, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

This invocation is a central part of our practice, a way to orient ourselves before we delve deeper into the nature of being. It guides us in contemplating the divine presence and our connection to it. As we begin our contemplation, we turn our hearts and minds: *"Toward the one, the perfection of love, harmony, and beauty. The only being, united with all the illuminated souls who form the embodiment of the messenger,*

the spirit of guidance." This profound prayer directs our intention towards the ultimate source of all existence, recognizing the unity of all enlightened beings in manifesting divine guidance. It sets the stage for our journey of self-discovery, inviting us to activate our dormant subtle faculties and realize our divine inheritance.

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The Copper Rule of Willing Help

Source: CT8 · April 18, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

THE RULE

"My conscientious self, extend your help willingly to those in need."

The rules always begin with the phrase *"My conscientious self,"* which is a crucial reminder of their purpose.

"It means that we're speaking to ourselves. We're not, um, pointing a finger at anyone else, and we're not going to use these rules to admonish anyone. Everyone is responsible for themself and accountable to their own conscience."

"We're speaking to that dimension of ourself which is awake and aware, conscientious, mindful, bringing it to the fore."

MUTUAL SUPPORT

"You can imagine a world in which when people found themselves in real need, others recognized the fact and were there to help. It could happen to any of us at any time."

Life is a series of changing roles. In one season we may find ourselves in need, and in another, we may be in a position to offer help.

"If we're all committed to the principle, we can all find our way through together. But if everyone is out for themself, in the end, everyone loses."

THE STORY OF THE FOUR FRIENDS

A Jataka tale illustrates this principle. There were four friends living in a forest: a hare, a jackal, an otter, and a monkey. The hare proposed that on the next holy day, they should fast and offer whatever food they found to someone who might be hungry. The friends all agreed.

The next morning, the jackal found a jar of milk and a piece of meat. The otter found fish buried in the sand. The monkey plucked ripe mangoes from a tree. Each of them, while willing to give their findings away, secretly hoped they would get to keep the meal for themselves.

The hare, however, was in a state of apprehension. *"I eat grass, but no one else eats grass."* What could he possibly offer?

Meanwhile, a fairy, the guardian spirit of the forest, had overheard their pledge and decided to test their resolve. Disguised as an emaciated old woman, she approached each of them in turn. The jackal, the otter, and the monkey all willingly offered up their food when she asked, but each time, she declined and moved on.

Finally, she came to the hare, who had nothing to give. He was utterly distraught until an idea flashed in his mind.

"I have nothing to give, but let me just give myself."

He asked the old woman if they could make a fire. She caused a fire to leap up.

"And the hare smiled and without any hesitation, leaped into the fire to be cooked, to be offered as food for the crone."

But something strange occurred--the flames were cool. The fairy revealed her true form and said, *"Oh, hare, I never meant to eat*

you. I was just playing a game, but your heart is so pure, so generous, so kind."

Then the fairy drew energy from a nearby hill, lifted her wand to the moon, and inscribed the hare's portrait upon it.

"And that's why when you go out to do your Shughl-i-Mahtabi at night on a clear night and you look up at the moon, you just might see a hare gazing down at you."

THE MEANING

"A story like this can say many things. Of course, it's a celebration of generosity and particularly the willingness to help someone in their hour of need, even if it means personal sacrifice."

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Closing Prayer: Most Gracious Sovereign

Source: CT8 · April 18, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

After grounding ourselves in the earth and opening our crown to the infinite, we rise to offer our closing prayer. This sacred invocation unites our hearts in humility and devotion as we address the boundless divine presence: *"Most gracious sovereign, messenger, messiah, savior of humanity. We greet thee with all humility. Thou art the first cause and the last effect, the divine light and the spirit of guidance, alpha and omega."* This profound address illuminates the omnipresent nature of God, recognizing the Beloved as the origin and culmination of all existence, manifested in countless forms and names throughout history and in every being. Through such recognition, we seek to experience the divine light shining within all hearts, fostering unity and a shared sense of family under God's parenthood.

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The Interplay of Inner and Outer Worlds

Source: CT9 · April 19, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

DIFFERENT MODES OF AWARENESS

"The outside world is not only outside, and the world within is not only within."

"At night when we close our eyes and go to sleep, what seemed to be the outside world enters us and becomes the world within. And when we wake up in the morning and remember our dreams and form our intentions for the day, the world within radiates out and fills the space that surrounds us."

This realization leads to a new understanding of perception. *"Within and without are not different places, they're different modes of awareness."*

A FIKR PRACTICE

This understanding can be practiced as a Fikr, a prayerful remembrance of the divine presence in both realms.

1. **On the exhale:** *"Be thou before me when I am awake"*
2. **On the inhale:** *"and within me when I am asleep"*

THE INTENTION OF THE PRAYER

"The greatest prayer is when that which we ask is the one from whom we ask it. I don't ask anything from you, beloved, but your own being. I ask to be with you."

This practice is an affirmation of our intention to perceive the divine in all states. *"Whether we look through physical senses or subtler senses, the prayer is, may these senses meet you."*

"So when we say this prayer, it isn't really so much to ask for something that as of yet isn't here, but the prayer signifies our own intention to meet what is here, to wake up to it, to be present."

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A Fikr Practice for Divine Presence

Source: CT9 · April 19, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

A prayerful Fikr (remembrance) to realize the divine presence that is already here, whether our senses are turned outward to the world or inward to the states of sleep and dream.

A PRAYER TO MEET WHAT IS HERE

"Fa-aynama tuwallu fa-thamma wajhu-Llah. Wheresoever you turn, there is the divine face."

"When we say this prayer, it isn't really so much to ask for something that as of yet isn't here, but the prayer signifies our own intention to meet what is here, to wake up to it, to be present."

"And really all prayers are like this, if one looks deeply into them. Whenever we lift up our hands and ask for blessings, in the act of asking, we are turning our attention to the blessing that is already here for us. The imagined future is realized in the prayerful present."

THE PRACTICE

1. As you exhale, say the words: *"Be thou before me when I am awake."*
2. As you inhale, say the words: *"and within me when I am asleep."*
3. Practice first with spoken words, then move to reciting them silently within.
4. Finally, *"let the words dissolve away. So what remains is simply the intention."*

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Opening Invocation: The Perfection of Love, Harmony, and Beauty

Source: CT9 · April 19, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

Beloved ones, let us gently draw a breath, allowing the outer world to soften, and turn our gaze inward, towards the heart's sanctuary. For in this sacred space, we seek to attune ourselves to the source of all existence, that infinite ocean from which all arises. As we gather for contemplation, let us open to the radiant presence permeating creation, whispering truth through silence, singing beauty through the manifest. With this intention, this yearning for union, we offer the timeless invocation: *"O Thou, the One, the perfection of love, harmony, and beauty, the only being, united with all the illuminated souls who form the embodiment of the messenger, the spirit of guidance."* May this sacred utterance resonate within, awakening us to divine grace and preparing our hearts to receive wisdom. Let us simply be present, imbued with this truth.

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The Song of Your Life

Source: CT10 · April 19, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

SPEECH BEYOND AUDIBLE WORDS

To be a servant of the divine speaker is to find a natural alignment where our words are attuned to the moment, rather than to become self-conscious and nervous.

"The goal is to find such natural alignment in one's way of being that one's words are naturally attuned to the situation in which you find yourself."

This care extends beyond audible words, as they are only one form of speech. We also speak with our thoughts and, most powerfully, with our actions.

"As the saying goes, actions speak louder than words. We communicate not only by forming words in our mouths, we communicate in many ways. Everything we do represents a form of communication."

YOUR LIFE'S ANSWER TO THE DIVINE MESSAGE

This raises a fundamental question about the message we are communicating through our very existence.

"What am I saying in life? What is my life saying? What is the message of how I live?"

"After all, the message of your life is your answer to the divine message. God is speaking to us, the divine voice speaks on all sides, and then we're given the chance to answer."

The spiritual quest is to find the unique melody of our being. By attuning to this inner song, our speech can flow naturally from that state rather than from careful, conscious thought.

"How does our life speak or sing? What is the song of your life?"

"And when you more and more have a feeling for that, the song, the melody of it, the character of it, then you'll find that instead of having to think hard about each word, you just attune to the melody that's coming through your being, and it guides your speech."

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Before You Play Your Music, Let Me Sing My Song

Source: CT10 · April 19, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

"This is what Murshid describes in one of his very last poems. I'd like to share it with you. The poem is a prayer to God."

A PRAYER TO GOD

"Before you judge my actions, Lord, I pray you will forgive. Before my heart has broken, will you help my soul to live? Before my eyes are covered, will you let me see your face? Before my feet are tired, may I reach your dwelling place?"

"Before I wake from slumber, you will watch me, Lord, I hold. Before I throw my mantle, will you take me in your fold? Before my work is over, you, my Lord, will right the wrong. Before you play your music, will you let me sing my song?"

THE QUEST TO SING YOUR SONG

"The final verse of the prayer keeps resounding. Will you let me sing my song?"

"Our quest is to find our song and to, and to sing it with the divine permission. For this we need the grace of Al-Kalim. Because God is the speaker and God is the singer."

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Prayer of Saum (in Dutch)

Source: CT10 · April 19, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

Our quest is to find our song and to sing it with divine permission. For this, we need the grace of Al-Kalim, the Speaker, for God is the speaker and the singer. It is in this spirit of profound trust that we offer this prayer: *"Algenadigste Heer, Boodschapper, Messias en Verlosser van de mensheid, wij groet U in alle ootmoed. Gij zijt de eerste oorzaak en het laatste gevolg, het goddelijk licht en de geest van leiding, Alfa en Omega. Uw licht is in alle vormen. Uw liefde in alle wezens."* This prayer seeks to recognize the Divine in all its sacred names and forms, inviting us to see the presence of God illuminating our

path at every junction and unifying humanity in divine parenthood.

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The Inayati Invocation

Source: CT10 · April 19, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

The divine voice constantly speaks to us, manifesting on all sides, and it is our profound trust to respond to this creative act. Our hearts, as the meeting place of heaven and earth, are uniquely poised to receive this constant divine communication. This is why the Inayati Invocation begins with this profound plea: *"Thou who art the perfection of love, harmony, and beauty, the sovereign of heaven and earth, open our hearts that we may hear thy voice, which constantly cometh from within."* This prayer serves as a powerful means to attune our being to the perpetual stream of divine guidance that resides within each of us. By earnestly seeking this inner communication, we allow the light of the spirit to illuminate our path, enabling us to find our unique song and sing it, bringing forth our perfect nature.

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The Inayati Benediction

Source: CT10 · April 19, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

As we conclude our contemplation and prepare to go our different ways, know that our heart-to-heart connection remains constant, and the light of the spirit of guidance illuminates your path at every junction. In this spirit of divine presence and companionship, I offer this benediction for your ongoing journey: *"May your heart be filled with heavenly joy. May your*

soul be illumined with divine light. May your spirit unfold the divine message. May you go on in the spiritual path. May God's peace abide with you forever and evermore. Amen." This blessing serves as a continuous source of strength and inspiration, encapsulating the essence of our aspiration for a life lived in divine attunement, marked by spiritual progress and the unwavering presence of God's peace, uniting us in this sacred companionship forever and evermore.

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Part II · Chapter 2

BREATH PRACTICES

The Rhythm That Carries the Contemplation

The breath is the bridge between body and spirit, between the outer world and the inner chamber. These practices — purification breaths, elemental breaths, and the breath of Haq — prepare the ground on which every contemplation stands.

16 Entries · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

The Lataif as Divine Inheritance

Source: CT7 · April 18, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

ACTIVATING WHAT IS ALREADY ONE'S OWN

"The whole of the path consists of this, not obtaining something external, but activating and realizing and integrating what is already one's own. Your birthright, your divinely appointed nature."

The Lataif--the subtle centers of our being--are not new knowledge to be acquired, but dormant faculties to be awakened. *"Murshid calls it a divine inheritance."*

THE TREASURE IN THE WALL -- AN ANALOGY

The Quran tells a story of Khidr and Moses arriving in a village where the people were unfriendly. Despite their rudeness, Khidr stopped to rebuild a wall that had fallen down.

"Later on, Khidr explained that it was because in the wall, a treasure was hidden, and that treasure was the inheritance of some orphans of the town."

"Because the people of the town were so ill-dispositioned, if they had seen the treasure before the orphans had grown to the age when they could claim it, the town's people would have taken it for themselves. Something was hidden for the children that would have been discovered by them and claimed by them when the time was right."

RECEIVING YOUR INHERITANCE

"And so it is that in this universe there are inheritances that are meant for souls, meant for discovery by them when the time is right. When we are ready for them, when we have the means to use them."

"There is a knowledge that it's already your own, it's your inheritance, but it only reaches you when the time is right. So the teachings on the Lataif are like this."

"The Lataif are the limbs and organs of our own bodies, they're already ours. But the introduction to them... comes when we are ready."

THE MEETING OF SEEKER AND LINEAGE

"Readiness comes when the seeker's motivation and dedication is clear, and when the lineage of those who came before is ready to meet the seeker in that intention. And there's a mutual joy in the in the meeting and in the transmission."

"It was meant to be received and it was meant to be passed down."

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Contemplating the Ruh: The Light of Vision

Source: CT7 · April 18, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

A practice for contemplating the Ruh, the subtle center on the right side of the chest, by cultivating spaciousness and embodying its light as the very substance of vision.

THE PRACTICE OF PREPARATION

1. Turn your attention to the right side of the chest. *"Let the weight come off your shoulders. Let your chest open."*
2. Create a feeling of permeability and receptivity. *"Let your skin become translucent. The hard edges of your being soften."*
3. Allow this softening to create an inner atmosphere. *"And with that softening comes a sense of expansion, spaciousness, lightness of being."*

EVOKING THE SENSIBILITY

"Sometimes an evocation of celestial grace and subtlety will help orient you to what is there."

These images can help conjure the sensibility of the Ruh:

- *"I envision a swan gliding."*
- *"Or the crescent of the moon, a lake shimmering at night under the moon."*
- *"A gossamer elegance."*
- *"Or you might think of entering a crystal cavern or moving in a landscape of ice and snow."*

THE REVERSAL OF PERCEPTION

Once you sense the quality of the Ruh, you can let go of the images and give yourself over to its character.

"The light of the Ruh... might at first appear as something that you are encountering and contemplating. But more and more a reversal takes place."

"And now it isn't that you are looking upon the light of the Ruh, but rather the light of the Ruh is your vision. It's the substance of your vision. You don't see it, but you see by it."

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The Fiery Sun of the Heart

Source: CT7 · April 18, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

A contemplation on the Qalb--the heart center on the left side of the chest, characterized by the fiery blaze of the sun.

ACCESSING THE HEART'S LIGHT

"Spaciousness still holds the key."

To access this center, feel into the space within the physical body, allowing the subtle light to emerge from within that spaciousness.

"The space between the ribs, the space between the tissues of the organ of the heart, between cells, between molecules, between atoms."

"In the space, the light of the heart wells up."

THE RED SUN OF THE QALB

This center is evoked by symbols of vibrant, active, and potent life.

"The red rose with its pungent fragrance and its bright vermilion hue and its sharp thorns."

It stands in dynamic contrast to the Ruh, the center on the right side of the chest.

"The cool passivity of the moon characterized the the Ruh. The fiery blaze of the sun characterizes the Qalb. It's the red sun opposite the white moon."

THE PRACTICE -- LET THY SUN SHINE

"The sun of the heart is an atom of the divine sun."

Connect the personal heart-fire to its universal source with this breath practice from Hazrat Inayat Khan:

1. On the in-breath, silently repeat: *let thy sun*
2. On the out-breath, silently repeat: *shine in my heart*

"And so we say with Murshid, inhaling, let thy sun, exhaling, shine in my heart."

"And then let the words dissolve away, but stay with the experience."

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Progression of the Lataif: From Belly to Chest

Source: CT7 · April 18, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

FROM EARTH TO HEAVEN

"We began with the center at the belly, and then went on to the center in the forehead, from the Nafs to the Khafi..."

INTO THE HEART

"...and then on to the centers of the left and right side of the chest, which are solar and lunar in nature."

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Lost and Found: The Timely Appearance of Sacred Knowledge

Source: CT7 · April 18, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

THE REAPPEARANCE OF TREASURE

"Even to this day, there are things that Murshid wrote, writings of Pirzadi Shahida Noor, which have disappeared only to suddenly appear. And whenever these treasures appear, I know it is because they are now given to us, we're meant to have them, to learn from them."

YOUR OWN INHERITANCE

"And that is true in the in the life of each of us, there is a knowledge that it's already your own, it's your inheritance, but it only reaches you when the time is right."

THE RIGHT TIME FOR THE LATAIF

"So the teachings on the Lataif are like this. The Lataif are the limbs and organs of our own bodies, they're already ours. But the introduction to them in a world in which so much knowledge

is forgotten, so much of our true nature is veiled, the introduction comes when we are ready."

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A Breath for the Sun of the Heart

Source: CT7 · April 18, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

As we delve into the subtle centers of our being, focusing on the Qalb, the heart, we recognize it as more than just an organ; it is a fiery blaze, a divine inheritance, truly an atom of the divine sun within us. This profound realization allows for the conscious unfoldment of our inherent spiritual faculties. We embrace this deep connection, understanding that the very light of the heart wells up from this sacred, deeper source, ready to be activated. And so we say with Murshid, *"inhaling, let thy sun, exhaling, shine in my heart. Inhaling, let thy sun, exhaling, shine in my heart."* This is a potent invocation, a sacred breath practice to continually draw the divine radiance into our innermost being. Allow its warmth and illumination to manifest fully within your heart, letting the words dissolve and abiding in this sacred experience.

In Pir Zia's own words: *"And so we say with Murshid, inhaling, let thy sun, exhaling, shine in my heart. Inhaling, let thy sun, exhaling, shine in my heart."*

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The Jataka Tale of the Four Friends

Source: CT8 · April 18, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

"There's a story that illustrates this in a moving way. And it's one of the Jataka tales… retold by Pirzadi Shahida Noor."

THE PLEDGE

"There were four friends, a hare, and a jackal, and an otter, and a monkey. And they lived in the forest."

One day, the hare reminded them that the following day was a holy day. *"And so the hare said, why don't we do something different? Instead of eating the tasty things we find as usual, why don't we fast? And whatever we find, we'll offer it to someone who may be hungry."*

The friends all agreed to this and went their ways.

THE FINDINGS

The next morning, the jackal found a jar of milk and a piece of meat. *"And he called out, does this milk and meat belong to anyone? And there was no one there, so he thought, might as well be mine... if anyone needs it, I'll give it to them, but otherwise, I'll have a delicious meal."*

The otter found fish buried in the sand. *"So the otter said, do these fish belong to anyone? ...if no one asks for them, when the day's fast is over, it'll be a real pleasure to sink my teeth into them."*

The monkey found ripe mangoes *"and thought to himself, we'll see if anyone comes along, otherwise, these will be mine."*

The hare, however, was in a state of apprehension. *"What can I find? What can I offer? I eat grass, but no one else eats grass."*

THE TEST

A fairy in the forest heard their pledge and became intrigued. *"And she decided to test the confederates to determine the extent of their resolve."*

Disguised as a bent, old, emaciated lady, she approached the jackal, then the otter, then the monkey.

"And the monkey, like his friends had secretly hoped that no one would ask for what he had, but when he was asked, he was quite willing to offer it up…"

In each case, the friend willingly offered their findings, and in each case, the fairy declined and moved on.

THE ULTIMATE OFFERING

Finally, she came to the hare, who had nothing to give and was utterly distraught.

"And suddenly an idea flashed in his mind. I have nothing to give, but let me just give myself."

He asked the old crone to make a fire. She caused a fire to leap up. *"And the hare smiled and without any hesitation, leaped into the fire to be cooked, to be offered as food for the crone."*

But something strange occurred: *"there was no blistering, there was no burning, there was no singeing of fur. The flames were cool."*

The fairy revealed herself. *"Oh, hare, I never meant to eat you. I was just playing a game, but your heart is so pure, so generous, so kind."*

She then lifted her wand to the moon and inscribed a shape. *"And the hare looked up and saw his own portrait on the moon."*

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The Hare's Ultimate Sacrifice

Source: CT8 · April 18, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

THE GIFT OF SELF

When the fairy, disguised as an old crone, came to the hare, he was distraught. He had nothing to give.

"Suddenly an idea flashed in his mind. I have nothing to give, but let me just give myself."

He asked the crone to make a fire. She caused one to leap up.

"And the hare smiled and without any hesitation, leaped into the fire to be cooked, to be offered as food for the crone."

But a miracle occurred--there was no burning, no blistering, no singeing of fur.

"The flames were cool. As the flames that enwrapped Abraham proved cool when Abraham was in a garden in the flames."

THE PORTRAIT ON THE MOON

The fairy revealed her true form and spoke to the hare with a smile.

"Oh, hare, I never meant to eat you. I was just playing a game, but your heart is so pure, so generous, so kind."

Then the fairy directed her wand to a nearby hill, drawing its telluric magnetism into her wand. She lifted it to the moon and inscribed the hare's portrait.

"And that's why when you go out to do your Shughl-i-Mahtabi at night on a clear night and you look up at the moon, you just might see a hare gazing down at you."

THE ALCHEMY OF SELF-GIVING

This story is a celebration of generosity--*"particularly the willingness to help someone in their hour of need, even if it means personal sacrifice."*

There is a deeper, alchemical meaning in the fairy's actions.

"The fairy draws energy from the earth into her staff, and then uses that energy to etch a depiction of the face of the being to be hallowed in the moon, which symbolizes the soul. So the wand is like the central axis, and the axis is a link between celestial and terrestrial conditions."

"And through this alchemy of self-love and self-giving and the receipt of that kindness, something of our earthly incarnate

condition is essentialized and abstracted so that it ornaments the immaterial life of the soul."

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The Forest Fairy Saka and the Unsuria

Source: CT8 · April 18, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

GUARDIAN SPIRITS OF NATURE

"Many places in nature have guardian spirits."

"These are, these are Unsuria, these are earthly jinn, and sometimes hybrid jinn who occupy landscapes and who protect them in various ways or simply personify the energy of the place."

THE TEST OF RESOLVE

The fairy in this story, whose name is Saka, overheard the friends make their pledge the night before.

"And so she became very intrigued. She wanted to see what would happen. And she decided to to, uh, test the confederates to determine the extent of their resolve."

"And so she disguised herself as a bent old, emaciated lady and hobbled around."

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Telluric Magnetism and Shughl-i-Mahtabi

Source: CT8 · April 18, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

THE HARE IN THE MOON

"The fairy directed her wand to a nearby hill, and the telluric magnetism of the hill poured out from the hill into her wand. And then she lifted the wand to the moon and inscribed a shape. And the hare looked up and saw his own portrait on the moon."

"And that's why when you go out to do your Shughl-i-Mahtabi at night on a clear night and you look up at the moon, you just might see a hare gazing down at you."

AN ALCHEMY OF SELF-GIVING

"There's a detail in the story that's quite remarkable. No doubt you noticed how the fairy draws energy from the earth into her staff, and then uses that energy to etch a depiction of the face of the being to be hallowed in the moon, which symbolizes the soul."

"So the wand is like the central axis, and the axis is a link between celestial and terrestrial conditions."

"And through this alchemy of self-love and self-giving and the receipt of that kindness, something of our earthly incarnate condition is essentialized and abstracted so that it ornaments the immaterial life of the soul."

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Noor Inayat Khan's Sacrifice and the Jataka Tale

Source: CT8 · April 18, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

THE ALCHEMY OF SELF-GIVING

"And through this alchemy of self-love and self-giving and the receipt of that kindness, something of our earthly incarnate condition is essentialized and abstracted so that it ornaments the immaterial life of the soul."

"Beautiful story. It was, I believe it was the favorite of the Jataka tales that Noor told. It was her her personal favorite."

NOOR'S OWN SACRIFICE

"And tragically, as you know, she went into the fire in the end herself, and that was a consequence of her self-giving for the sake of those in need."

"And we can be sure that her insignia is emblazoned in the heavens."

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The Highest Form of Prayer

Source: CT9 · April 19, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

THE GREATEST PRAYER

"There are prayers in which we ask for something we wish for from the one whom we ask it from. But then the greatest prayer is when that which we ask is the one from whom we ask it."

This is a prayer that turns from all lesser requests to the source of all blessing itself.

"I don't ask anything from you, beloved, but your own being. I ask to be with you."

"I ask to be face to face with you. I ask to live in the light of your presence."

A PRACTICE OF PRESENCE

This prayer can be practiced as a Fikr, a remembrance with the breath.

1. As you exhale, say the words: *"Be thou before me when I am awake."*
2. As you inhale, say the words: *"and within me when I am asleep."*

"Whether we look through physical senses or subtler senses, the prayer is, may these senses meet you."

WAKING UP TO WHAT IS HERE

The meeting we pray for is already a reality.

"Fa-aynama tuwallu fa-thamma wajhu-Llah. Wheresoever you turn, there is the divine face."

"So when we say this prayer, it isn't really so much to ask for something that as of yet isn't here, but the prayer signifies our own intention to meet what is here, to wake up to it, to be present."

This is the deeper truth of all prayer. *"Whenever we lift up our hands and ask for blessings, in the act of asking, we are turning our attention to the blessing that is already here for us. The imagined future is realized in the prayerful present."*

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Contemplating the Borderland of Hirkalya

Source: CT10 · April 19, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

An entry into the Alam al-Mithal, the world of subtle images. The focus of this practice is not on the world around you, but on the nature of your own being in that imaginal realm.

"The focus is on who you are. What is the character of the body that you wear? What is the condition of your awareness?"

THE CONTEMPLATION

The key is to use the imagining faculty to discover the celestial reality behind your physical sheath.

"The key to this is to once more avail yourself of your imagining faculty, to represent to yourself faces of angels."

These faces have a unique quality, free from earthly preconceptions.

"If your attunement is close, they will seem very real indeed, but of a gossamer-like texture and immaculate like a porcelain doll. You will have to discount any conditioning from the romanticized pictures that some artists have made of angels."

"Know that you need to allow yourself to be transfigured by your exaltation and your communion with light."

THE BORDERLAND BETWEEN WORLDS

This practice takes place in a precise location: the borderland between Malakut (the world of subtle forms) and Jabrut (the formless world of pure spirit).

"The angels belong to Jabrut proper, and one cannot say that their faces have a form in their own homeland because Jabrut transcends form."

"But on the borderland between Jabrut and Malakut, Arwah, souls, begin to manifest in the realm of Ajsam, of bodies. And so the first glimmerings of lineaments begin to appear."

This liminal space, where the formless acquires the first hints of form, has a name.

"The angel is showing itself through the prism of the world of forms. This borderland is sometimes called the heaven of Alam al-Mithal, sometimes designated as Hirkalya."

This is the destination: *"envisioning the faces of the angels and the fiber of our own being in this borderland between form and the formless."*

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Discovering Your Celestial Counterpart

Source: CT10 · April 19, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

The focus of this contemplation is not on the world around you, but on who you are. *"What is the character of the body that you wear? What is the condition of your awareness?"*

"You are in an attunement that is conducive to getting to know more about the celestial counterpart of your being."

THE PRACTICE OF ATTUNEMENT

1. *"The key to this is to once more avail yourself of your imagining faculty, to represent to yourself faces of angels."*

2. *"You will have to discount any conditioning from the romanticized pictures that some artists have made of angels."*
3. *"Know that you need to allow yourself to be transfigured by your exaltation and your communion with light."*

THE CELESTIAL REALITY

"If your attunement is close, they will seem very real indeed, but of a gossamer-like texture and immaculate like a porcelain doll."

"Thanks to having followed your imagination, you have discovered the celestial reality behind your physical sheath."

THE BORDERLAND OF FORM

This experience takes place in *"the borderland between Malakut and Jabrut."*

"The angels belong to Jabrut proper, and one cannot say that their faces have a form in their own homeland because Jabrut transcends form."

"But on the borderland between Jabrut and Malakut, Arwah, souls, begin to manifest in the realm of Ajsam, of bodies. And so the first glimmerings of lineaments begin to appear." This borderland is sometimes called Hirkalya.

Here we go, *"envisioning the faces of the angels and the fiber of our own being in this borderland between form and the formless."*

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Entering Malakut with the Music of Victoria

Source: CT10 · April 19, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

A contemplative practice entering the Alam al-Mithal, the earth of Malakut, carried by the music of the composer Victoria.

THE INWARD FOCUS

In this entry, the primary orientation is not toward the external landscape of the subtle world, but toward your own state of being.

"The focus is not so much on the world around you, that will reveal itself in due course. But the focus is on who you are."

"What is the character of the body that you wear? What is the condition of your awareness?"

THE MUSIC'S ACCORD

The music is the vehicle that guides you into a new mode of being, one that is in harmony with the imaginal world.

"We're going to be guided into a certain mode of embodiment, a certain tenor of identity."

"And first we'll hear the words, then we'll let them sweep us into the world in which this form of embodiment is in accord with the bodies of all beings and of the earth itself, as we listen to the music."

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The Borderland of Hirkalya: Where Arwah meet Ajsam

Source: CT10 · April 19, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

TWO REALMS: MALAKUT AND JABRUT

The contemplative journey into *"the world of Malakut, which is the world of subtle images"* is often focused on a precise borderland between two great realms.

"The angels belong to Jabrut proper, and one cannot say that their faces have a form in their own homeland because Jabrut transcends form."

THE BORDERLAND OF HIRKALYA

The focus of this contemplation is the liminal space where the formless world of souls begins to interact with the world of subtle bodies.

"But on the borderland between Jabrut and Malakut, Arwah, souls, begin to manifest in the realm of Ajsam, of bodies."

It is here that the first hint of form appears. *"And so the first glimmerings of lineaments begin to appear. The angel is showing itself through the prism of the world of forms."*

This transitional zone has its own names. *"This borderland is sometimes called the heaven of Alam al-Mithal, sometimes designated as Hirkalya."*

OUR DESTINATION

"And this is where we go now, envisioning the faces of the angels and the fiber of our own being in this borderland between form and the formless."

Part II · Chapter 3

FIKR & ZIKR — REMEMBRANCE

Silent and Spoken Remembrance of the One

Fikr is the silent remembrance borne on the breath; Zikr is the spoken remembrance that resounds in the heart. Together they form the continuous thread of presence that contemplation gathers into a single luminous point.

8 Entries · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

Shaping Your Hereafter in the Now

Source: CT8 · April 18, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

THE INTERSECTION OF WORLDS

After returning from a visionary contemplation, we find that we don't have to exist entirely in one world or the other.

"You might keep one foot as it were in the gossamer landscape of moonlight and shimmering water, finding yourself at the intersection between two worlds, visionary and material."

THE GARDEN OF THE HEREAFTER IS GROWING NOW

Once a trail has been blazed into an inner landscape, it becomes easier to return.

"Having blazed a trail in that scene… you might find that it isn't difficult to go back there… simply by recollecting the state of being that is the key to that particular space."

This ability to travel inwardly by attuning our consciousness is the very method by which we shape our existence beyond this life.

"In fact, you can go anywhere in the universe by attuning to the nature of that place. And our hereafter will be the place that we've chosen for ourself by tuning our mind to it. So if we're going to be in a garden in the hereafter, that garden is already growing now."

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The Lataif Polarity of Innocence and Experience

Source: CT8 · April 18, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

A key dichotomy within the Lataif system is the juxtaposition of innocence and experience, represented by the soul (Ruh) on the right side and the heart (Qalb) on the left.

THE SOUL (RUH) — INNOCENCE

"On the right, the soul, which is innocent."

This center is distinct from the sagely self, which is *"seasoned by experience."* The soul, in contrast, remains untouched by the world.

"The soul is never seasoned in itself. The Ruh is simply the Ruh. It's Atman, it's sheer, luminous awareness. So we discern that capacity through the right side."

THE HEART (QALB) — EXPERIENCE

The countervailing side is the heart. *"If this is being, then becoming."*

The heart is the center for *"the process of experiencing life, empathizing, meeting fellow human beings and fellow beings generally in all kinds of vicissitudes and transformations of history and of the world, and finding a path of creativity and service... which brims with passion."*

"We can't really attribute passion to the Ruh. It's there in potential, but as yet in a very unheated form."

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Review of the Nafs and Sage Polarity

Source: CT8 · April 18, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

A review of the first polarity in the Lataif system—the juxtaposition of the socially conditioned self and the serene, far-seeing sage within.

THE NAFS — THE VALLEY BELOW

We begin with the center in the belly, the one most salient to our conditioned existence.

"We began with the the center that is perhaps more, most salient to our day-to-day social state of being. So much so that for many people, it's most of what one knows... it's kind of home base."

This is the socially situated self, reacting to circumstances.

THE SAGE — THE MOUNTAIN TOP

In contrast, there is a parallel center that offers a higher vantage point.

"There's a parallel center that, um, is to the Nafs what the mountain top is to the valley below, a higher vantage point, a place of farther vision."

This is the sage in you, a dimension accessed in moments of profound peace.

"There have been moments when you rise above the the fray of life and taste a certain peace and satisfaction, a calm that isn't disturbed by urgent longings. It's the the sage in you."

This quality often predominates in the later years of life, which is one reason we honor our elders.

"It tends to predominate in the latter years of life, particularly, the golden years of a life when one has one by one put aside the things that one has occupied oneself with and one is able to just be, to be a presence."

"That's why we honor our elders, because we sense in them that that station."

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The Couplet Rule: Guarding Against Arrogance

Source: CT9 · April 19, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

THE PLEDGE

"My conscientious self, to not look down upon the one who looks up to you."

THE DANGER ON THE PATH

One of the great dangers on the spiritual path is the emergence of a subtle conceit — an inflated sense of self that feels superior to others.

"It's just another kind of egotism. Whereas really, the essence of the path is all about becoming emptier and becoming ever more dedicated to the service of creation, not standing over and above others and looking down upon them, but accompanying them, serving them, loving them through siblinghood, beyond all distinctions and differences."

"All manner of piety and and worship and abstemiousness and fasts and every kind of religious virtue counts as nothing when arrogance is the yield."

THE MIRROR OF THE FAITHFUL

If you are on the path and making discoveries, it may attract the attention of others who are also seeking. The couplet rule is a reminder of how to hold this admiration.

"Don't let that attraction lead you to imagine yourself superior to the one who is drawn to you. They're drawn to what you've been drawn to."

"As the saying goes, al-mu'min mir'at al-mu'min, the faithful is a mirror of the faithful. If someone sees something beautiful in you, it's actually their own beauty that they're seeing in the mirror that you are. So when people honor you, when people admire you, recognize that the goodness that they're seeing is their own."

THE PATH OF HUMILITY

"People on the path aren't immune to hubris... sometimes find themselves in a false position, becoming arrogant, and the result is always some kind of downfall from that artificial position of superiority."

"To put yourself on a high pedestal is to prepare yourself for a fall. Stay close to the earth."

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The Faithful is a Mirror of the Faithful

Source: CT9 · April 19, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

THE FAITHFUL IS A MIRROR

When you are on the spiritual path, your discoveries will likely draw the attention of others who are seeking.

"But don't let that attraction lead you to imagine yourself superior to the one who is drawn to you. They're drawn to what you've been drawn to."

"And really, as the saying goes, al-mu'min mir'at al-mu'min, the faithful is a mirror of the faithful. If someone sees something beautiful in you, it's actually their own beauty that they're seeing in the mirror that you are."

"So when people honor you, when people admire you, recognize that the goodness that they're seeing is their own."

A CAUTIONARY TALE: THE HERMIT AND THE SINNER

A story is told of a hermit in the desert who lived a life of perpetual worship. One day, Jesus was passing through, and as they stood together, a third figure appeared--a man on his hands and knees, weeping.

"And he cried out, 'I've made so many mistakes, I've sinned so badly. Could there ever be hope for a sinner such as me?'"

When the sinner approached, hoping for a blessing, the hermit took Jesus by the arm and said: *"Let's, let's away. Um, we shouldn't let ourselves be caught up in the state of this reprobate."*

THE REVELATION

At these words, a revelation came to Jesus. There are two versions of the story:

In the Jalali (severe) version, Jesus tells the hermit: *"Don't worry, you won't be near him. He'll be in paradise."*

In the Jamali (beautiful) version, Jesus says: *"On this day, you both begin again. You, hermit, all of your prayers have been erased, and you must start afresh. And you, sinner, all of your sins are erased, and you too begin anew."*

THE LESSONS OF THE STORY

"It's a story that reminds us of two things. One is that it's never too late to repent and that sincere hope for divine forgiveness... is never too late. The divine forgiveness stops at nothing."

"The story also tells us that all manner of piety and and worship and abstemiousness and fasts and every kind of religious virtue counts as nothing when arrogance is the yield."

"To put yourself on a high pedestal is to prepare yourself for a fall. Stay close to the earth."

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The Hermit and the Sinner: The Jalali Version

Source: CT9 · April 19, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

A cautionary tale about the danger of spiritual pride, told through the encounter of a pious hermit, a repentant sinner, and

the prophet Jesus. This is the fierce (Jalali) version of the revelation.

THE ENCOUNTER

A weeping sinner approaches, crying out:

"I've made so many mistakes, I've sinned so badly. Could there ever be hope for a sinner such as me?"

Seeing him, the pious hermit pulls Jesus away, saying:

"Let's, let's away. We shouldn't let ourselves be caught up in the state of this reprobate."

THE JALALI REVELATION

"When Jesus heard these words, an inspiration, a revelation came to him. There are two versions of the story. There's a Jalali version and a Jamali version."

In the Jalali (severe, majestic) telling, the judgment is decisive:

"Jesus says to the hermit, 'Don't worry, you won't be near him. He'll be in paradise.'"

The hermit, with all his piety, is excluded from the company of the one he scorned. The Jamali (gentle) version of the same story is preserved in a separate teaching.

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A Breath for Heaven and Earth

Source: CT10 · April 19, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

THE SIRR — WHERE OPPOSITES MEET

"Shaykh Abu Sa'id al-Kharraz said, 'Look for God where the opposites meet.' And we look now to the center of the pattern, in the center of the chest."

This center is the Sirr, the secret. *"It's never one thing or the other. It's no one part of a pair. It's the crux, it's the intersection,*

it's the whole, where the physical planet is brought into an identity with the nameless and formless."

THE HUMAN BEING IS MY SECRET

"It is in this that we are of the divine, for the divine, and so it is said, 'Al-insanu sirri wa ana sirrul insan.' The human being is my secret, God says, and I am the secret of the human being."

"This secret is held at the crux, at the crossroads, at the center of it all, the Sirr."

THE PRACTICE

In the Sirr, the point where heaven and earth interface, we can engage a breath to harmonize these two dimensions of reality.

1. **Inhale:** Breathe in with the intention, *"Let the heavens be reflected in the earth."*
2. **Exhale:** Breathe out with the intention, *"Let the earth may turn into heaven."*

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The Path of Grace and Gentleness

Source: CT10 · April 19, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

THE CONSTANT CONNECTION

"All the while, our heart-to-heart connection will be constant. We are together in the work that we're doing, the practices that we're practicing. And more fundamentally, we're united in the companionship of this path."

A BLESSING FOR THE WAY

"May your steps be blessed, each footstep along the way. May you be protected and guided and consoled and uplifted."

"And may the purpose of your life become clearer and clearer so that you find all doubts vanishing, all anxieties disappearing,

and the light of the spirit of guidance illuminating your path at every junction."

THE SUPPORT OF THE LINEAGE

"Murshid is with us, the Silsila is with us, the prophets and prophetesses overlay us. The whole divine is here."

"And without any doubt, we will make our way to the destination by a path of grace and gentleness and endless beauty."

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Part II · Chapter 4

WAZIFA — WORKING WITH THE NAMES

The Ninety-Nine Names as Instruments of Transformation

The Names of God are not mere epithets but living attributes of the Divine. To repeat a Name with attention is to invite that quality to take root in the soul. This chapter gathers the wazifas given during the retreat — each a key to a particular door.

4 Entries · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

The Root of Creaturehood: Latifa Qalabiyya

Source: CT8 · April 18, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

One of the fundamental polarities in the landscape of the Lataif is between the root in the tailbone and the crown at the top of the head. The tailbone is the Latifa Qalabiyya.

THE MOLD OF BEING

The name *Qalabiyya* shares a root with *Qalb* (heart) and can mean *"the mold."* This reflects an ancient belief that the tailbone holds the essential pattern of our physical form.

"It's the idea that the template of the physical body lies in the tailbone. And therefore that the tailbone is the seed of the body of resurrection, which is based on the physical body."

OUR CRUDE CREATUREHOOD

"Sufis sometimes called it the crude creaturehood of a person."

This term is not derogatory. From the perspective of Tawhid, or oneness, the manifest and unmanifest are equal, and our physical incarnation is a sacred process.

"In Tawhid, in oneness, there is an equality between the visible and the invisible, the manifest and the unmanifest. We don't differentiate."

"So our crude creaturehood is intrinsic to the sacred process of our bearing witness to the divine treasure. And our incarnation has its role to play in this."

A TAPROOT TO THE PLANET'S CORE

Activating the awareness of the tailbone brings a profound and stabilizing quality of groundedness. It cultivates the quality of being deeply rooted, like a tree.

"There's a taproot that runs right down to the center of the planet."

This center connects us to the very foundation of our world.

"One can hardly imagine how marvelous is the domain beneath the earth's crust, the mineral and metallic and crystalline and magmic worlds underground leading to the planetary core. All of this is the foundation of the tailbone."

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The Nasama, the Ethereal Body, and the Ghost Limb

Source: CT8 · April 18, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

THE ENERGETIC MOLD AND THE GHOST LIMB

"It may not be that this body is built up solely upon the model of what is in the genome... but that there's an underlying energetic mold, which you can actually feel even in cases where, let's say a limb is missing."

"Captain Ahab in Moby Dick lost a leg but could still feel the leg. It's an example. It's called a ghost limb."

THE TEMPLATE OF OUR PHYSICALITY

"It's the principle that there is an underlying matrix that is the template of our physicality, and that it's the basis of regeneration--one basis of regeneration, the way that amphibians can regrow tails, for instance."

"And also it is rooted in the earth itself... and that rootedness functions primarily through the tailbone."

SACRED CREATUREHOOD

"Sufis sometimes called it the crude creaturehood of a person. That could sound derogatory, but... in Tawhid, in oneness, there

is an equality between the visible and the invisible, the manifest and the unmanifest."

"Our crude creaturehood is intrinsic to the sacred process of our bearing witness to the divine treasure. And our incarnation has its role to play in this."

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Al-Kalim: Divine Speech Through Imperfection

Source: CT9 · April 19, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

Al-Kalim, The Speaker, is the seventh of the seven leading divine names. It is profoundly associated with Prophet Moses.

THE PARADOX OF MOSES (KALIMULLAH)

"Prophet Moses, peace be upon him, Musa alayhi salam is called Kalimullah, the speaker with God, the speaker for God, the speaker of God."

"And the interesting thing is that Moses was known to have a speech impediment. His tongue was burned in childhood and he had difficulty speaking clearly. And he was the one that was chosen to speak for God in the court of the Pharaoh."

IMPERFECTIONS IN SERVICE OF A HIGHER PURPOSE

"It just may be that the divine guidance may use an instrument that seems to the world unsuited to the purpose."

"Maybe that even our limitations, our imperfections, lend themselves to a higher purpose."

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Zikr Practice of the Seven Leading Names

Source: CT9 · April 19, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

A practice in reciting the seven leading names, or *"mother names,"* to witness how divine qualities unfold into the symphony of creation.

AN UNFOLDING SYMPHONY

"This is a chance to say them one after another and see how one leads to another, how they cascade into creation, into manifestation, as an unfolding symphony of sacred witnessing."

THE PRACTICE

Recite the seven names in sequence, contemplating the flow from one divine quality to the next.

1. **Ya Hayyu** (The Living)
2. **Ya Alimu** (The Knowing)
3. **Ya Qadiru** (The All-Powerful)
4. **Ya Muridu** (The Willing)
5. **Ya Samiu** (The All-Hearing)
6. **Ya Basiru** (The All-Seeing)
7. **Ya Kalimu** (The Speaker)

THE SEVENTH NAME: AL-KALIM

The final name in the sequence is Al-Kalim, The Speaker.

"Prophet Moses, peace be upon him, Musa alayhi salam is called Kalimullah, the speaker with God, the speaker for God, the speaker of God."

"The interesting thing is that Moses was known to have a speech impediment. His tongue was burned in childhood and he had difficulty speaking clearly. And he was the one that was chosen to speak for God in the court of the Pharaoh."

"It just may be that the divine guidance may use an instrument that seems to the world unsuited to the purpose. Maybe that

even our limitations, our imperfections, lend themselves to a higher purpose.”

Part II · Chapter 5

CONTEMPLATION PRACTICES

Holding the One Reality in the Heart

At the center of the Suluk stands contemplation itself — mushahada, muraqaba, the gaze of the witness, the abiding in presence. These practices train the heart to hold a single reality until the veil between seeker and sought dissolves.

20 Entries · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

The Divine Senses: As-Sami' and Al-Basir

Source: CT7 · April 18, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

The seven *"mother names"* of God include a pair corresponding to our most predominant senses, hearing and seeing. These are not just human faculties, but cosmic principles.

"In the elaboration of the cosmos from the eternal source, in the course of creation, these two senses correspond to the most foundational developments in the crystallization of manifestation: vibration, corresponding with hearing, and light, corresponding with seeing."

FROM POWER TO PERCEPTION

The cosmos unfolds from raw power toward refined, loving intentionality--a process that necessitates the ability to perceive.

"The sheer intense willfulness of Qudrat, the power of Al-Qadir, gave way to the intentionality of Al-Murid."

"The discernment of possibilities, the pursuit of those possibilities, the construction of a whole universal architecture becoming increasingly complex, refined, organically interconnected, a process of tremendous intricacy, which bespeaks meaningfulness of an almost unfathomable degree."

AS-SAMI' -- THE ALL-HEARING

What emerges from love's quest? The need for true responsiveness. Acquisitive, projective love is immature; what is needed is the capacity to truly receive the other.

"What is needed is the ability to listen, and not only hear what you expect you're going to hear... Listening would require really being changed by what you hear, being ready to be surprised."

This deep listening attunes us to a cosmic symphony.

"When one listens very attentively, not only with the mind but with the heart, you find yourself in the middle of a planetary

symphony, the music of creation that communicates the emotion of the creator."

Ultimately, our hearing is a vessel for a greater hearing. *"Everything is heard by the divine audition, and you're simply participating in that endless listening."*

AL-BASIR -- THE ALL-SEEING

"Very close to As-Sami', the hearer, is Al-Basir, the seer. Hearing comes first because vibration arises before light. Light is an after-effect of vibration."

Like listening, true seeing goes beyond the surface to perceive the soul.

"This is the deeper seeing beyond surfaces, a kind of x-ray vision, seeing into minds, into hearts, into souls."

Our vision is a conduit for the divine vision.

"The Quran says regarding Allah, vision doesn't perceive Allah. Allah perceives vision."

"Even as we look for God, God is looking out through these searching eyes. And when we take heed of this, our glance is illuminated. We see better when we are not seeing for a self that begins and ends. Our seeing is given over to the divine sight."

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The Art of Deep Listening

Source: CT7 · April 18, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

FROM ACQUISITIVE TO MATURE LOVE

Love that is merely acquisitive and based on projection will never result in satisfaction. Mature love requires a deeper faculty.

"Love which is just acquisitive is very immature. It it's a kind of consumerism. One is trying to acquire an object."

"The love that is mature is a love that encompasses this reality of not a subject meeting an object, but a subject meeting a subject. And how each of them contains mystery, each of them possesses an infinite depth."

THE PRACTICE OF LISTENING

The key to this maturity is the ability to listen--not just to what you expect, but with a readiness to be transformed by what you hear.

"What is needed is the ability to listen, and not only hear what you expect you're going to hear, which is all too commonly the way of listening... Listening but just hearing what you expect, what your prejudice tells you you're going to hear."

"No, listening would require really being changed by what you hear, being ready to be surprised, not only listening to the words, listening to the cadence of the voice, the tone of the voice, what the person is saying, but also what's behind what the person is saying. Listening is a very deep art."

THE PLANETARY SYMPHONY

This deep listening can be extended beyond human conversation to the entire natural world.

"Listening to the voices of the birds in the morning, listening to the rustling of the leaves in the wind, the lapping of the waves, the crack of thunder."

"When one listens very attentively, not only with the mind but with the heart, you find yourself in the middle of a planetary symphony, the music of creation that communicates the emotion of the creator."

THE DIVINE LISTENER

Ultimately, our own listening is a participation in the divine audition.

"You are aware of God as the listener. So your hearing is simply a vessel for the divine hearing. You don't claim it as your own."

"Everything is heard by the divine audition, and you're simply participating in that endless listening."

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God is the Listener

Source: CT7 · April 18, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

THE ART OF DEEP LISTENING

Mature love requires the ability to listen--a practice that goes beyond merely hearing what you expect to hear.

"Listening would require really being changed by what you hear, being ready to be surprised, not only listening to the words, listening to the cadence of the voice, the tone of the voice, what the person is saying, but also what's behind what the person is saying. Listening is a very deep art."

When we listen with the heart, we find the divine voice communicating through all sounds, from the natural world to the industrial city.

"When one listens very attentively, not only with the mind but with the heart, you find yourself in the middle of a planetary symphony, the music of creation that communicates the emotion of the creator."

"Listen to it and listen to what is in the depths of it, listen to what's behind it. And you find that the divine voice is everywhere."

A SHIFT IN IDENTITY

The practice of listening has two stages. The first is honing your own listening. The second is a radical shift in identity.

"So first you're you're listening to sound that you know reaches you ultimately from the divine source, and you're honing your listening. But secondly, you are aware of God as the listener."

In this realization, your personal hearing becomes a vessel for the divine hearing. You do not claim it as your own.

"Everything is heard by the divine audition, and you're simply participating in that endless listening."

PRIMAL MEMORIES OF AUDITION

This deep listening can unlock primal memories, connecting you to the very source of sound and being.

"You might remember still earlier moments of audition when you were in the womb, listening to the mother's heartbeat. You might remember when it was music that led you into the womb to begin with. Your soul ushered down through the planes, through an aisle of resonant sound."

"You may even recall somewhere deep, deep down in your being, the very first encounter with the divine voice, the voice of which this whole creation is made."

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The Deeper Seeing of Al-Basir

Source: CT7 · April 18, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

COSMIC SEQUENCE

"Very close to As-Sami', the hearer, is Al-Basir, the seer. Hearing comes first because vibration arises before light. Light is an after-effect of vibration."

The evolution of our senses is an elaboration of love's need for responsiveness. As our capacity for love grows, the heart develops its own faculties of perception.

THE HEART'S EYES

"You might say your heart is growing ears and also eyes. Not only the eyes to see, let's say the obviously attractive contours which appear in this world, but eyes to see into other pairs of eyes."

"This is the deeper seeing beyond surfaces, a kind of x-ray vision, seeing into minds, into hearts, into souls."

THE DIVINE GLANCE

"The Quran says regarding Allah, vision doesn't perceive Allah. Allah perceives vision."

"So we're aware of our glance as a conduit for the divine glance. Even as we look for God, God is looking out through these searching eyes."

"And when we take heed of this, our glance is illuminated. We see better when we are not seeing for a self that begins and ends. Our seeing is given over to the divine sight."

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Love's Quest for Responsiveness

Source: CT7 · April 18, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

IMMATURE, ACQUISITIVE LOVE

"Love which is just acquisitive is very immature. It it's a kind of consumerism. One is trying to acquire an object."

This approach of projecting one's own desires and expectations onto another will never lead to fulfillment.

"To merely project one's expectations, project one's desires is is incomplete and will never result in satisfaction."

MATURE LOVE: SUBJECT TO SUBJECT

"But another person is not an object, another person is also a subject, just as each of us is a subject. And not only people are subjects, everything is a subject. Animals, plants, everything."

"The love that is mature is a love that encompasses this reality of not a subject meeting an object, but a subject meeting a subject."

In this meeting, we encounter the true nature of the other--a being with its own unfathomable depth.

"Each of them contains mystery, each of them possesses an infinite depth leading into the deepest heart of being."

THE ART OF DEEP LISTENING

To move from acquisitive love to mature love requires responsiveness--the ability to truly listen.

"What is needed is the ability to listen, and not only hear what you expect you're going to hear, which is all too commonly the way of listening, only half listening."

"No, listening would require really being changed by what you hear, being ready to be surprised... not only listening to the words, listening to the cadence of the voice, the tone of the voice, what the person is saying, but also what's behind what the person is saying. Listening is a very deep art."

"When one listens very attentively, not only with the mind but with the heart, you find yourself in the middle of a planetary symphony, the music of creation that communicates the emotion of the creator."

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Intoning the Names of Hearing and Seeing

Source: CT7 · April 18, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

DIVINE HEARING AND SEEING

"You are aware of God as the listener. So your hearing is simply a vessel for the divine hearing. You don't claim it as your own."

"The Quran says regarding Allah, vision doesn't perceive Allah. Allah perceives vision."

"Even as we look for God, God is looking out through these searching eyes."

"When we take heed of this, our glance is illuminated. We see better when we are not seeing for a self that begins and ends. Our seeing is given over to the divine sight."

THE PRACTICE OF INTONATION

A practice to experience the reality of As-Sami' (the Hearer) and Al-Basir (the Seer).

1. While intoning the name *As-Sami'*, give your attention to your ears.
2. While intoning the name *Al-Basir*, give your attention to your eyes.
3. In both movements of the practice, *"give them over to the divine."*

"Let God be the heard and the hearer. Let God be the seen and the seer."

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The Seven Mother Names: A Review of the Divine Attributes

Source: CT7 · April 18, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

THE DIVINE UNFOLDING

"Now, alongside the seven Lataif, we have also been gradually getting to know seven divine names, seven leading names, seven mother names."

"And these have been thus far, Al-Hayy, the living, Al-'Alim, the knowing, Al-Qadir, the powerful, and Al-Murid, the willing or the desiring."

THE SENSES OF THE COSMOS

The path now leads to a pair of attributes that govern perception and responsiveness: As-Sami' (The All-Hearing) and Al-Basir (The All-Seeing).

"They correspond to the senses which are the most explicit ones in our experience."

"In the elaboration of the cosmos from the eternal source, in the course of creation, these two senses correspond to the most foundational developments in the crystallization of manifestation: vibration, corresponding with hearing, and light, corresponding with seeing."

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The Gaze of the Heart and Limbic Resonance

Source: CT7 · April 18, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

THE HEART GROWS EYES

As your capacity for love grows, your heart develops its own senses.

"You might say your heart is growing ears and also eyes. Not only the eyes to see, let's say the obviously attractive contours which appear in this world, but eyes to see into other pairs of eyes."

LIMBIC RESONANCE AND DEEPER SEEING

This meeting of souls has a physiological basis--a deep resonance that goes beyond surface appearances.

"This meeting of glances brings about what scientists sometimes call limbic resonance. You see into the heart of a person, and your own heart is affected by the encounter."

"This is the deeper seeing beyond surfaces, a kind of x-ray vision, seeing into minds, into hearts, into souls."

THE DIVINE GLANCE

Our personal sight is a conduit for a perception that is vaster than our own.

"The Quran says regarding Allah, vision doesn't perceive Allah. Allah perceives vision."

"So we're aware of our glance as a conduit for the divine glance. Even as we look for God, God is looking out through these searching eyes."

When we realize this, our perception is transformed. *"Our seeing is given over to the divine sight."*

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Primordial Memories of Sound

Source: CT7 · April 18, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

Friends, our journey into profound hearing invites us to remember the earliest experiences of listening, moments that precede our conscious memory yet continue to resonate within us. By deeply tuning into the subtle vibrations that constantly surround and permeate our being, we can recall something truly ancient. *"You might remember still earlier moments of audition when you were in the womb, listening to the mother's heartbeat. You might remember when it was music that led you into the womb to begin with. Your soul ushered down through the planes, through an aisle of resonant sound."* This remembrance reveals that our very essence is woven from divine harmony, a primal music that not only initiated our existence but continuously offers guidance for our life's unfolding. It reminds us that our capacity for listening is a vessel for the divine audition itself.

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The Mind as an Accommodation of the World

Source: CT8 · April 18, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

THE MIND SURROUNDS THE WORLD

"All that exists, whether it is business or anything else, all that is visible or invisible, seems to be outside, but in reality, it is in our mind."

"It is outside because our eyes see it outside, but it is within us because the mind surrounds it. It is accommodated in our mind. Mind is an accommodation of the world which is outside."

The mind isn't smaller than the body--the mind is larger than the body.

"The body sits inside the mind. And whatever is perceived sits within the mind."

A HEART LARGER THAN THE UNIVERSE

"A Hindustani poet describes this wonderfully. The land and sea are not too large for the heart of man to accommodate."

"In other words, the heart of man is larger than the universe. If there were a thousand universes, the human heart could accommodate them."

THE IMPRESSION OF LIMITATION

"But we human beings, unaware of our inner being, impressed by outer limitation, remain under the impression of weakness, limitation, smallness."

"And that keeps one from using this great power, which one can find within oneself. This great light with which one can see life more clearly. It is only because one is unaware of oneself."

A REORIENTATION FOR CONTEMPLATION

This realization encourages a reorientation away from our ordinary perception.

"Instead of thinking of ourself as a bounded self situated in a larger world, a world through which we move, instead, one comes to experience the body as a figure moving within the field of consciousness, which subsumes everything you perceive."

"As we make our way into the domain of contemplation, we come to more and more identify with consciousness itself and all that it encompasses."

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Reorienting Perception Beyond Subject and Object

Source: CT8 · April 18, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

THE MEANING OF 'INNER'

We must be careful with the meaning we ascribe to language. In the inner life, does *"turning within"* mean that consciousness is located somewhere inside the body?

"No. By inner is meant a shift from the explicit to the implicit, from the obvious to the subtle. This shift doesn't take place spatially."

The mind is not a thing that sits inside the body; it is not smaller than the body. The mind is larger than the body.

"The body sits inside the mind. And whatever is perceived sits within the mind. So the mind pervades."

A REORIENTATION FOR CONTEMPLATION

This understanding encourages a fundamental reorientation. We move from the sense of a limited self in a vast world to an entirely different experience.

"Instead of thinking of ourself as a bounded self situated in a larger world, a world through which we move, instead, one comes to experience the body as a figure moving within the field of consciousness, which subsumes everything you perceive."

A UNIFIED FIELD OF PERCEPTION

This realization takes us beyond the reductionist view of a subject confronting an object.

"This universe is made of the overlapping perceptions of all perceiving beings, all of which are waves of the perception of the one ultimate perceiver."

In this unified field, the division between seer and seen dissolves. *"Subject and object participate in a unified manner in all that is perceived."*

As we deepen our practice, we come to identify more and more with consciousness itself and all that it encompasses.

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Musical Contemplation with Clair de Lune

Source: CT8 · April 18, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

"Shall we enter another landscape, another visionary landscape through a musical contemplation?"

This practice uses a vignette from Pir Vilayat Inayat Khan and the music of Debussy's *"Clair de Lune"* to enter a state of deep contemplation.

THE VISIONARY LANDSCAPE

"Imagine that you are wandering leisurely alongside a tranquil lake. So relieved to have escaped from the humdrum turmoil of life in our modern societies."

"The atmosphere is windless, nebulous, sedate, and eerie under the diaphanous glow of the full moon."

"The sheer sight of the stars peering through evanescent clouds confers a sense of immensity to the environment. The turbulence in your mind and emotions is becalmed. So you cannot resist the quiescence enveloping you. A sigh of relief infuses your being."

THE PRACTICE

1. Close your eyes and imagine yourself walking in this landscape.
2. The object of contemplation is the drizzling rain upon the lake.
3. *"As you watch the eddies formed by each drop of water as it impinges on the surface of the lake… you lose yourself in the elaborate wave interference patterns that they describe."*
4. Observe them *"as they merge and compose, dancing in covert collusion, glistening under the glary eye of the mystic full moon."*
5. Continue this contemplation for the duration of the music.

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Walking in a Living Tricosm

Source: CT9 · April 19, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

THE WORLD AS A TRICOSM

The practice of contemplative walking begins with a shift in perception.

"Discern the world around you not merely as a flat land devoid of spirit, but instead as a tricosm, brimming not only with matter but also with psychic life and spiritual life, in all manner of manifestations."

As you walk, be aware of the multiple dimensions of your being and your world, all present at once.

"Walking, aware of your breath, aware of your heartbeat, sensing the etheric body within your physical body and the psychic double at the same time and the the soul itself, all of these dimensions are simultaneous as you're walking."

"You're not alone. Innumerable beings surround you... The sun is shining down and all the stars are pouring their light down over the earth and into your flesh and blood and bones. Gravity is gently holding you to the earth. Gravity which itself is a phenomenon of Ishq."

SERVANT OF THE NAME

Into this practice, we introduce the sacred transmission of a divine name.

"It's a very precious transmission to receive a name that has been communicated through revelation, passed down from heart to heart, recited with deep devotion, lifetime after lifetime, and now entrusted to you."

"Entrusted to your vocal cords, entrusted to your breath, given over to your heart to recite and to contemplate."

"For the period of time when you are working with this name, you are a servant of the name. It becomes your identity and your responsibility and your character. This is the station you've taken on, a certain station of worship."

WALKING IN THE SPIRIT OF THE NAME

The name is not only to be recited, but enacted and embodied, especially during the contemplative walk.

"When you walk, walk in the spirit of the name. Let your gait, let your mode of walking reflect it, let your whole attitude reflect it."

"You fulfill the practice by not only saying the name, but enacting it in your actions, in your words, in your thoughts, noticing it around you in the world, in any number of beings, in

any number of landscapes, situations, you're always looking for and finding the traces of the name."

"And you'll be drawn to those who are deeply infused with the name and they'll be drawn to you. There's a common recognition which is that you're sharing in a secret, your participation in a quality of being that is unfolding its nature in creation."

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Becoming the Servant of a Divine Name

Source: CT9 · April 19, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

A SACRED TRUST

Receiving a divine name is a profound spiritual inheritance, a direct link in a chain of transmission.

"It's a very precious transmission to receive a name that has been communicated through revelation, passed down from heart to heart, recited with deep devotion, lifetime after lifetime, and now entrusted to you."

"You become in this way the Abd of the name you were given... For the period of time when you are working with this name, you are a servant of the name. It becomes your identity and your responsibility and your character."

LIVING THE NAME AMIDST LIFE'S CHALLENGES

The practice is not merely recitation, but embodiment--especially when faced with adversity.

"You fulfill the practice by not only saying the name, but enacting it in your actions, in your words, in your thoughts, noticing it around you in the world."

Life, however, presents challenges that can pull us away from this embodiment. We often respond not from our deepest self, but from a place of conditioning and fear.

"When we're not only challenged by complex situations, but we're specifically challenged by someone who is pressing on that vulnerability, well then the tendency is to react very unpurposefully, very reactively, with intense emotion and often without much insight."

THE PRACTICE OF THE PAUSE

This reactivity is a distraction from our purpose. The key is to create a space between the trigger and the response.

"It's very easy to be pushed into reactions that take us out of balance, take us out of wisdom, and lead to a spiraling confrontation that is a huge distraction from the real purpose of our human existence."

"The opportunity then is to, as always, pause. Not just react right away... You feel I've got to write a message and send it now. You feel I've got to just say what's on the tip of my tongue. It's very tempting. But if we can just learn at that moment to pause and breathe, we'll find there's always a better way."

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Using the Contemplative Walk for Guidance

Source: CT9 · April 19, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

When facing dilemmas or hardships, our first response is often reactive. *"Very often the response is something that comes from conditioning, it comes from fearfulness."* It's tempting to act immediately, but if we can learn to pause, we find there is always a better way.

"The action won't come well if it comes from sheer exasperation." The contemplative walk offers a method to move beyond reactivity and open to a wiser course of action.

THE PRACTICE FOR RECEIVING GUIDANCE

1. **Consider the Situation**

Before you walk, take a moment to hold the problem in your mind. *"Think about it, think about the different sides, who you think is right, who you think is wrong, what all of the evidence is from every point of view... Take a moment, just let that all be there in your mind."*

2. **Put It All Aside**

Once you have considered the matter, consciously release it. *"And then put it all aside. Put it completely aside."*

3. **Walk with Presence**

During the walk, your focus is not on the problem. *"You're not thinking about the situation. But you're also not repressing it, you're not running away from it... on the walk, you're just feeling every footstep... breathing the fresh air, you're airing out your heart, you're letting your heart breathe."*

4. **Listen for the Insight**

After walking for some time, an insight may arise naturally, not from effortful analysis but from a state of calm openness.

THE NATURE OF THE INSIGHT

This process creates the space for a solution to appear. *"It didn't come from thinking hard about the problem. It was just that after you cleared the air and breathed freely, you were shown what you need to do."*

This applies to intense conflicts as well as life's crossroads. It complements, rather than replaces, rational thought. *"You do your research, you think hard, but then you put it all aside and*

just breathe and walk and open yourself to guidance. And what comes then, that's what you listen to."

The guidance that emerges is distinct from a reactive impulse. *"It's not something that you're compelled to do by the intensity of your emotional reaction... it's just what guidance is showing you now that you've calmly put everything aside and walked through a landscape in the presence of God."*

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The Polarity of Belly and Forehead

Source: CT10 · April 19, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

A meditation on two centers of being — the belly, where a transitory self is made, and the forehead, the vantage point of the far-seeing sage.

THE BELLY — THE TRANSITORY SELF

"Now, if we look into the belly, we find that the bread we eat in this world is digested there, becoming our own flesh. A self is made there, a self that walks through the world through time and space."

"A self carrying a name and a profession, a self which is hauling along many other things as well: memories, fears, preferences."

"In the great scope of things, it's such a transitory little thing, only alive on this planet for a few years, a planet that is billions of years old. And yet, through this narrow gate, something enormous is passing."

THE FOREHEAD — THE SAGE'S VANTAGE

"Now, if we lift our attention up to the forehead, we have a different vantage point. We can see the horizons on all sides, see into the far distance, can even see into the life that will follow this life."

"We see that our human existence isn't the end of the story, and that whatever isn't resolved here will be resolved elsewhere."

"And there's a kind of mellowness that comes with this far-seeing, a fading of the appetites, or maybe a sharing of them with all beings so that you delight more in seeing someone you love partake of something delicious rather than partaking yourself."

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The Heart's Polarity: Serenity and Yearning

Source: CT10 · April 19, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

THE RIGHT SIDE OF THE CHEST — SERENE LIFE

"If we turn to the right side of the chest, we discern the sheer luminosity that has always been the basis of our being. Something fresh, pure, simple, vital."

THE LEFT SIDE OF THE CHEST — THE JOURNEYING HEART

"On the opposite side of the chest is another kind of vitality, not the vitality of the serene life that doesn't differentiate between here and there, but the vitality that moves, that journeys, that searches and creates."

"We find the heart's yearning, its pain and ecstasy."

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Earthly Roots and the Transcendent Abyss

Source: CT10 · April 19, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

This contemplation explores the two furthest poles of our being, connecting our most immanent, earthy nature with our most transcendent, formless potential.

THE PLANETARY INTELLIGENCE

In the tailbone, we connect to a deep, terrestrial wisdom--our rootedness in the physical world and the ancient life of our planet.

"In the tailbone, there's a root grounded in the ancient life of the planet, exquisitely earthy, chthonic, terrestrial, and very close to the being of the planetary intelligence..."

THE ABYSS BEYOND TIME AND PLACE

In contrast, the crown opens to the other extreme: the infinite reality beyond all manifestation. These two centers represent one of the three great pairs of opposites that define the spectrum of our being.

"We have three pairs: the ego and the sage, the innocence in us and the experience in us, the planetary intelligence and the abyss that transcends time and place."

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The Sirr: The Secret Where Opposites Meet

Source: CT10 · April 19, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

WHERE THE OPPOSITES MEET

"God is odd and loves odd numbers."

We contemplate three pairs: the ego and the sage; the innocence in us and the experience in us; the planetary intelligence and the abyss that transcends time and place.

"Where there is six, there will be a seventh. Where there are two poles, there will be a marriage and a child born."

Following the wisdom of Shaykh Abu Sa'id al-Kharraz, we *"look for God where the opposites meet."* We look to the center of the pattern, in the center of the chest--between the belly and the forehead, between the right and the left, between the crown and the tailbone.

THE SIRR — THE SECRET

"And here we look to find the Sirr, the secret. It's never one thing or the other. It's no one part of a pair."

"It's the crux, it's the intersection, it's the whole, where ego and sage are two faces of one truth... where the physical planet is brought into an identity with the nameless and formless."

THE PERFECT NATURE (TABIYAT-I TAM)

"All of these dimensions come into symmetry in what is called the Tabiyat-i tam, the perfect nature."

"And by perfect, what is meant is whole, unmired, the entirety of being, leaving nothing out from the finite to the infinite and back again."

THE DIVINE SECRET

"It is in this that we are of the divine, for the divine, and so it is said, 'Al-insanu sirri wa ana sirrul insan.'"

"The human being is my secret, God says, and I am the secret of the human being. This secret is held at the crux, at the crossroads, at the center of it all, the Sirr."

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The Human Being as God's Secret

Source: CT10 · April 19, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

THE SIRR — WHERE OPPOSITES MEET

"Look for God where the opposites meet."

In the center of the pattern, between all poles, we find the Sirr — the secret. *"It's the crux, it's the intersection, it's the whole, where ego and sage are two faces of one truth… where the physical planet is brought into an identity with the nameless and formless."*

This is the Tabiyat-i tam, the perfect nature — whole and unmired, *"leaving nothing out from the finite to the infinite and back again."*

THE HOLY SAYING

"It is in this that we are of the divine, for the divine, and so it is said, 'Al-insanu sirri wa ana sirrul insan.' The human being is my secret, God says, and I am the secret of the human being."

"This secret is held at the crux, at the crossroads, at the center of it all, the Sirr."

A PRACTICE: THE INTERFACE OF HEAVEN AND EARTH

"And here it is that we may say that heaven and earth interface. And so in the Sirr, we breathe…"

1. Inhale: *"Let the heavens be reflected in the earth."*
2. Exhale: *"Let the earth may turn into heaven."*

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Part II · Chapter 6

GUIDED VISUALIZATIONS & MOVEMENT

Inner Images and Sacred Gestures

The imagination is a wing of the soul. Guided journeys to the Garden of the Heart, visualizations of light and lineage, and the gestures that accompany prayer: each uses image or movement as a doorway into the interior.

5 Entries · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

Evocative Imagery for Contemplating the Ruh

Source: CT7 · April 18, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

In our practice with the Lataif, as we direct our awareness to the Ruh, the subtle center in the right side of the chest, it's helpful to consider its inherent qualities of celestial grace and subtle essence. Sometimes, an evocation of such grace and subtlety through vivid imagery can effectively orient us to what resides there. Pir Zia suggests, *"I envision a swan gliding. Or the crescent of the moon, a lake shimmering at night under the moon. A gossamer elegance. Or you might think of entering a crystal cavern or moving in a landscape of ice and snow."* These powerful images are not meant to be clung to, but rather serve to conjure a distinct sensibility. Once this subtle character of the Ruh's light is perceived, a deeper experience unfolds where this light transforms into the very substance of our vision, allowing us to see *by* it, not just *it*.

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The Bridge Between Earth and Eternity

Source: CT8 · April 18, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

The final polarity in the Lataif system is between the root and the crown.

"And then there's one more polarity. And that is between the the root in the tailbone and the crown at the top of the head."

These are not different places, but different modes of perceiving the same reality. *"When we go through these doors of the Lataif, we're not going to different places. It's all the same place, just perceived differently."*

THE TWO POLES

The Root — the Latifa Qalabiyya at the tailbone. This is our connection to the earth, our *"crude creaturehood."*

"There's a taproot that runs right down to the center of the planet. And one can hardly imagine how marvelous is the domain beneath the earth's crust, the mineral and metallic and crystalline and magmic worlds underground leading to the planetary core. All of this is the foundation of the tailbone."

The Crown — the Latifa Akhfaiyya at the top of the head.

"Akhfa is most hidden, superlative, profoundly hidden. Why is it hidden? Because it transcends physical sensation... It's the same reality, but experienced in its transcendence, experienced beyond the frame of time and space."

THE HUMAN ALIF

We stand between these two poles, embodying the vertical axis that connects them.

"We find ourselves as an alif, its lower extremity rooted in the solidity of the earth, its upper pole lost in eternity. And the spine is the vertical bridge between these two contraries."

This is the ladder of Jacob, which exists within each of us. *"Jacob, peace be upon him, discovered this when he ascended and descended along the the ladder that was shown to him... this ladder has been given to all of us, the ladder between the tailbone and the crown."*

OUR BIRTHRIGHT TO MIGRATE

It is our purpose to move freely along this inner axis, experiencing both the immanent and the transcendent.

"There are many ways to experience this movement toward transcendence. And there are many ways to experience the contrary movement toward incarnation."

"To be able to move back and forth between transcendence and immanence, between the crystalline planet and the… beyond the beyond, the ocean beyond the ocean… the stark mystery in the face of which even the deepest blackness pales, to be able to migrate, to move to and fro, this is our this is our birthright."

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The Hidden and Most Hidden: Khafi and Akhfa

Source: CT8 · April 18, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

At the crown of the head is the Latifa Akhfaiyya. It shares an etymology with the Latifa Khafi in the forehead, revealing a gradation of subtlety.

"Khafi in the forehead is hidden, and Akhfa is most hidden, superlative, profoundly hidden."

WHY IT IS MOST HIDDEN

The reason this center is considered *"most hidden"* is that it lies beyond our primary mode of knowing.

"Why is it hidden? Because it transcends physical sensation, and we mostly know life through our senses."

"It doesn't mean it's far away or unrelated to us or irrelevant. It's profoundly present, but it's not different from the manifest. It's the same reality, but experienced in its transcendence, experienced beyond the frame of time and space."

THE SAME PLACE, PERCEIVED DIFFERENTLY

Accessing this center is not a matter of going to a different place, but of perceiving the same reality in a different way.

"We have to remember that these aren't, when we go through these doors of the Lataif, we're not going to different places. It's

all the same place, just perceived differently. And in the degree of Akhfa, it's perceived without any temporal container."

"So it's natural that we associate transcendence with the heavens because in our direct experience, the earth under our feet is solid and opaque, whereas the sky is translucent and the night sky is evidently infinite."

THE ALIF OF BEING

This polarity between the earthly and the transcendent is bridged by our own being.

"So we find ourselves as an alif, its lower extremity rooted in the solidity of the earth, its upper pole lost in eternity. And the spine is the vertical bridge between these two contraries."

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The Tasawwul Zikr Practice on Jacob's Ladder

Source: CT8 · April 18, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

THE LADDER WITHIN

"The spine is the vertical bridge between these two contraries... this ladder has been given to all of us, the ladder between the tailbone and the crown."

"To be able to migrate, to move to and fro, this is our this is our birthright."

THE TASAWWUL PRACTICE

"We're moving on this ladder when we say the syllables of the Tasawwul practice."

1. Start with the *"Ha,"* which moves up from the tailbone to the chest.
2. Then go into the *"Hu,"* which is from the chest up to the forehead.

3. Say this a few times: *"Ha. Hu. Ha. Hu. Ha. Hu."*

THE TWO POLES OF BEING

"Tailbone is rooted in the center of the earth. Crown is open to the infinite."

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Guided Meditation: The Clair de Lune Vignette

Source: CT8 · April 18, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

Through contemplation, we can enter visionary landscapes and reorient our sense of self within the field of consciousness. I invite you to close your eyes and imagine this scene, offered to us by my father: *"Imagine that you are wandering leisurely alongside a tranquil lake. So relieved to have escaped from the humdrum turmoil of life in our modern societies. The atmosphere is windless, nebulous, sedate, and eerie under the diaphanous glow of the full moon."* This visionary landscape offers a refuge from the 'humdrum turmoil,' allowing for a reorientation of perception. By engaging in such contemplations, we discover the mind's vast capacity to encompass the world and find inner quiescence, a key to accessing profound states of being.

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Part II · Chapter 7

TEACHINGS & WISDOM

The Living Commentary of the Path

Alongside the practices, Pir Zia offered teachings — framings, commentaries, and rules of the Suluk — that illuminate the inner landscape. These are the lamps set along the path.

10 Entries · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

The Meeting of Seeker and Lineage

Source: CT7 · April 18, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

In this universe, there are divine inheritances meant for our souls, knowledge that is already our own but only truly reaches us when the time is right, when we are ready to receive and use it. The teachings on the Lataif, for example, are like this: they are limbs and organs of our own subtle bodies, inherently ours. Yet, in a world where so much of our true nature is veiled and forgotten, the introduction to them comes when we are truly prepared. Indeed, *"And readiness comes when the seeker's motivation and dedication is clear, and when the lineage of those who came before is ready to meet the seeker in that intention. And there's a mutual joy in the in the meeting and in the transmission."* This sacred exchange highlights a reciprocal dynamic; the sincerity of the seeker awakens the ancestral wisdom, culminating in a joyful, profound connection that unveils our deepest being.

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Integrating the Gross and the Subtle

Source: CT7 · April 18, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

Having journeyed into the subtle dimensions of our being through the Lataif, our practice now calls for a conscious integration of this expanded awareness with our physical reality. We seek to hold both simultaneously, without one eclipsing the other. *"And bring your awareness back to the physical solidity of your body, which doesn't require forgetting the subtle dimension. Let's see if we can maintain awareness of both, the gross and the subtle."* This integration is crucial for the full unfoldment of our divinely appointed nature, activating what is

already our own. By embracing both the tangible and the intangible, our capacity for love deepens, allowing our senses to become channels for divine perception and bringing the sacred into every moment of our lived experience.

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Hearing the Divine Voice in Urban Sounds

Source: CT7 · April 18, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

Learning the art of deep listening allows us to transcend mere surface perception and uncover the sacred melodies within all sound. While we may readily find God's voice in the planetary symphony of nature, we are called to discover it even in the less obvious acoustic environments of our daily lives, like cities. The sounds of urban and industrial life may not initially seem conducive to this connection. *"However, even these sounds turn out to belong to a certain kind of music which communicates the divine voice. And partly it requires us to move beyond our habitual agitation and frustration and impatience and really sink into the sound waves themselves as an oceanic field."* This practice transforms our ordinary hearing into a divine audition, moving beyond personal expectation to perceive the underlying emotion and intention of the Creator, making our individual listening a conduit for God's endless presence.

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Allah Perceives Vision

Source: CT7 · April 18, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

The divine names are not merely abstract concepts, but living truths that shape our perception and experience. As we delve

into the name Al-Basir, the Seer, we are invited to consider vision not just as a physical faculty, but as a spiritual conduit. *"The Quran says regarding Allah, vision doesn't perceive Allah. Allah perceives vision. So we're aware of our glance as a conduit for the divine glance. Even as we look for God, God is looking out through these searching eyes."* Recognizing this, our act of seeing is transformed; it transcends our limited individual self and is illuminated by the universal divine sight. This realization allows us to perceive with greater depth, uncovering the mystery and infinite depth in all that we behold.

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The Universe as Overlapping Perceptions

Source: CT8 · April 18, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

We often conceive of ourselves as bounded individuals in a vast external world, with our minds situated inside our bodies. However, a deeper contemplation reveals that the mind is not smaller than the body, but rather encompasses it, pervading all that is perceived. This encourages a profound reorientation in our understanding of reality. *"This universe is made of the overlapping perceptions of all perceiving beings, all of which are waves of the perception of the one ultimate perceiver. This realization takes us beyond the reductionism of our ordinary positing of a subject confronting an object."* In this unified perspective, subject and object seamlessly participate in all that is perceived. As we delve into contemplation, we increasingly identify with consciousness itself and the boundless reality it encompasses.

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The Experience of Transcendence and Immanence

Source: CT8 · April 18, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

Our being functions as a vertical bridge, connecting the earth's rootedness at the tailbone to the infinite openness of the crown, allowing us to migrate between the profound states of transcendence and immanence. We find ourselves moving between these two poles as we experience existence. *"As you feel yourself energetically rising, you're moving toward selflessness… Sometimes it comes across as something like a a deluge, like the flood of Noah, sweeping everything away… And there are many ways to experience the contrary movement toward incarnation. It can feel like the exhalation of a breath that has been long held."* This birthright enables us to traverse the continuum from the stark mystery of the beyond to the rich manifestation of our embodied reality.

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Our Birthright to Migrate Between Worlds

Source: CT8 · April 18, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

The wisdom tradition offers us the understanding that a ladder exists within our very being, connecting our deep earthly roots to the infinite cosmos. This realization allows us to experience the profound expansiveness of our consciousness, unbounded by ordinary perception. As we learn to activate the different energetic centers, we discover the innate capacity to traverse these realms. As Pir Zia teaches, *"And to be able to move back and forth between transcendence and immanence, between the crystalline planet and the water al-wara, the beyond the beyond… to be able to migrate, to move to and fro, this is our*

this is our birthright." This profound realization frees us from the illusion of limitation, inviting us to consciously navigate the full spectrum of our existence and expand our awareness.

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Prayer Realizes the Future in the Present

Source: CT9 · April 19, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

As we reflect on the nature of prayer, we discover that it is not primarily about asking for something that is currently missing, but rather about an intentional recognition of what is eternally present. Indeed, *"Whenever we lift up our hands and ask for blessings, in the act of asking, we are turning our attention to the blessing that is already here for us. The imagined future is realized in the prayerful present."* This teaching reveals that prayer is fundamentally an act of awakening to the divine reality that continuously surrounds us. By consciously directing our attention to the blessings we aspire to, we empower their manifestation, transforming our future hopes into a vibrant, lived experience in the present moment. Our sincere focus now brings the desired good into being.

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Navigating Reactivity and Emotional Wounds

Source: CT9 · April 19, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

Friends, as we endeavor to live a purposeful life, we inevitably face situations that test our inner resilience. Beyond general hardships, we often encounter individuals whose actions or words inadvertently—or even purposefully—touch upon our

deepest emotional wounds. This makes a mindful response incredibly difficult, as our immediate inclination is often to defend or strike back. It is precisely *"when we're not only challenged by complex situations, but we're specifically challenged by someone who is pressing on that vulnerability, well then the tendency is to react very unpurposefully, very reactively, with intense emotion and often without much insight."* Such moments threaten to derail our spiritual progress, pulling us into a spiraling confrontation. Therefore, cultivating the practice of pausing and breathing becomes crucial, allowing us to rise above reactive patterns and seek a divinely guided, more insightful course of action.

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The Two Lessons from the Hermit's Fall

Source: CT9 · April 19, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

The tale of the hermit and the sinner leaves us with two enduring lessons.

FIRST -- DIVINE FORGIVENESS HAS NO CUTOFF

Sincere turning is always received. It is never too late. Divine mercy meets any soul that reaches for it, no matter how far it has strayed.

SECOND -- PIETY IS WORTHLESS WHEN ARROGANCE IS THE YIELD

"The story also tells us that all manner of piety and and worship and abstemiousness and fasts and every kind of religious virtue counts as nothing when arrogance is the yield."

This is the sharper edge of the teaching. Outward observance -- fasts, prayers, asceticism -- counts for nothing the moment it becomes a pedestal from which to look down on others.

“Arrogance is a great danger in our lives and we're reminded to put yourself on a high pedestal is to prepare yourself for a fall. Stay close to the earth.”

Humility is not an accessory to the spiritual life. It is the ground the spiritual life grows in.

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Part II · Chapter 8

STORIES, PARABLES & POETRY

The Wisdom That Travels in Images

Some truths refuse to be said plainly. They must be told as story, sung as poetry, enacted as parable. This chapter preserves the tales and verses that illuminated the retreat.

1 Entries · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

The Hermit and the Sinner: The Jamali Version

Source: CT9 · April 19, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

The gentle (Jamali) version of the hermit-and-sinner tale, the companion to the Jalali telling.

THE JAMALI REVELATION

Where the Jalali version decisively separates the hermit from the sinner, the Jamali version opens a door for both:

"And the Jamali version is that Jesus says, 'On this day, you both begin again. You, hermit, all of your prayers have been erased, and you must start afresh. And you, sinner, all of your sins are erased, and you too begin anew.'"

THE TEACHING

In the Jamali reading, divine grace is boundless and always available for a fresh start. Spiritual merits are annulled when contaminated by pride -- but so are sins when met with sincere turning.

The same story, read through Jamal rather than Jalal, becomes a teaching on divine forgiveness: it is never too late to begin again, and the ledger of piety is not the ledger that matters.

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Part II · Chapter 9

DEEP STUDY & SACRED TERMS

Keys to the Arabic Lexicon of the Path

Certain words carry the whole teaching folded into a syllable — tawhid, mushahada, fana, baqa. Here the sacred vocabulary of contemplation is unfolded, each term a key to a chamber of meaning.

1 Entries · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

A Synchronicity of the Name Al-Kalim

Source: CT9 · April 19, 2026 · Pir Zia Inayat-Khan

As we approach the seventh of the seven leading divine names, Al-Kalim, it is remarkable how the universe sometimes offers direct affirmations of the path we walk. Just recently, such a sign presented itself in a most personal way: *"How interesting, just today, um, I had a guest here at Fazl Manzil named Sayyid Kalim, Sayyid Kalim Nizami. His arrival is a synchronicity and a sign of this name now entering our caravan."* Kalim means *"the speaker,"* and it is noteworthy that Prophet Moses, known as Kalimullah or *"the speaker with God,"* was said to have had a speech impediment. This reminds us that divine guidance can utilize instruments that may seem unsuited for a purpose. Perhaps our very limitations and imperfections can lend themselves to a higher purpose, becoming vessels for divine speech. Embracing Al-Kalim, therefore, means recognizing the divine utterance in every form, including our own unique and often flawed expressions.

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Appendix A

CLASS SCHEDULE

Contemplation Section I comprised 10 sessions taught by Pir Zia Inayat-Khan across two retreat weekends. The Spring Retreat (CT1–CT6) was held March 27–29, 2026; the Easter Retreat (CT7–CT10) followed on April 18–19, 2026.

Session	Date	Instructor	Part
CT1	2026-03-27	Pir Zia Inayat-Khan	I
CT2	2026-03-27	Pir Zia Inayat-Khan	I
CT3	2026-03-28	Pir Zia Inayat-Khan	I
CT4	2026-03-28	Pir Zia Inayat-Khan	I
CT5	2026-03-29	Pir Zia Inayat-Khan	I
CT6	2026-03-29	Pir Zia Inayat-Khan	I
CT7	2026-04-18	Pir Zia Inayat-Khan	II
CT8	2026-04-18	Pir Zia Inayat-Khan	II
CT9	2026-04-19	Pir Zia Inayat-Khan	II
CT10	2026-04-19	Pir Zia Inayat-Khan	II

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Appendix B

COLOPHON

The Book of Contemplation — Mount Qaf Companion Handbook

First Edition — April 2026

Retreat Sections with Topic Sub-chapters

Compiled from 226 teachings extracted from the transcripts of

10 Contemplation sessions, Suluk Global Online Program 2025–2027

Part I: The Spring Retreat — 149 teachings
Part II: The Easter Retreat — 77 teachings
Instructor: Pir Zia Inayat-Khan · CT1–CT10

Kabir · Class of Mount Qaf
Pod Mentor: Farzana · Inayatiyya

This handbook is for personal spiritual use. The teachings belong to the Inayatiyya lineage and are shared here as a student's learning companion.

The knowledge is held. The path continues.